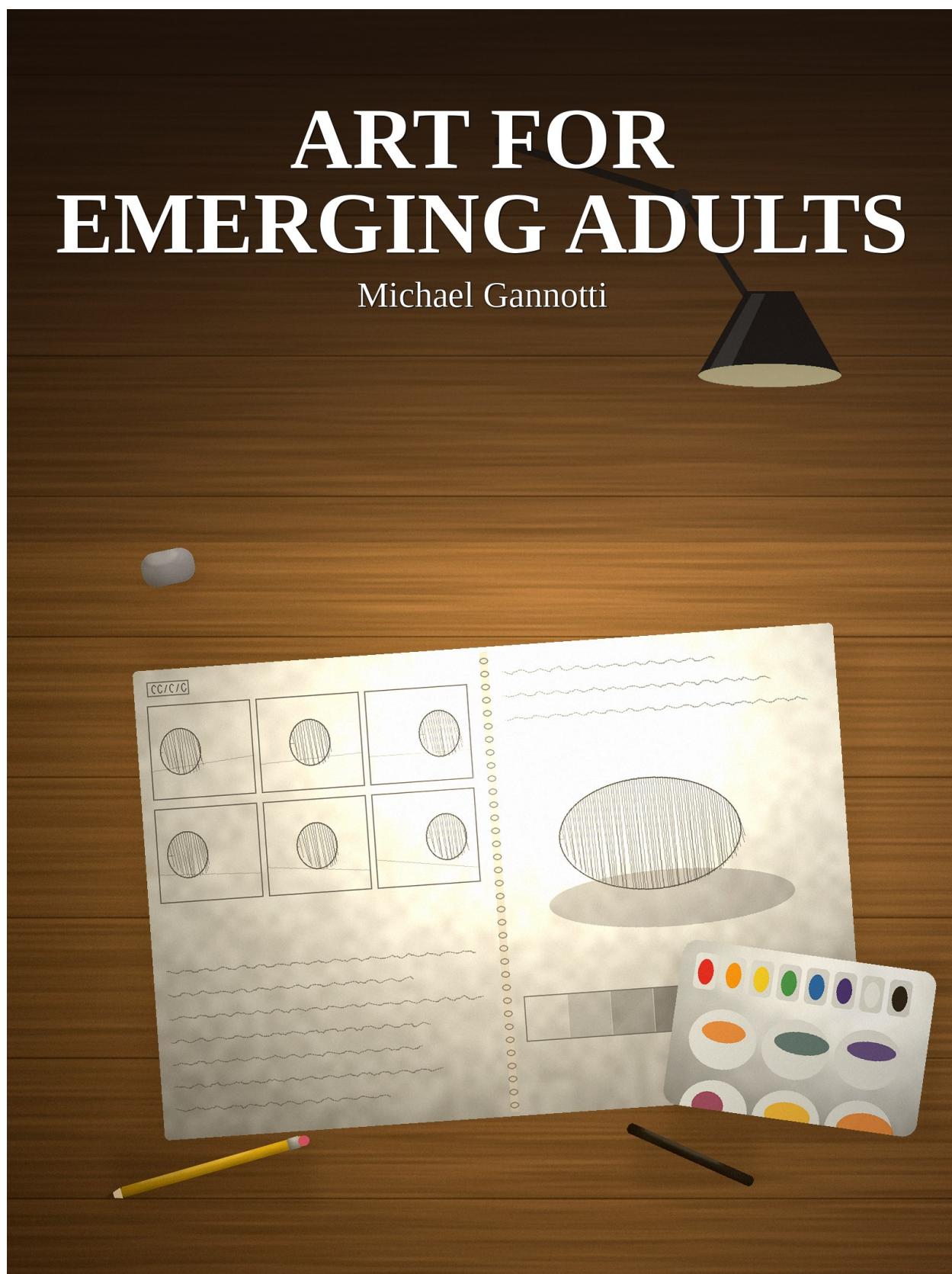


ART FOR EMERGING ADULTS

Michael Gannotti



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A homeschool teaching manual for ages 15–18. Illustrated teaching-manual edition, 28 September 2026. Notes run in one series at the back. Chapter-opening images are original still-lives, not portraits of people.

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Welcome

You do not need to be an artist to mentor a fifteen- to eighteen-year-old through a real year of art.

You need to protect the time, set up a safe corner, ask good questions, find outside eyes, and keep honest records. Your student does the looking and the making, and more and more, the leading.

That is what this book is for.

A Thursday, for example

It is a little after two in the afternoon. A small mirror is clamped to the edge of a table by the window, and a desk lamp is angled so that one side of the mirror's reflection is in light and the other in shadow. A sixteen-year-old has been working on a self-portrait for forty minutes. The board is propped against the table edge. A pencil is held out at arm's length, one eye closed, measuring.

Her mother comes in with a mug of tea, sets it on the shelf by the door (nothing to eat or drink at the art table; that rule has been in the house for a year now), and asks one question: "Where are you looking hardest?"

The student doesn't look up. "The shadow under my cheekbone. I thought it was one shape. It's three."

Her mother nods, says, "Good. I'll leave you to it," and leaves.

That is most of the job. An hour later there is a dated drawing, a phone photo of it in the family archive, a line in the hour log (*Thurs, 55 min, self-portrait session 2*), and a note in the sketchbook margin: *three shadow shapes — the middle one is the lightest*. Nobody said the drawing was good or bad. The student will decide that for herself, later, with reasons.

(That Thursday is a composite, drawn from common situations. It is not a real family. You will meet a few more like it in this book, and each one is labelled.)

The student you actually have

Fifteen to eighteen is a remarkable age for art, and a demanding one.

Your student can do real work. Many can render some things convincingly and hold a piece across several sessions. They can use adult materials under clear rules. They can run a critique, write

about their own work, and plan a week.

They are also hard on themselves. A student who can draw a convincing eye can see exactly what is wrong with the other one. Their taste often runs ahead of their hand: they love work they cannot yet make, and the gap can feel like a verdict. They want a voice of their own, sometimes before they have had the chance to find out what they care about.

Their time is pulled in many directions: a job, driving lessons, heavier academic courses, friends. And their work has audiences everywhere: friends, social feeds, contest judges, admissions readers, AP scorers. Each wants something slightly different.

None of this is a problem to fix. The self-criticism means they can see. The taste means they know where they want to go. The wish for a voice is the start of a real body of work, if it can be turned into a question and pursued across many pieces instead of a style chosen on the first day.

At this age the question is less *can you draw?* and more *what will you choose to look at, and will you stay with it?* This book is built around that question.

Why this matters now

In the 2016 national survey of homeschooling families, art was being taught to 78 percent of home-schooled students in the earliest grades and to fewer than a third (29 percent) of homeschooled high schoolers.¹ The survey does not say why. It does suggest that high school is where art most often slips off the week.

It is also the age when art can count most. A year of honest studio work can become a high-school credit with a plain title, a portfolio for college or art school if your student wants one, and, more lasting than either, a habit of looking and making that goes with them into adult life.

What a good week looks like

A good week of art at this age is not heroic. On Monday your student writes a short plan and you initial it. Two or three times that week they chair an Art Hour of about an hour: a few minutes of silent looking, ten minutes of thumbnails, a long stretch of making, a short critique they run, and a few minutes of filing. Every day, Hour or not, there is a dated sketchbook page of ten to fifteen minutes. Somewhere in the week there is studio time they chose for themselves. Every week or two there is an outing: a museum with one question, a gallery, a park bench, a community class. On Friday there is a five-minute File: what happened, the hours, one next step.

That is it. Some weeks will be thinner, because of exams, a job, a family week away. A thin week with a daily page in it still counts. The habit is the thing, and the habit is small enough to survive a busy house.

What you actually do

Your jobs are ones you can do well starting this week:

- **Protect the time.** Two or three Art Hours a week, a short daily sketchbook page, and some open studio time.
- **Set up the studio safely.** A corner with light, moving air, and a place for everything. The rules are in The Art Hour, stated once.
- **Ask good questions.** Each chapter gives you the exact words. Then you wait.
- **Find outside eyes.** A community class, a co-op critique, a portfolio review, a working artist who will talk for half an hour. When your student outgrows what you can show them, that is good news.
- **Keep honest records.** Hours, dates, photos of finished work, a course title a stranger can read.

None of these jobs needs you to draw well. All of them need you to show up, and the student notices when you do.

You may also learn alongside. A parent who keeps a cheap sketchbook of their own, and doesn't show it off, teaches more about practice than any speech.

The focus of the whole book

See long before you judge; sketch before you polish; sign only what you made.

See long before you judge means staying with a hard drawing, a strange contemporary painting, or your own portfolio long enough to find evidence before deciding anything.

Sketch before you polish means thumbnails, studies, and honest ugly middles come before the resolved piece. They are the work, not the warm-up.

Sign only what you made means authorship. Your student discloses tools, references, and help; credits every source; and puts their name only on marks and choices that are theirs.

If you used *Art for Young Minds* with this student a few years ago, you will recognize the first two clauses. The third arrives now because at fifteen to eighteen the work starts going out into the world with a name on it.

Two readers at once

Most of this book talks to you, the parent, as co-teacher and mentor. Each teaching chapter also has a section headed **For the student**, written directly to your fifteen- to eighteen-year-old. Hand it over. It is short, it is written for someone nearly grown, and it is meant to be used without you in the room.

What this book will not do

It will not hand you a 180-day plan. You get a week the student plans, a pacing sketch for the year, and the judgment to choose.

It will not sell you a curriculum or rank programs. The resources chapter describes options by fit and starts with what is free.

It will not promise admission to any school, an AP score, a scholarship, or a prize.

It will not tell you art makes students smarter at reading or math. The large reviews of that question found no good evidence that it does.^{2,3} Art is worth teaching for what art teaches: close looking, sustained work on hard problems, decisions you can explain, and the ability to talk honestly about a made thing.

It is not a rehash of the earlier books. *Art for Little Thinkers* (ages 5–10) and *Art for Young Minds* (ages 11–14) come before this one on the WisdomForge Art Hour ladder; *Art for Homeschooling* gives a grades 1–12 overview. This book teaches fifteen to eighteen, in depth.

It will never treat a generated image as your student’s work, or a model-written statement as their words.

It uses no nude figure references. People in this book are drawn clothed, with their consent.

It will not put a brand on the transcript. There is no course called “Emerging Adults Art I.” Chapter 9 gives you titles a stranger can read.

Encouragement that is specific

This week, you can learn to ask one question, “Where are you looking hardest?”, and leave the room.

Today, your student can date a sketchbook page and draw one thing in front of them for fifteen minutes.

That is enough to begin.

— Michael Gannotti

How to use this book

Read *The Art Hour* together. It takes about half an hour, and it holds the session shape, the week the student plans, the talk-box shape, the safety spine, and the AI rules that every later chapter points back to. Then you read the parent sections of Chapter 1, and your student reads Chapter 1's section **For the student**. Then start.

That is the whole on-ramp. You do not need to read the book cover to cover, and you do not need to shop first. A sketchbook, a few pencils, a pen, a lamp, and whatever is on the kitchen table will carry the first two weeks.

This week's shape

1. **Monday: the student writes the plan.** One line per session on a card or the inside cover of the sketchbook. You read it and initial it. In the first month at 15–16, you write it together.
2. **Two or three Art Hours**, about 45–60 minutes each, chaired by your student using the five beats in *The Art Hour*.
3. **The daily page**, 10–15 minutes, every day, Hour or not.
4. **Studio time** as your student chooses, on the current piece.
5. **One out-of-home try-it every week or two:** a museum with a question, a gallery, a park, a community class.
6. **Friday File:** what happened, the hours, one next step. Five minutes. You initial it.

Here is one real-looking week. Treat it as a sample, not an assignment.

Day	What happens
Monday	Student writes the plan; Art Hour: daily page started, blind contour of the hand, baseline check
Tuesday	Daily page
Wednesday	Art Hour: a student-chaired look at one real painting; nine thumbnails for a still life
Thursday	Daily page; 40 minutes of studio time on the still life
Friday	Art Hour: the still life continued; Friday File and hour log

Day	What happens
Saturday	Museum or gallery visit with one question, if the week allows
Sunday	Daily page

Most chapters take three to six weeks. Some take longer, and that is fine.

Placement: skill and independence, not birthday

Inside every teaching chapter you will see two planning bands: **15–16** and **17–18**.

The 15–16 moves assume you are in the room when a new tool or material appears, a range of media rather than depth in one, student-led critique with a simple question card, and short written statements. The 17–18 moves assume longer independent studio blocks, a sustained investigation (one question pursued across many works), a more formal critique the student chairs, writing to real limits, outside venues you have checked, and, if your family chooses, solvent-free oil painting.

Use the bands as a guide, not a lock. A fifteen-year-old with four years of serious drawing behind them may work in the 17–18 moves. An eighteen-year-old starting art in senior year begins with the 15–16 moves, and there is nothing lost by it. Nobody in this book is “behind.” A “grade 11 art” book is a publisher’s scope, not a legal level.

How a teaching chapter is built

Every teaching chapter uses the same eight headings in the same order, so you always know where to look.

- **Why this matters:** one page on what this unlocks.
- **For the parent: understand it yourself:** the idea in plain words, an everyday picture and a precise one, the wrong answers you should learn to hear, and a short warm-up for you alone.
- **How to teach it this week:** the first try-it, exact wording, how to fade your help, when to stop talking, and the band moves.
- **Practice that actually builds learning:** named try-its in the home and outside it, the chapter’s talk box, and one incorrect example to diagnose together.
- **For the student:** a page or two written to your student.
- **If it isn’t clicking:** common snags and the next move for each.
- **Tools, including AI:** short, pointing back to The Art Hour.
- **What “done enough” looks like:** a checklist before you move on.

In order, or by need

The order is a good default: the habit and the studio first, then drawing from life, painting, photography and digital work, art history, critique and statements, and the portfolio.

Bend it where your student needs it. A student aiming at art school should reach Chapter 3 (drawing from life) early, because observation work takes months to build. Chapter 6 (art history and contemporary art) can thread through the whole year. The monthly progress checks in Chapter 8 start in the first month, even though the chapter sits near the end. And read Chapter 9 (records and credit) before the first semester ends, so the hours are logged from day one rather than reconstructed in May.

A year with this book (a sketch, not a schedule)

Months	Focus	Running alongside
September	Chapters 1–2: the habit and the studio	Daily page; baseline check
October–November	Chapter 3: drawing from life	A park or museum sketching trip
December–January	Chapter 4: painting	Monthly progress checks
February–March	Chapter 5: photography, digital art, and design	A photo walk; a real client
April	Chapter 6: art history and contemporary art (or all year)	A gallery visit
May	Chapter 7: critique and the artist statement	An outside critique
All year	Chapters 8 and 9: portfolio checks and the hour log	Friday File

A first year like this comes to about 120 logged hours, the usual size of one elective credit. A second year goes deeper in two chapters your student chooses. A senior portfolio year builds a sustained investigation from September.

The banks are a menu

The try-its in this book come from 102 named activities, grouped into banks: sketchbook, observation, figure, painting, color, design, digital, photography, history, contemporary art, critique, writing, portfolio, assessment, credit, outings, and safety. Each has a short code, listed in the notes, so a later chapter can point back to it.

A chapter picks one or two try-its a week from its banks. Nobody does all 102 in a year, and nobody should try.

Two ages, or two bands, at one table

If a younger sibling is using *Art for Little Thinkers* or *Art for Young Minds*, your teenager can lead one of that child's activities now and then. The teen learns by explaining; you get a breather.

Two teenagers in different bands can share the See and Critique beats and the museum trips. They split for Make, and they keep separate plans and separate records.

Students who need a different door

This book gives practical moves, not diagnoses. For anything more, talk with your student's own professionals.

- **Hand or motor challenges:** larger tools, digital drawing, photography, collage from their own photographs. The seeing and the ideas are the art.
- **Visual impairment:** high-contrast media, tactile work such as clay at a community studio, and audio description at museums. Ask local services what they offer.
- **Attention differences:** shorter Make blocks, a timer, one project at a time, and the daily page as the anchor.
- **Anxiety about judgment:** a private sketchbook, always. Critique of other people's work before their own. Your student asks their question first.
- **Advanced students:** outside eyes early: a community class, a dual-enrollment course, a portfolio day. A sustained investigation can start at fifteen.

If you don't draw

Good. You are well placed for this job.

A parent who draws beautifully is sometimes tempted to fix the page. A parent who doesn't is more likely to ask a question and wait, which is what this book asks. Your warm-ups are private. Nobody grades them. When your student's skill passes what you can show them (it may happen fast), you stay on as the person who protects the time, keeps the studio safe, finds the next teacher, and keeps the records.

Finding outside eyes

Sooner or later, your student needs someone who is not family to look at the work. That is not a comment on you; it is how artists grow at every age. Outside eyes can be a community studio class, a co-op critique, a sketch group that meets in a library, a college course taken as dual enrollment, a portfolio review day, or a local artist who agrees to a half-hour conversation. Chapter 10 has a checklist for judging fit: the instructor, the age rules, how materials are handled, and the figure-model policy. You arrange it; your student prepares their questions.

What to skip for now

Skip the big shopping trip until a few Art Hours have run with what is already in the house. Skip any AI tool until you have read the box in The Art Hour. Skip oils entirely at 15–16, and at 17–18

until the rag rule is a habit. Skip any chapter you are not ready for this month. The map is a path, not a race.

Records from day one

Keep a weekly hour log from the first week: Art Hours, daily pages, studio time, outings, classes. Photograph finished work the day it's done. Keep every sketchbook. When the year ends, the course gets a plain title: Art I for a first general year, or a medium title such as Drawing or Photography if most of the hours went there.^{4,5} Never a brand, never "Art Hour," never "AP" unless the course has been authorized through the College Board's AP Course Audit. Chapter 9 covers it all.

If you only remember five things

Keep this page where the week gets planned. When things feel scattered, come back here before you add anything new.

1. See long before you judge

Look, measure, describe, and then decide. That order works on a mug, a contemporary installation, and your student's own portfolio. When your student says "it's bad," the next move is a question about evidence: *Where did you look longest? What's actually there?* Judgment is welcome. It comes last, with reasons.

The word *long* matters at this age. Ten minutes with a painting your student dislikes, or a second session with a drawing they want to throw away, usually changes the verdict, and sometimes it doesn't. Either way, the verdict now has evidence behind it.

2. Sketch before you polish

The sketchbook is where the work happens. Thumbnails, studies, and ugly pages are licensed, and expected. Decisions are cheap on a two-inch thumbnail and expensive on good paper. The sketchbook is private by default: you check that pages happen, and you read the ones your student offers.

For a student who is sure their work must look finished to count, say it plainly: the portfolio is chosen later, from the archive. The sketchbook is for thinking.

3. Draw from life, with consent

Objects, places, the student's own hands, the student in a mirror, family members who say yes. Clothed models only. Ask first, allow a stop, show the drawing before sharing it. Art schools ask for work from direct observation, and there is no shortcut to it.

Most drawing trouble is still seeing trouble at seventeen. Measuring (holding a pencil at arm's length to compare sizes and angles) is how artists see, not a way around seeing.

4. Adult tools, stated rules

Read the label before anything opens. Move the air and keep food out. Blades with a mat, a metal ruler, and a glove. No solvents at home; oils only at 17–18, only if your family chooses, and only solvent-free. Sprays outside, never indoors. Darkrooms, kilns, and presses belong to community studios. The full spine is in The Art Hour.

Teach each rule before the material comes out, and have your student show it back to you. At 17–18, the student can write the studio rules card and post it. Rules a teenager wrote get kept.

5. Sign only what you made

Disclose tools, references, and help on every piece that might leave the house. A generated image is not your student's mark. A model-written statement is not their words. Log the hours and name the course plainly.

This is not suspicion. It is how working artists, AP readers, and admissions offices already expect work to be presented. A student who fills in a whose-mark card every Friday will find the portfolio forms familiar when they arrive.

Those five are the book in miniature. The session shape, the safety spine, and the AI rules live once, in The Art Hour.

The Art Hour



About 45 to 60 minutes. Five beats. Your student chairs it. A dated page and a line in the log at the end.

This is the session spine for the whole book. Later chapters say “run the Art Hour” and point back here, so the shape only has to be learned once. The week the student plans, the talk-box shape, the try-it shapes, the safety spine, and the AI rules also live here, once.

The shape follows what careful research found in serious high-school art rooms: a short demonstration, a long stretch of work time with the teacher checking in, and critique with the work up on the wall.⁶ You can run the second and third from the first day. The first you can borrow: a community

teacher, a short video watched together and paused, or a move your student has just learned and shows you.

Before the first Hour: the corner and the rules

You do not need a studio. You need a table that can stay a little messy, a light you can aim, a window that opens, and a shelf or bin where the art things live. Chapter 2 builds the full corner; for the first week, a sketchbook, a few pencils from hard to soft, a kneaded eraser, a fine black pen, a lamp, and three household objects are plenty.

Before any new material comes out, the label gets read, by your student, aloud, the first time. Before any blade comes out, your student shows you the cutting routine. That habit, *rule first, then the tool*, is the whole safety culture of this book, and it starts before anything risky is on the table.

Put your phone face down. Ask your student to do the same, or to put theirs in another room for the hour. A timer on the table works better than one on a screen.

The five beats

1. See (5 minutes)

Silent looking first. Your student sets the subject: the still life, the view, the painting, yesterday's page. Then they measure, squint, or list what's there. No verdicts yet, from anyone.

What the chair might say: "Five minutes. Just looking. List what's there." What you might add, passing through: "Where are you looking longest?"

2. Sketch (10 minutes)

Thumbnails (small, fast planning sketches, a couple of inches across), gesture drawings (fast drawings of a pose's movement), or quick studies for the current piece. Ugly is allowed. This is where decisions get made while they are still cheap.

3. Make (25–35 minutes)

The chapter's named try-it, or the current piece in a longer project. Your student holds the tool. If you demonstrate, keep it short and do it on scrap paper, then move the scrap aside so there is nothing to copy.

When your student is stuck and asks for help, use the **rescue order**:

1. **Ask.** "What are you trying to do right there?"
2. **Wait.** A real wait. Look at the subject, not at them.
3. **Hint.** "Measure it against the handle." "Where's the darkest dark?"
4. **Short demo on scrap.** Ten seconds, one move.
5. **Hand it back.** "Your turn."

That order keeps the skill and the dignity in the same hour. A parent's hand on the page, even a loving one, teaches that the parent is the real artist.

4. Critique (5–8 minutes)

The chapter's talk box, chaired by your student. At fifteen to eighteen, talking about work becomes a skill with its own methods, which is why this beat is called Critique rather than Talk.

At 15–16, the chair uses the three questions of Visual Thinking Strategies, a museum-education method: *What's going on here? What do you see that makes you say that? What more can we find?*⁷ At 17–18, the chair can run a version of Liz Lerman's Critical Response Process: responders say what was meaningful to them; the artist asks their own questions; responders ask neutral questions; and opinions come only when the responder asks permission and the artist says yes.⁸ The artist can say no. Chapter 7 teaches both in full.

5. File (3–5 minutes)

Date the page. Photograph anything finished or worth keeping. If the piece might become portfolio work, fill in a **whose-mark card**: what the student made by hand or by their own decisions; tools used, including edits; every reference, cited; any help, and from whom; any AI use (in this book, normally "none"); consent for any person shown; and a signature line: *I made the marks and choices described here*. Chapter 8 grows the card. Then log the minutes, clean up, and put materials away safely: rags where they go, blades in their container, wet work on its shelf.

Filing sounds like housekeeping. It is the habit that turns a year of Thursdays into a credit and a portfolio a stranger can read.

One hour, start to finish (an illustration)

Here is a 17–18 hour, so you can hear the whole shape once. It is a composite, not a real family.

See (5 minutes). Three eggs and a white bowl sit on a gray cloth under a single lamp. The seventeen-year-old sets a timer and lists in the margin: *cast shadows touch; bowl rim brighter than any egg; reflected light under the left egg*. Her father reads the plan card on the way through and keeps walking.

Sketch (10 minutes). Nine thumbnails, each changing one thing: crop, eye level, lamp position. She stars two and enlarges one.

Make (30 minutes). A value drawing on good paper. At minute twenty she calls out: the bowl looks flat. Her father comes back. "What are you trying to do there?" She says the inside should go darker. He waits. She squints, finds the darkest dark is inside the bowl at the far edge, and adds it. He never touched the paper.

Critique (7 minutes). She pins the drawing beside the setup and runs the process. "My question: does the bowl sit on the cloth or float?" Her father answers with what he sees. Then: "I have an opinion about the left egg. Would you like it?" "Not today." He leaves it. That is allowed.

File (4 minutes). Date, a photo of the drawing and one of the thumbnail page, a line in the log (*Wed, 56 min, egg-and-bowl value study*), the pencils back in the jar, the cloth folded. Fifty-six minutes. One honest page. A question for Friday.

A 15–16 hour, briefly

The same shape at fifteen looks a little different. You are in the room for more of it. The See beat might be the student reading a label aloud before a new watercolor set is opened. The Sketch beat is six thumbnails of a mug instead of nine. In Make, you sit at the other end of the table with your own sketchbook, not watching. In Critique, your student reads the three VTS questions off a card and you answer them about their painting, then they answer about yours. In File, they date the page, you initial the log, and the brushes are washed together. Forty-five minutes, and the student chaired every beat.

The daily page

Every day, Hour or not, your student does one sketchbook page: 10 to 15 minutes, dated, drawn from something in front of them, with one written line underneath. Stop at the timer.

The page is private by default. Teenagers are especially sensitive to being watched and evaluated,⁹ and a page no one else will judge is a page they will actually draw. You check that the page exists. You read it only when your student offers it. Your student's sketchbook has no followers. That's the point.

The daily page is the quiet engine of this book. It is the easiest thing to log, the richest evidence of process, and the habit most likely to outlast high school.

The week the student plans

At this age the student plans the week and you initial it. There is no 180-day script. There is this:

- **Monday plan:** one line per session. “Mon: Hour, nine thumbnails and still life start. Wed: Hour, still life values. Thu: studio 40 min. Fri: Hour, finish, critique, File. Sat: museum, one question.”
- **Every day:** the daily page.
- **Two or three Art Hours,** and studio time as the student chooses.
- **Every week or two:** one out-of-home try-it.
- **Friday File:** what happened, the hours, and one next step. You initial it.
- **Monthly:** a progress check (Chapter 8), a wall critique (Chapter 7), and a sketchbook review (Chapter 2).

In the first month at 15–16, write the Monday plan together. After that, ask for it.

Bands inside the hour

15–16. Plan on 45–50 minutes. The student chairs, with you nearby. You are in the room whenever a new tool or material appears, and for any blade. Range across media matters more than depth in one. Critique uses the three VTS questions. Written statements are about 100 words. Any AI account is yours, and your student sits beside you.

17–18. Plan on 50–60 minutes, plus independent studio blocks. The student may run a sustained investigation: one question pursued across ten to fifteen works. Critique follows the Critical Response Process. Statements are written to real limits (AP fields, college portals). Solvent-free oils are an option if your family chooses. Outside venues are ones you have checked. Any AI account is parent-linked, and only where the service’s terms allow teens.

Move a student between bands by what they can show you, not by their birthday.

The talk-box shape (once for the book)

Every teaching chapter has a talk box. The shape never changes.

The opening question. Each chapter gives it word for word. It is a real question with no single right answer, and it points at the work, never at talent. At 17–18, your student may ask it themselves, of their own work or yours.

Three to five follow-ups. One for seeing or evidence (“What do you see that makes you say that?”). One for process (“Where did you get stuck?”). One for choice (“What did you rule out?”). One that lets them revise (“What would you try next?”).

How to wait. After asking, count a slow three in your head before saying anything. After they answer, wait again; the second answer is often the better one. The slow three is a classroom habit, not a finding from art research, and it works. If the silence feels heavy, look at the work, not at your student.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. Bracing for a verdict. A question that secretly asked for one (“Do you like it?”). Hunting for the “right” art word. An opinion of yours already hanging in the air. Or the piece feels too close to talk about today. “Not today” is an allowed answer. To get talk moving, describe something yourself, neutrally: “I notice the shadow reaches the edge of the cloth.”

One “don’t say / say instead” line. Each chapter gives you one. The pattern is always the same: trade a verdict for a way of checking.

Try-it shapes (once)

Every named try-it carries the same five fields:

- **Time:** a realistic estimate.
- **Materials:** what needs to be on the table.

- **Mess / safety:** plain and specific, pointing back to the safety spine below.
- **The pull:** why a teenager might actually want to do it.
- **The skill:** the seeing or making move being practiced.

In-home try-its use a table, a lamp, a window, a mirror, household objects, family members who agree to pose, and the student's own hands.

Out-of-home try-its carry the same fields plus the venue's rules. The ones that recur:

- **Museums.** Many allow pencils only in the galleries and limit sketchbook size or stools. Photography rules vary. Check the visitor rules before you go, and preview galleries if your family has standards about subject matter.
- **Galleries.** Ask before sketching in a small space. Read the statement after looking, not before.
- **Community studios and art centers.** Check the instructor, the age rules, the materials safety, and the figure-model policy before enrolling.
- **Public sketching.** People at a distance. No close-up studies of a stranger's face without asking, no photographs of strangers for portfolio work, and stop if anyone objects.
- **Portfolio days and reviews.** Bring the pieces, the sketchbook, and one question per piece.

People, consent, and privacy

Many students this age want to draw and photograph people. Good. This book's people are: the student in a mirror; the student's own hands and feet; family members and friends who agree to pose, clothed; people at a distance in public places; and works in museum collections. Clothed, consenting models only. The book uses no nude references, and no student is sent to an adult-only session. Studio and class age rules vary from venue to venue, so you check them before booking anything.¹⁰

The consent line is part of the craft: *"May I draw you for twenty minutes? You can say no or stop anytime, and I'll show you before I share it."* A photograph of a person needs their consent, and a signed release before it is entered in a contest or posted; for another minor, their parent signs.¹¹

Photograph the work, not the student. Crop to the edge of the paper. Keep faces, full names, school names, and location details out of anything shared, and turn off location tagging where the phone allows. Store the archive of finished work on a drive your family controls, with a backup. Photos of people, and especially of minors, stay off shared AI tools and shared cloud workspaces. Contest and admissions uploads are fine through the official portal. Posting is your student's choice as well as yours. A portfolio can be complete without ever going online.

The safety spine (once for the book)

Safety in this book is ordinary and non-negotiable. It is said once, here. Chapters 2, 4, and 5 point back and add only what their materials need.

1. **Read the label.** The Art and Creative Materials Institute (ACMI) puts an **AP** seal on products

labelled for students in sixth grade or younger, and a **CL** seal on products for seventh grade or older, whose label must be read in full before opening, with its cautions followed.¹² A line saying a product “conforms to ASTM D-4236” means it was reviewed and labelled for long-term hazards under federal labelling law. It is a labelling procedure, not a “non-toxic” stamp.¹³

2. **Move the air; keep food out.** A window open and a fan pulling air *out*. A fan that only stirs the room’s air around is not ventilation.¹³ No eating or drinking in the studio. Wash hands afterward.
3. **Blades.** A cutting mat, a metal ruler, fresh blades, cuts made away from the body, a cut-resistant (metal-mesh or Kevlar) glove on the holding hand, and used blades into a lidded container.¹³ At 15–16, you are present whenever a blade is out.
4. **No solvents at home.** No turpentine, no mineral spirits, no paint thinner. Oils are optional, only at 17–18, and only solvent-free: wipe the brush, work a little safflower oil through it, wipe again, then wash with soap and water. That two-rag method is an oil-paint maker’s published guidance.¹⁴
5. **Oily rags.** Into a bucket of water or a closed metal safety can, and out of the house daily. Rags soaked with linseed oil or solvents can heat up and catch fire on their own.¹³ This book keeps solvents out entirely, but oil paint soaks rags too, which is why the rule exists even in a solvent-free studio.
6. **Sprays.** Fix drawings with a brush-on clear acrylic polymer instead.¹³ If a spray is truly needed, it happens outdoors, downwind, with you present. No sprays indoors.
7. **Powders and pigments.** Premixed paints rather than dry pigment. Wet-wipe dust; never blow it off the page. No pointing brushes with the lips.
8. **Darkrooms, kilns, and presses.** Community venues only. A darkroom needs ventilation of at least ten room-air changes an hour, and kilns need venting to the outdoors, which is well beyond a home bathroom or garage.¹³
9. **Screens.** Short, frequent breaks. Screen at eye level. Wrists neutral.
10. **People and privacy.** Consent before drawing or photographing anyone; releases before entries or posting; no photos of minors, including your student, uploaded to AI tools or shared hosted workspaces (see the AI box below).
11. **If something goes wrong.** Poison Control in the U.S. is **1-800-222-1222**. For an emergency, call 911.¹³ Keep a first-aid kit on the studio shelf. After any near-miss (a slip with a blade, a rag found in a pile, a spray can opened indoors), stop, reset, and go back to the simpler tool or method for the rest of the week. That is what careful studios do, not a punishment.

These are the book’s practice rules. Your judgment of your student comes first: you know their hands, their attention, and your house better than any chart.

The AI box (once for the book)

AI in this book: a helper for you, never the artist. A generated image is not your student's mark. It never goes in the portfolio, on a contest entry, or on the transcript as their work, and any AI use goes on the whose-mark card. **Who holds the account:** at 15–16, you do, and your student sits beside you. At 17–18, a parent-linked account only where the service's terms allow teens (most say 13+ with parent permission under 18; some, like Claude, are 18+). Turn image generation off and training opt-out on where the settings allow. No AI during the attempt. **Good uses:** art-history questions you then check; three neutral critique questions *after* your student's own critique (crop to the work, no faces, never a grade); finding open-access collections; your own planning and safety checklists, verified. **The outside rules agree:** AP Art and Design (2026–27) prohibits generative AI in final work and requires disclosure of any use; Pratt bans AI-rendered images and AI-written text; Scholastic disqualifies AI-generated final work. This book's rule is stricter, so following it keeps you inside all of them. **Not in this book:** making the art; generative fill on portfolio work; statements written by a model; AI companions or agents for students; detectors as grades; uploading faces, other children, or identifying details. If you run your own assistant (a hosted bot or agent), treat it as *your* tool. A shared hosted workspace is not a privacy boundary for a teenager's photos.

A few plain lines to go with the box.

Why the line sits here. The looking and the marking are the skill. A brush or a stylus records your student's hand; a prompt-generated image does not. The U.S. Copyright Office has drawn the same line: a person can own what they themselves determined in a work, but not the output of “the mere provision of prompts.”¹⁵ The outside rules in the box are current as of this writing; the details and dates are in the notes.^{16,17,18,19,11}

Never during making, never in the portfolio or the statement. No tool is open during the attempt. Nothing generated goes into the portfolio, and no model writes an artist statement, caption, or essay. Your student writes every word. A student on the AP route may meet looser rules for early-stage ideas; this book's default is that the sketchbook does that job better.

One labelled comparison, once. Chapter 5 includes a single exercise for 17–18, with you present: one generated image placed beside your student's own observed drawing of the same subject, labelled *not my mark*, used only as something to look at and compare, and never filed. It is the only generated image in this book.

One caution from outside art. In a trial with high-school students learning math, those who leaned on an unguarded chatbot during practice did worse once it was taken away.²⁰ That was math, not art, and no study like it exists for art, but it is the same reason the attempt always comes first.

Checking and grading. Chatbots can invent sources with confidence, so every art-history claim gets checked against a museum page or a book.²¹ AI “detectors” are unreliable and have shown bias in writing; they are never used to grade anything in this book.²² Evidence of authorship comes from the sketchbook, process photos, saved versions, and the whose-mark card.

Uploads are privacy decisions. Some services’ terms give the company a broad, lasting licence to whatever is uploaded, including a person’s image and likeness.²³ Faces, other children, and identifying details stay out of every AI tool.

Your own assistant is your tool. If you use a hosted agent, keep it on your side of the table: planning the week, drafting a materials list, finding open collections. A hosted agent service can run all of an account’s bots on one shared cloud computer that holds their files, browser sessions, and logins, and its makers say plainly that separate bots are not a security boundary.²⁴ That is the Grok Bot arrangement, for example. So photos of your student, their friends, or their siblings never go onto a shared computer like that, and neither do identifying documents.

Platform ages at the time of writing (checked September 2026; terms change, so check the current page before signing up):^{25,23,26,27,28}

Service	Minimum age	Teens
ChatGPT (OpenAI)	13	Under 18 needs a parent’s or guardian’s permission
Grok (SpaceXAI)	13	13–17 need a parent’s permission; the parent is responsible for all use
Gemini (Google)	13	Check current teen and Family Link settings
Claude (Anthropic)	18	Not for students under 18
Adobe generative features	—	18+ to use non-Adobe models inside Adobe’s generative tools

When the hour goes wrong

What you see	What it usually means	First move
Won’t start	Blank-page fear; no plan	An ugly page on purpose (Chapter 2); a one-line Monday plan
Copies phone images	Skipping observation	Draw the real object first; measuring (Chapter 3)
Drowning in one piece for weeks	No stopping rule	A timer; a series of small studies instead
Only wants digital	Comfort medium	Digital drawing from life, with process capture on (Chapter 5); one analog day a week
Hates critique	Bracing for judgment	Critique other people’s work first; the student asks their question first

What you see	What it usually means	First move
You keep fixing the page	The helping instinct	Demo on scrap only; hand the tool back
A generated image in the folder	Blurry sense of authorship	The whose-mark card; a calm conversation; not portfolio work
Rags in a pile	A habit gap	Rags into water or the can today; tape the rule to the lid
A spray can opened indoors	Convenience	Stop, ventilate; brush-on fixative from now on
The investigation stalls	The question is too broad	Rewrite the question; plan in three chapters of five works (Chapter 8)

Dose honesty

Here is the arithmetic, not a mandate. Three 50-minute Art Hours a week for 32 weeks is about 80 hours. A 12-minute daily page on five days a week adds about 32. Two museum or gallery trips and one portfolio review add roughly 10. That comes to about 120 hours, the usual size of one elective high-school credit; about 60 hours is commonly counted as a half-credit.^{4,5} Studio time and community classes add more.

If a day holds only twenty minutes, do See, a short Make, and File. One beat done well beats five rushed. And if a semester is all your student can give art this year, a half-credit done honestly is a real credit.

The rhythm of the habit

Look back at last week's page before starting a new one. Draw the same object again next month and put the two pages side by side. Keep the daily page going over holidays and breaks, even at one page a week. Photograph finished work the day it's done. Stop a session while your student still wants one more line.

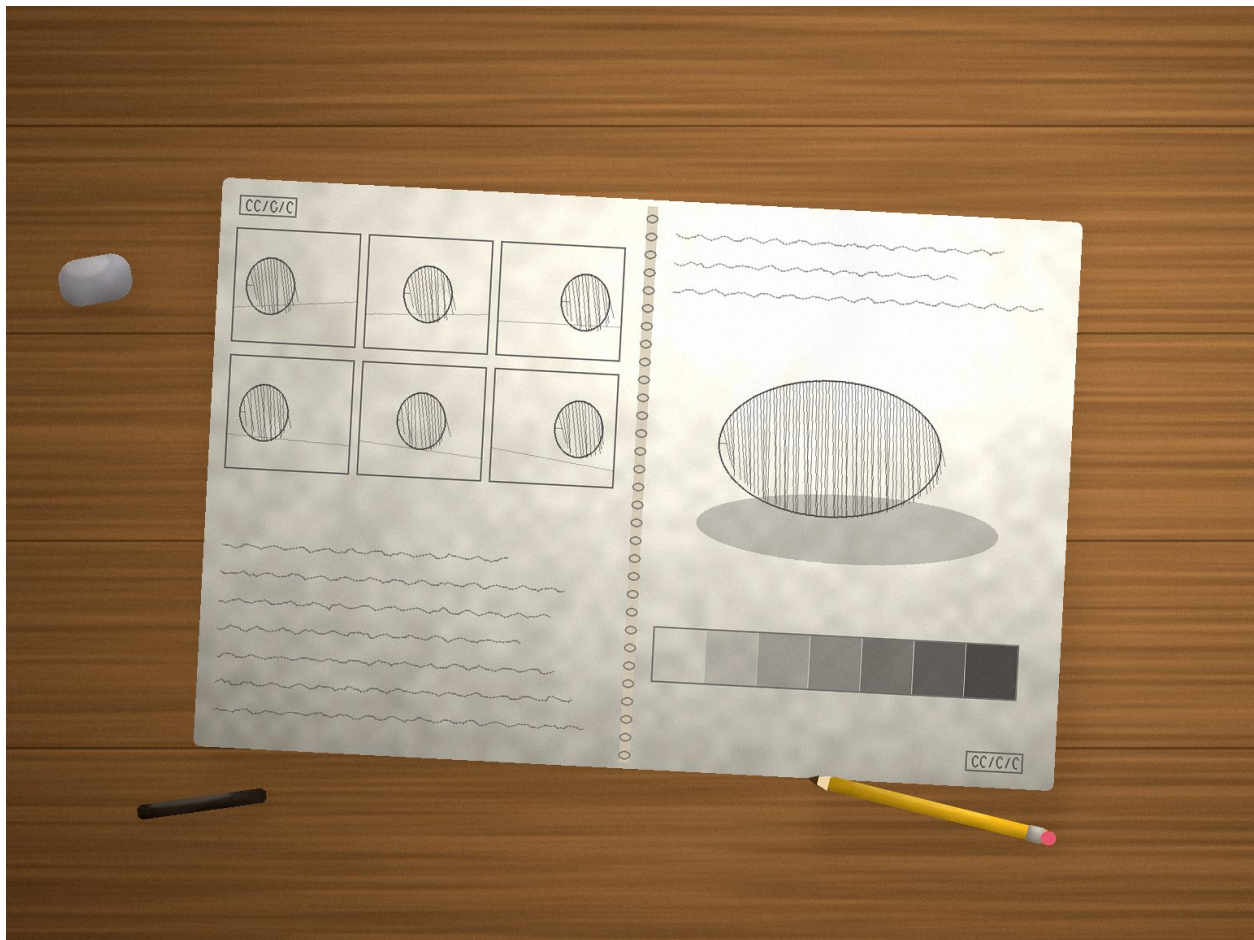
That rhythm lives here, in each chapter's "done enough" list, and in the records. It does not need a chapter of its own.

Ready to begin

You have the hour, the daily page, the week the student plans, the talk-box shape, the try-it shapes, the safety spine, and the AI box.

Chapter 1 puts the whole focus on the table. Tonight, set out a lamp and three ordinary objects. Tomorrow, hand your student a sketchbook and ask them to write the date in the corner.

Chapter 1 — What art looks like at 15–18



Why this matters

Somewhere around fifteen, the question about art changes.

At eleven or twelve, most young people want their drawings to look *right*, and the work of those years is learning to see well enough to get there. By fifteen, many students can render some things convincingly. They can draw a mug that sits on the table, a hand that looks like a hand, a street that goes back into the distance. The new question is not whether they can draw. It is what they will

choose to look at, and whether they will stay with it long enough to make something that is theirs.

Here is the student you actually have. They can do sustained, serious work. They see every flaw in their own drawing, often before they see anything good. Their taste is ahead of their hand: they admire work they cannot make yet, and the gap can feel like a judgment on them. They want a voice. They have audiences everywhere, from friends and social feeds to contest judges and admissions readers. And their time is being pulled toward jobs, driving, and heavier coursework.

Every one of those traits is useful. The self-criticism means they can see. The taste tells them where they are headed. The wish for a voice is the beginning of a body of work. The audiences give the work somewhere to go, once there is a private place to make it first. Even the time pressure helps, because it forces a question every working artist has to answer: what is worth my hours?

This chapter sets up the year. It puts the focus of the whole book on the table:

See long before you judge; sketch before you polish; sign only what you made.

It changes your role from teacher to co-teacher and mentor. It hands your student the week: they plan it, they chair the Art Hour, they run the critique. It places your student in a band by what they can do and how independently they work, not by their birthday. And it gives you a baseline, a dated starting point you will be glad to have in May.

Why the struggle is worth it. At this age, many students are one discouraging semester away from deciding art “isn’t their thing.” In the most recent national survey that asked, fewer homeschooled high schoolers were being taught art than at any earlier stage (the Welcomes have the numbers).¹ A student who gets through the first uncomfortable month of daily pages, slow blind contours, and critiques they have to run themselves comes out with something durable: the knowledge that art is a practice they own, not a talent someone else hands out.

You do not need to be an artist to teach this chapter. You need to hand over the chair, and then ask good questions from the passenger seat.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You are not the art teacher this year, not in the old sense. You are the person who makes the studio possible and keeps it honest. That is a different job, and most parents find it easier than they feared.

You are also in good company. In the 2022–23 school year, about 3.4 percent of American school-age children were homeschooled, and 3.1 percent of students in grades 9–12.²⁹ Many of those families are working out the same shift you are: from teaching a child to mentoring a near-adult.

The everyday picture: the passenger seat

Think about coaching a teenager who already has a learner’s permit and knows the rules of the road. You are no longer explaining the pedals. You sit in the passenger seat. You ask, “What did you see at that junction?” You notice when they drift, and you ask about it rather than grabbing the wheel. And when they need something you can’t give, such as a highway lesson or a parallel-parking drill, you arrange it with someone better at it than you.

That is your role this year. Your student drives the Art Hour. You protect the time, keep the studio safe, ask what they saw, and find outside teachers when the student has outgrown the passenger seat. Grabbing the wheel, even once, even kindly, teaches that the car is yours.

The precise picture: what serious high-school studios teach

A research team led by Lois Hetland and Ellen Winner videotaped 38 visual-arts classes at two arts-focused high schools, Walnut Hill School for the Arts and the Boston Arts Academy, and interviewed the teachers about what they were trying to teach.⁶ They found teachers building eight habits alongside painting and drawing technique. Here they are in plain lines:

Habit	What it looks like in your student
Develop Craft	They can control the tool and keep a tidy, safe studio.
Engage and Persist	They stay with a hard piece past the boring middle.
Envision	They can picture what isn't there yet and plan for it.
Express	The work says something beyond "I can draw."
Observe	They look longer and more closely than people usually do.
Reflect	They can say what's working, what isn't, and why.
Stretch and Explore	They try things they might fail at, on purpose.
Understand Art Worlds	They know some of the history and people their work talks to.

These are descriptions of good teaching, not measured outcomes. Nobody has shown that practicing them raises test scores, and this book won't claim it. What they give you is a vocabulary. When you run a monthly progress check (Chapter 8), these eight lines are what you and your student look for.

The same research describes how those teachers spent class time: a short demonstration, a long stretch of students working while the teacher circulates and asks questions, and critique with the work up on the wall.⁶ Look at that list again. Two of the three are jobs you can do from the first day: protecting work time with good check-in questions, and hosting a critique your student chairs. The third, the demonstration, you borrow.

There is one honest bridge to the rest of life worth knowing. In one experiment, learning to look closely at works of art improved people's skill at observing scientific images.² That is a close cousin of the same skill, not a general boost to intelligence, and it is the right size of claim for art. Art is worth your student's hours for what art teaches.

Where this age sits on the map

The art educator Viktor Lowenfeld described a long arc of how young people’s art changes. He called the high-school years the “Period of Decision”: the stretch when young people decide, consciously or not, whether art is going to be theirs.³⁰ Editions of his book give different ages, so hold the years loosely and keep the idea. Your student is deciding right now. Your job is not to decide for them; it is to make sure they decide after an honest try, not after one bad semester.

A note on the series name. Researchers use “emerging adults” for people roughly eighteen to twenty-five, the years after high school when many people are finding their footing.³¹ This book borrows the phrase as a name for the third stage of the WisdomForge ladder, fifteen to eighteen. When this book talks about what teenagers are like, it means teenagers.

What changes in the focus

At eleven to fourteen, the focus was *see before you judge; sketch before you polish*. It has grown in two ways.

See long before you judge. The word *long* is new. Your student can already look. Now they practice staying: a second session with a drawing they want to abandon, ten minutes with a contemporary work they dislike, a week of pages of one object. Most drawing trouble is still seeing trouble, even for adults: careful research found that misjudging what the object looks like causes more drawing errors than an unsteady hand.³² Staying longer is how the seeing gets better.

Sign only what you made. This clause is new, because the work is starting to leave the house with a name on it: a contest entry, a portfolio, a transcript line. It covers every kind of help. A copied photo isn’t an observation. A parent’s fix isn’t the student’s drawing. A generated image isn’t the student’s mark. None of this is about suspicion. It is about being able to stand behind every piece.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

These are the five you will hear most in the first month. Each has a usual meaning and a next move.

1. **“I’m just not an artist.”** Usually means a verdict before the work. They are judging a skill they haven’t practiced yet. Next move: leave the talent question alone and start the habits: a daily page for two weeks and one long drawing. Revisit the question with evidence in a month.
2. **“I only draw from photos.”** Usually means they are skipping observation, often because photos hold still and feel safer. Photos have a place, credited. But drawing from life is its own skill, and it is the one art schools ask for by name. RISD strongly recommends work from direct observation, Pratt asks for several observation pieces, and SAIC discourages work copied from photographs, as of this writing.^{33,19,34} Next move: one daily page a day from a real object, no screens.
3. **“I need to find my style first.”** Usually means a style being chosen before any investigation. Style tends to show up after many works on one question, not before. Next move: trade “style” for “question.” What do they keep drawing? What do they want to find out about it?

4. **“It doesn’t count unless it’s for AP.”** Usually means the doors have been mistaken for the house. AP, dual enrollment, and art-school applications are real options, and this book treats them accurately. None of them is the spine. A year of honest studio work with logged hours is a credit whether or not an AP portfolio is ever submitted. Next move: show them Chapter 9’s list of plain course titles.
5. **“I made this,” about a generated image.** Usually means a blurry sense of what making is. Next move: a calm, plain conversation. The U.S. Copyright Office has said that writing a prompt does not make someone the author of the image that comes back.¹⁵ Neither does this book. The image can be looked at and talked about. It never goes in the folder as their work.

Your ten-minute warm-up (alone, before the first Hour)

Put your non-drawing hand on the table in a relaxed pose. Set a timer for ten minutes. Draw it. Don’t erase, don’t sigh, and don’t stop early.

When the timer goes off, write a list underneath: *what would I need to learn to make this better?* Maybe: how long the fingers really are compared to the palm; where the knuckles line up; how to make the shadow side look round.

That list is your student’s life at this age: a skill that can be broken into learnable parts, practiced in a sketchbook nobody grades. Keep your page. You may want to show it to your student this week, without commentary.

How to teach it this week

This week’s focus

One idea: **the year belongs to the student, and it starts with seeing.** Everything this week practices one of three things: the daily habit, slow looking, or running a critique.

The first try-its

In the first Art Hour, in this order:

1. **Start the daily page** today, with the first page done in the Hour so the routine is clear.
2. **A grown-up blind contour** of the student’s own hand as the Sketch beat.
3. **The baseline progress check** as the Make beat: one dated drawing from life, unaided, to file.

In the second Art Hour, your student chairs a **student-led look** at one real work of art using the three VTS questions, with you answering. In the third (if the week has one), they make a first small piece of their own choosing and run a short critique of it. Full try-it cards are in the next section.

Exact wording you can use

Try these as written. They are short on purpose.

- Opening the year: “This is your studio year. You plan the week; I’ll initial it.”
- Handing over the sketchbook: “This is yours. I’ll check that pages happen. I’ll read the ones you show me.”
- Passing through during Make: “Where are you looking hardest?”
- Handing over the critique: “You chair the critique today. I’ll answer your questions.”
- Talk-box opening (locked): “What did you make this week that you’d make again — and why?”
- After the baseline: “This isn’t graded. It’s a snapshot so we can see how far you’ve come.”
- Setting direction: “Let’s write down what you want to learn this year.”
- When they ask for your opinion: “I’ll give it. First tell me what you see.”

How to fade your help

- **First two Hours:** sit in for the whole thing. Do your own daily page at the same table. Model the silent look by actually doing it.
- **Weeks two and three:** be there for the start (reading the plan) and for the critique. During Make, busy yourself with something quiet in the same room or nearby.
- **After that:** read the Monday plan, pass through once during Make with one question, come back for the critique, and initial the Friday File.

At 15–16, you will probably stay closer for longer, and that is fine. At 17–18, many students want the room to themselves by the second week.

When to stop talking

Once the pencil moves, stop. Advice given mid-line lands as criticism at this age, however kindly meant. Save it for the critique, and even then, ask permission before offering an opinion.

If you catch yourself narrating (“Careful with that edge...”), leave the room or pick up your own sketchbook. Both work.

Band moves

15–16. You co-plan the week for the first month: sit down together on Monday, and your student writes the lines. You are present for any new material. Critique uses the three VTS questions on a card. The baseline can be a simple arrangement: three objects under one lamp. The year’s question can be loose (“I want to get better at hands”).

17–18. Your student plans the week; you ask for the plan and initial it. They may choose to chair critique using the Critical Response Process from the start. The baseline can be harder: a mirror self-portrait, a chair in a corner, a view out a window. The year’s question can aim at a sustained investigation later in the year.

Placing a student. Use what you see this week, not the birthday. A fifteen-year-old who plans a sensible week unasked, measures by instinct, and can run a critique is ready for 17–18 moves. An eighteen-year-old coming to art fresh starts with 15–16 moves, and there is nothing lost by it. You can change the placement any month.

A sample week

Day	What happens
Monday	Student writes the plan (co-written at 15–16); Art Hour: first daily page, blind contour, baseline check
Tuesday	Daily page
Wednesday	Art Hour: student-led VTS on one painting; the year’s question drafted
Thursday	Daily page; studio time if wanted
Friday	Art Hour: a small piece of the student’s choosing; talk box; Friday File and first hour-log entry
Weekend	Museum or gallery visit with one question, this week or next

That is a full week. If life allows only two Art Hours, keep Monday and Friday.

Practice that actually builds learning

Each try-it below uses the shape from The Art Hour: time, materials, mess and safety, the pull, and the skill. This chapter’s materials are gentle (pencils, pens, paper), so the safety spine mostly stays in the background this week.

In-home — The daily page

- **Time:** 10–15 minutes, every day
- **Materials:** Sketchbook; pencil or pen; whatever is in front of the student
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The pull:** It is short, private, and nobody grades it. Many students come to like it more than the Art Hour.
- **The skill:** A daily habit of drawing from life; the backbone of every later chapter

Steps. Date the page. Draw one thing that is actually in front of you for ten to fifteen minutes. Write one line underneath: something noticed, tried, or wondered. Stop at the timer.³⁵

Stuck → move. Tape a list of thirty “boring objects” inside the sketchbook cover (a stapler, a sneaker, a cut onion, the kettle) and take the next one on the list. Boredom with the object is fine. Boredom is often where the looking gets interesting.

In-home — Blind contour, grown up

- **Time:** 10 minutes
- **Materials:** Pen (not pencil; no erasing) and paper

- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The pull:** It looks strange, and it is supposed to. It is also the fastest way to feel the difference between looking and guessing.
- **The skill:** Slowing the hand to the speed of the eye; lines that follow edges instead of symbols

Steps. A contour is a line that follows an edge. Your student does three two-minute blind contours of their non-drawing hand, eyes on the hand the whole time, never on the page, moving the pen as slowly as the eye creeps along each edge. Then one more, in which they may glance at the page only at corners and joints.³⁵

Stuck → move. If the pen races ahead, slow it down to the speed of the eye. If peeking keeps happening, put the drawing hand under a sheet of paper with a hole for the pen.

In-home — A student-led look at a real work

- **Time:** 15 minutes
- **Materials:** One real work of art: a museum postcard, a library art book, or a large image from a free museum collection (Chapter 10)
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The pull:** The student asks the questions and the parent has to answer them.
- **The skill:** Seeing before judging, applied to someone else's work; running a critique

Steps. Your student holds the card with the three VTS questions: *What's going on in this picture? What do you see that makes you say that? What more can we find?* They ask; you answer. Their job is to paraphrase each of your answers before asking the next question, without praising or correcting.⁷ After ten minutes, read the museum label together.

Stuck → move. If paraphrasing feels awkward, have them start every paraphrase with “So you’re seeing...”. By the third answer it usually feels normal.

In-home — The baseline progress check

- **Time:** 30 minutes, once now and then once a month
- **Materials:** A simple setup you can recreate (three objects under one lamp, or a mirror and a lamp); pencil; good paper; a folder for check pages
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The pull:** Honestly, not much this week. In about four months, when the pages go side by side, a great deal.
- **The skill:** A dated snapshot of where your student is starting

Steps. Say: “Thirty minutes, from life, no help from me. It isn’t graded. It’s a snapshot.” Stay out of it. When the timer ends, your student dates it, names the setup, and then does something new for this age: they rate the drawing against three of the eight habits from the table above (Observe, Develop Craft, and Engage and Persist work well to start), with two sentences on what they see. You add one sentence of your own, describing something you noticed. File it.³⁵

How to read it. Look for seeing, not polish. Do the proportions come from measuring or guessing? Is there light and shadow, or only outline? Did they stay the full thirty minutes? The page tells you

where Chapter 3 needs to start. It tells you nothing about talent.

Stuck → **move**. If they want to redo it, gently decline: “Next month there’s another one.” At 17–18 many students prefer you out of the room entirely.

In-home (optional) — Teach a younger sibling

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** One activity from *Art for Little Thinkers* or *Art for Young Minds*, and a younger child
- **Mess / safety:** Whatever the younger book’s activity calls for
- **The pull:** Being the expert for half an hour
- **The skill:** Explaining a skill simply, which reveals what your teenager actually understands

Steps. Your teenager leads the younger child through one activity, then writes down what they had to explain and where they got stuck explaining it.³⁵ That note is a surprisingly good diagnostic: the part they couldn’t explain is usually the part they haven’t quite learned.

Stuck → **move**. If they start doing it for the younger child, remind them of the rescue order: demonstrate on scrap, then hand it over.

Out-of-home — A museum or gallery visit with one question

- **Time:** About 2 hours
- **Materials:** Sketchbook; pencil (many museums allow pencils only in the galleries; check the visitor rules before you go)
- **Mess / safety:** Venue rules; hands off the art; preview galleries if your family has standards about subject matter
- **The pull:** One question instead of a forced march through every room
- **The skill:** Looking long at real work, and choosing

Steps. Before you go, your student writes one question: *How do painters make a room feel quiet? What do sculptors do with hands? How dark do the darkest darks get?* At the museum, they find three works that answer it and sketch each one for about ten minutes. Phones stay away except to photograph a label where the museum allows it. Afterward, they write a short paragraph answering the question.³⁵ Chapter 6 grows this into a full practice.

Stuck → **move**. If the question feels too big in the building, sit in one room for twenty minutes and let the question narrow to what’s on those walls.

Talk box — this chapter

Opening (locked): “What did you make this week that you’d make again — and why?”

Use it on Friday, about anything from the week: a daily page, the blind contour, the baseline, a museum sketch. At 17–18, your student may ask it of you about your own warm-up page. Answer honestly.

Follow-ups:

1. **Seeing:** “What did you see that you didn’t expect?”
2. **Process:** “Where did you get stuck?”
3. **Choice:** “What did you choose, and what did you rule out?”
4. **Revise:** “What would you try next?”

How to wait. Ask, then count a slow three in your head. After they answer, wait again. The “why” part of the opening often comes on the second wait. If the silence feels heavy, look at the page, not at your student.

What stuck silence usually means. Most often at this age: the student expects a verdict and is bracing for it, or thinks “make again” is a trick question about which piece was “best.” It can also mean they are hunting for the right art word, or that nothing from the week felt worth making again. That last one is an honest answer, and worth a follow-up: “What would have to change for you to want to make it again?” To get talk moving, describe something you noticed, neutrally (“The second blind contour has a lot more wrinkles in it than the first”), and wait again. “Not today” is allowed.

Don’t say / say instead. Don’t say: “I like this one best.” Say instead: “Tell me which one you’d make again first.”

Your favorite, said first, becomes the answer. Asked second, with permission, it becomes a conversation.

Blocked and mixed practice

Blocked, for the new habit. A week of daily pages of one object: the same shoe, kettle, or houseplant every day, from a new angle, in new light, or with a new tool each day. Short and repetitive on purpose. By day four, most students find things they could swear weren’t there on day one.

Mixed, for choosing when. Later in the month, combine: a daily page in the morning and a student-led VTS session on a real painting in the afternoon, then ask which habit from the table each one practiced. Your student practices naming what they’re doing, not just doing it.

Retrieval. On Friday, without notes: “Say the focus in your own words.” “Name three of the eight habits and one place you used each this week.” Short spoken answers are enough.

One incorrect example to diagnose

Make this pair yourself on scrap paper, or describe it and let your student make it. (It is an illustration, not a real student’s work.)

Two drawings of the same mug. The first was traced from a phone photo: clean, confident outline; the rim a perfect ellipse; the handle an even loop; no cast shadow, because the photo was taken with a flash; the same line weight all the way around. The second was drawn from the real mug on the table: the rim ellipse slightly flatter than a textbook ellipse; a couple of corrected lines near the handle, left visible; the shadow side of the body darker than the light side; a cast shadow that

is darkest right where the mug touches the table; a thin bright edge along the rim where the lamp catches it.

Ask: **“Which one was seen?”**

Let your student explain how they know. They will point at the corrected lines, the shadow, the bright rim, the way the handle thins where it meets the body. Those are the evidence of looking. The traced one is tidy, and it contains no decisions at all.

Then, plainly: “The first one is fine as a labelled study. It isn’t an observation. This year, we’re building the second kind.”

For the student

This section is for you. Your parent can read it too, but it is written to you.

Here is the idea. At this age, the question isn’t whether you can draw. It’s what you’ll choose to look at, and whether you’ll stay with it.

This book comes down to one sentence in three parts:

See long before you judge. Look carefully, measure, and describe before you decide whether something works, whether it’s your drawing or a painting in a museum you think is terrible. Then decide. With reasons.

Sketch before you polish. Thumbnails, studies, and ugly middles are where the real decisions get made. The careful version comes after.

Sign only what you made. Put your name only on marks and choices that are yours. Credit your references, note who helped, and never treat a generated image as your work.

What serious art students practice. Researchers who watched serious high-school art classes found teachers building eight habits. You’ll use them to check your own progress each month:

- **Develop Craft:** you can control the tool and keep a tidy, safe studio.
- **Engage and Persist:** you stay with a hard piece past the boring middle.
- **Envision:** you can picture what isn’t there yet and plan for it.
- **Express:** the work says something beyond “I can draw.”
- **Observe:** you look longer and more closely than people usually do.
- **Reflect:** you can say what’s working, what isn’t, and why.
- **Stretch and Explore:** you try things you might fail at, on purpose.
- **Understand Art Worlds:** you know some of the history and people your work talks to.

A tiny worked example. Pick up a mug. You know its rim is a circle. Now set it on the table and look at it from where you sit. The rim isn’t a circle anymore; it’s a flattened oval, and the far edge looks thinner than the near edge. The handle, which you know is a loop, might be mostly hidden. If you draw the circle you know, the mug will look like it’s tipping toward you. If you draw the oval you see, it will sit on the table. That’s the gap between knowing and seeing, and closing it is most of what drawing from life is.

Try 1: the daily page, for a week. Every day for seven days, date a page and draw one thing in front of you for 10–15 minutes. Write one line underneath. Stop at the timer, even mid-line. Your sketchbook has no followers. That’s the point.

Try 2: one blind contour of your hand. Put your non-drawing hand on the table. Pen on paper. Look only at your hand, never at the page, and move the pen as slowly as your eyes move along the edges, into every wrinkle. Take at least three minutes. The drawing will look odd. Then look at your hand again. You’ll see things you’ve never noticed.

You’re running this. You plan the week on Monday: one line per session. You chair the Art Hour, including the critique. Your parent initials the plan and the Friday log, asks questions, and keeps the studio safe. If you want their opinion on your work, ask for it. If you don’t, “not today” is a fine answer.

Explain it back. In your own words, on the inside cover: *What does “sign only what you made” mean for your sketchbook?* (Think about copies, photos you used, and help from anyone.)

Challenge: your year’s question. Write one sentence: what do you want to find out this year, through your work? Not a style, a question. *How do I make a drawing feel like early morning? What can I do with only three colors? Why do I keep drawing hands?* It will change. That’s fine. Date it, and look at it again in a month.

One honest warning: the first couple of weeks of this can feel slower than just drawing the way you always have. You’re asking your eyes to do more work. It pays off, and the dated pages will show you exactly how much.

If it isn’t clicking

Snag 1: they won’t start

The sketchbook stays closed. “I don’t know what to draw” usually means “I’m afraid of how it will look.”

Next move. Do a daily page yourself, beside them, at the same time, on the same kind of object. Don’t show it off, and don’t make it a lesson. Shrink the task: “Just the handle. Five minutes.” Starting is usually the whole hurdle.

Snag 2: they only want to work digitally

Tablet yes; pencil no.

Next move. Fine, with two conditions. The drawing is from life (the real object on the table, not a screen), and process capture is on, so the time-lapse or saved versions show the hand at work. Chapter 5 covers digital drawing properly. Add one analog daily page a week, not as a penalty, just to keep the other hand in.

Snag 3: crushed by comparison online

They’ve seen what other sixteen-year-olds post, and now their own page looks hopeless.

Next move. Say plainly: the sketchbook is private, and the portfolio gets chosen later, from the archive. What gets posted online is usually a finished piece chosen from dozens of unposted attempts. Suggest accounts off, or the phone in another room, for the length of the Hour. Adolescents are especially sensitive to being watched and judged,⁹ and a page nobody will see is a page they can risk.

Snag 4: “art just isn’t my thing”

They say it calmly, and they might mean it.

Next move. Offer one honest semester, with the daily page, the Art Hours, and one outing a month, and then decide together, with the dated pages on the table. If the answer is still no, a semester of logged work is commonly counted as a half-credit,^{5,4} and it is a real credit, honestly earned.

An illustration: the screen artist

(A composite, not a real family.) A fifteen-year-old draws anime characters from screens, and draws them well. Their parent says, cheerfully, that they can’t draw a stick figure. The first baseline check, a still life, is stiff, and the student is annoyed about it.

Respect the interest; it represents real hours and real control of line. Keep it going on its own pages, credited (“after [show], episode ____”). Add the daily page from life. At the first talk box, the parent asks which of this week’s pages the student would make again, and the student, somewhat to their own surprise, picks a daily page of a crumpled paper bag. Nothing was taken away. Something was added.

An illustration: the senior starting late

(A composite, not a real family.) An eighteen-year-old decides in September of senior year that they want art on the transcript. They have not drawn since middle school.

They start with the 15–16 moves, with no apology needed. The plan is a half-credit: about sixty logged hours across one semester, built from daily pages, two Art Hours a week, and two museum visits. The baseline is honest and rough; the fourth monthly check is visibly different. The course gets a plain title and a (0.5). Nobody in this book is behind.

When to slow down, go ahead, or find another teacher

Slow down if the daily page isn’t happening most days after two weeks. Shrink it to ten minutes and one object before adding anything else.

Go ahead when there are five or more daily pages in a week, the student has chaired a critique, and the baseline is filed.

Find another teacher when your student has outgrown what you can give them: more demonstration, more technique, other young artists to work beside. A community class, a museum teen program, or later a dual-enrollment course is a gift, not a failure. You stay on as the mentor and the records-keeper.

Tools, including AI

The full rules are in the AI box in The Art Hour. In this chapter, any tool is for you, not your student.

One useful job: you may use an assistant to help plan the week or draft a list of neutral follow-up questions for the talk box, and then check it. The student's work stays theirs: no tool is open during the Hour, and nothing generated goes in the sketchbook.

What “done enough” looks like

Before moving on to Chapter 2, check:

- ☐ A dated baseline progress check is filed, with the student's two sentences and your one.
- ☐ At least five dated daily pages exist this week. You checked that they exist; you read only what was offered.
- ☐ Your student wrote a Monday plan and a Friday File (with your help at 15–16), and you initialed both.
- ☐ Your student has chaired at least one critique, on their own work or a real work of art.
- ☐ Your student can say the focus in their own words and explain what each clause means.
- ☐ You have agreed on a band placement for now, and you both know it can change.
- ☐ The weekly hour log has its first entry.
- ☐ The year's question is written down and dated, however rough.
- ☐ Nothing generated is in the sketchbook as your student's work.

Placement by skill. Use this week's pages, not the birthday, to decide how Chapter 2 starts. A “grade 10 art” book is a publisher's scope, not a legal level.

Done enough is not perfect. It is: the habit started, the chair handed over, a baseline filed, and the log begun.

Chapter 2 — The sketchbook, the studio, and adult tools



Why this matters

Everything else in this book stands on two things: a sketchbook that gets used every day, and a studio corner where work can start in two minutes and stop safely.

The sketchbook is where your student thinks. It holds the daily page, the thumbnails before every piece, the ugly experiments with a new tool, the labelled copies of paintings they admire, the

questions that will one day carry a whole body of work. It is dated, it is kept, and it is theirs. At fifteen to eighteen it is also evidence. The AP Art and Design course describes its central work as a sustained investigation carried out “through practice, experimentation, and revision”;¹⁷ sketchbook pages are exactly that, in the student’s own hand. A good sketchbook is how a reviewer, a college, or a stranger reading a transcript can see how your student thinks.

The studio is where the adult tools live. This is the age when a craft knife, a real set of acrylics, a can of fixative, and, at 17–18 if your family chooses, oil paint can enter the house. Each of those tools has rules. The rules are not complicated. Studio safety at this age comes down to three habits: read the label, move the air, and keep sharp and oily things where they belong. A student who has those habits is trusted with the tools. A student who doesn’t yet isn’t, and that is a fair and simple deal.

This chapter builds both at once, because at this age they are one subject: the working habit and the working space. It is also where the safety spine from *The Art Hour* stops being a list and becomes practice.

Why the struggle is worth it. A daily page sounds small. Some days it will feel pointless. But a year of daily pages is several hundred drawings from life, a record of change nobody can argue with, and a habit that tends to outlast high school. And a studio your student can set up, use, and clean up safely without being reminded is a quiet form of adulthood. Both are worth a few weeks of friction.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You don’t need to keep a sketchbook to teach this chapter, though many parents find a cheap one of their own helps. You do need to understand what the sketchbook is for, and to read a product label well enough to sort materials into what’s fine at home, what needs you present, and what doesn’t belong in the house.

The everyday picture: a practice log and a set-up kitchen

Think of a musician’s practice log and a restaurant kitchen’s *mise en place*, the chef’s habit of having every ingredient prepped and in its place before service.

The practice log is small, daily, and private. Nobody performs scales for an audience. The musician plays them because the concert is built out of them. The sketchbook is the same: it is where the daily practice happens, and most of it is not meant to be seen.

Mise en place is why a good kitchen can start cooking the instant an order comes in, and why it is safe. Knives have a place. Hot things have a place. Oily rags don’t pile up by the stove. A studio set up the same way means the daily page can start in two minutes instead of twenty, and the risky things are always where they should be.

The precise picture: the working sketchbook

A working sketchbook at this age holds several distinct kinds of page. Your student doesn't need all of them every week, but over a year, all of them should appear.

- **The daily page.** Ten to fifteen minutes, dated, drawn from something in front of them, one written line underneath.
- **Thumbnails.** Before any piece that matters, nine small compositions, each two inches or so across, each changing one thing. Two get starred; one gets enlarged.
- **Ugly pages.** A page filled fast and badly, on purpose, with a new tool, to find out what it does.
- **Labelled copies.** A passage copied from a master work, labelled “after [Artist], [Title]” with the source. Copies are how artists have always learned. The label keeps them honest.
- **A question log.** At the back: one “How might I...?” question a week. The ones that keep coming back become investigations.
- **Visual journal spreads.** At 17–18: a two-page plan for a piece, with the question, cited references, thumbnails, and a materials test. An AP reader, or any stranger, could follow it as process.
- **Tabs.** Once a month, sticky tabs on the pages worth returning to, with a word on each tab about why.

Private by default. Teenagers are especially sensitive to being watched and judged by others.⁹ A sketchbook that might be judged becomes a sketchbook of safe, finished-looking pages, and the thinking stops. So you check that pages happen. You read the ones your student offers. Nothing gets shown to anyone without their agreement.

No tearing out. Every page stays, including the bad ones. Torn-out pages are erased evidence: of process, of hours, of how far the student has come. A bad page can be turned past. It can't be removed.

The precise picture: reading a label

Most art materials a teenager uses carry one of two seals from the Art and Creative Materials Institute (ACMI), which runs a certification program for art materials.

- The **AP** seal marks products labelled for students in sixth grade or younger.
- The **CL** seal (“cautionary labeling”) marks products for seventh grade or older. The label must be read in full before opening, and its cautions followed.¹²

Both seals are applied under a federal labelling law, and most art materials also carry the line “conforms to ASTM D-4236.” That line means the product was reviewed for long-term hazards and labelled accordingly. It is a labelling procedure. It does not mean the product is non-toxic, and it does not mean it is safe to use in every way.¹³ The label itself, especially any warnings on a CL product, is what tells you how to use it.

So when you sort materials, sort by what the label says and what the process involves. Pencils, graphite, water-based markers, most watercolor and gouache, and most acrylics are ordinary home materials, used with the studio habits. Craft knives, new CL products, and anything that makes

dust or fumes need you present at 15–16 and the rules posted at 17–18. Solvents, spray products used indoors, darkroom chemistry, and kilns don't belong in the house at all.

The three habits, in practice

Read the label. Before any new product is opened, your student reads the label aloud to you the first time, and says what it tells them and what it doesn't.

Move the air; keep food out. Ventilation means clean air coming toward the artist and used air going away. A window open and a fan in another window pulling air *out* does that. A fan that only stirs the room's air around doesn't, and can make things worse.¹³ No food or drink at the art table. Hands washed afterward.

Keep sharp and oily things where they belong. Blades in a lidded container. Rags into water or a closed metal can. Cutting done on a mat with a metal ruler and a cut-resistant glove on the holding hand.¹³ Everything back in its place at the end of the File beat.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **“My sketchbook has to look good.”** Usually means performance has moved into the practice space, often because the student imagines an audience. Next move: the ugly-page license (below), and, if needed, a second cheap sketchbook just for ugly work.
2. **Torn-out pages.** Usually means embarrassment about a bad page. Next move: a house rule that pages stay, said kindly. “Turn past it. Don't tear it. It's part of the record.”
3. **A studio that takes twenty minutes to set up.** Usually means there will be no daily habit, because nobody starts something that takes twenty minutes to start. Next move: a two-bin rule (current project in one bin, everything else in the other) and a sketchbook that lives on the table.
4. **“It says non-toxic, so it's fine.”** Usually means the ASTM D-4236 line has been misread, or a marketing word taken for a safety rating. Next move: read the whole label together, and look for the seal and any warnings.
5. **Oily rags in a pile in the garage.** Usually means nobody told them. Rags soaked with linseed oil or solvents can heat up and catch fire on their own, with no flame nearby.¹³ Next move: rags into a bucket of water or a closed metal can today, and out of the house daily. Tape the rule to the lid.

Your ten-minute warm-up (alone, before the first lesson)

Find three art or craft products already in your house: a marker, a glue, a paint, a can of anything. Read each label in full. For each, find the ACMI seal if there is one (AP or CL), any ASTM D-4236 line, and any warnings. Then sort them into three piles: fine at home, only with an adult present, not in the house.

If one surprises you, good. You have just done the lesson you'll teach this week, and you'll be able to hear your student misread a label because you've done it too.

How to teach it this week

This week's focus

Two ideas: **the sketchbook is a lab, not a gallery**, and **every tool comes with its rule first**.

The first try-its

1. **The daily page** continues from Chapter 1, every day.
2. **Nine thumbnails** before this week's first real piece.
3. **The ugly-page license**: one page, fast and bad, with a tool your student dislikes.
4. **Read the label**: three products, sorted.
5. **Air and the no-food studio**: set up the corner together.

Full try-it cards are in the next section.

Setting up the corner

Walk through this with your student. They do the setting up; you check it. It is their studio.

- **Light**. A window for daylight, plus a lamp you can aim for still lifes.
- **A washable surface** and a board to work on.
- **A closed bin** (or two) for materials, labelled.
- **A place for wet work** to dry where no one will lean on it.
- **Air**. A window that opens, and a fan that pulls air out.
- **A snack table outside the studio** for the tea and the water bottle.
- **A lidded blade container** and a first-aid kit on the shelf.
- **A posted rules card**, written by your student, with Poison Control (**1-800-222-1222**) at the bottom.¹³
- **If oils ever arrive (17–18 only)**: a lidded metal can or a bucket of water for rags, set up *before* the first tube is opened.

The test is simple: can your student set up for the daily page in two minutes, and clean up after an Art Hour in five?

Exact wording you can use

- “Your sketchbook isn’t for anyone else. I’ll check that pages happen; I’ll read what you show me.”
- “Show me the thumbnails before the good paper.”
- “What does this label tell you, and what doesn’t it?”
- “Rule first, then the tool. Show me the rule.”

- When a page goes wrong: “Turn past it. Don’t tear it. What did it teach you?”
- Talk-box opening (locked): “Show me a page that went wrong — what did it teach you?”

How to fade your help

The sketchbook: you check that pages happen for the first month; after that, the monthly page review (below) replaces the checking.

The tools: each new material or tool gets taught, then demonstrated back. Your student reads the label aloud, or shows you the cutting routine, before the first use. At 15–16, you stay present for blades and new materials for as long as the book says; at 17–18, once the routine is demonstrated back cleanly and the rules card is posted, they can work independently, and you check the studio at the end.

When to stop talking

Once the rules are taught and shown back, stop repeating them. Point to the posted card instead. A teenager hears the fifth reminder as distrust; the card on the wall is just the studio.

Band moves

15–16. You are present whenever a blade is out and whenever a new material is opened. Labelled copies (a passage copied from a master, labelled “after”) are a good regular Make beat. The studio setup is done together.

17–18. The question log and visual journal spreads start. Your student writes and posts the studio rules. If oils or sprays arrive, the solvent-free rag routine and the outdoor spray rule come first and are demonstrated back before any use. Blades are independent once the routine is shown back.

Practice that actually builds learning

Each try-it uses the shape from The Art Hour. The safety spine there applies throughout; this chapter adds the routines that make it practice.³⁶

In-home — Nine thumbnails

- **Time:** 20 minutes
- **Materials:** Sketchbook; pencil or pen
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The pull:** Nine chances instead of one. The piece gets better before it starts.
- **The skill:** Planning composition cheaply; sketching before polishing

Steps. Before any piece that matters, your student draws nine small compositions, about two inches across, on one page. Each changes just one thing from the one before: the crop, the viewpoint, the eye level, the light, where the darks go. They star two, then enlarge one on good paper.

Stuck → **move**. If all nine look the same, the rule is: change only one thing per thumbnail, and write what changed beside it.

In-home — The ugly-page license

- **Time:** 15 minutes
- **Materials:** Sketchbook; a tool your student dislikes or has never used (a brush pen, charcoal, a stick dipped in ink)
- **Mess / safety:** Charcoal dust: wipe with a damp cloth, never blow it off the page
- **The pull:** Permission to be bad on purpose is surprisingly freeing.
- **The skill:** Separating making from judging; discovering what a tool can do

Steps. Fill a page fast and badly, on purpose, with the new tool. Then write one line: one thing the tool can do that you didn't expect.

Stuck → **move**. Set a three-minute timer for each kind of mark (lines, dots, smears, scrapes). The timer takes the pressure off.

In-home — Read the label

- **Time:** 10 minutes
- **Materials:** Three art products (a marker, a paint, a glue or medium)
- **Mess / safety:** Read only; nothing opens until the label is read
- **The pull:** Knowing more about the label than most adults do
- **The skill:** Sorting materials by what the label says, not by what the package implies

Steps. For each product, your student finds the ACMI seal (AP or CL), any ASTM D-4236 line, and any warnings. They sort the three into home-fine, parent-present, and not-at-home, and say why.

Stuck → **move**. If a CL seal is there, the rule is: read the whole label before opening, every time.
Exit: your student can explain, in one sentence, what D-4236 does and doesn't mean.

In-home — Air and the no-food studio

- **Time:** 10 minutes to set up; seconds to use after that
- **Materials:** A window; a fan; a small table outside the studio area
- **Mess / safety:** Fan placement: blowing out of a window, not just stirring the room
- **The pull:** The corner becomes a real studio.
- **The skill:** Ventilation and hygiene as automatic habits

Steps. Open the window, set the fan to pull air out, and move the snack and drink to the table outside. Wash hands at the end of every session.

Stuck → **move**. If the water bottle keeps drifting onto the art table, move the snack table closer to the door rather than arguing about it.

In-home — Blades and cutting

- **Time:** 10 minutes to learn; part of every cutting session after
- **Materials:** Craft knife with fresh blades; self-healing cutting mat larger than the cut; metal ruler; metal-mesh or Kevlar cut-resistant glove; lidded blade container
- **Mess / safety:** Parent present at 15–16. The holding hand wears the glove and stays behind the blade.
- **The pull:** A real tool, trusted to them
- **The skill:** A safe cutting routine that becomes automatic

Steps. Glove on the holding hand. Ruler held firmly. Cut away from the body, in several light passes rather than one hard one. Used blades straight into the lidded container. Knife closed and stored afterward. Your student demonstrates the routine back to you before the first real cut.¹³

Stuck → **move.** If a cut wanders, the answer is more light passes, not more pressure.

In-home — The labelled copy

- **Time:** 45 minutes
- **Materials:** A public-domain image from a free museum collection; sketchbook
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The pull:** Getting inside a painting you admire
- **The skill:** Learning from masters, with honest credit

Steps. Choose a painting from a free museum collection. The Art Institute of Chicago, for example, offers tens of thousands of public-domain images and suggests a simple credit line.^{37,38,39} Copy one passage, not the whole thing: a hand, a patch of sky, a folded cloth. Write underneath: “after [Artist], [Title],” plus the date and collection.

Stuck → **move.** Copy the big light and dark shapes first, then the lines. **Exit:** every copy is labelled, and no copy is ever filed as original work.

In-home (17–18) — The question log and the visual journal spread

- **Time:** 10 minutes a week for the log; 30 minutes for a spread
- **Materials:** The back pages of the sketchbook; collage scraps; pen
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The pull:** Finding out what you actually care about
- **The skill:** Turning interests into a question strong enough to carry many works

Steps. Once a week, write one “How might I...?” question in the back of the sketchbook. Circle any that come back. When one feels strong, plan a piece on a two-page spread using the four corners: *question / what it looks like / tests / next*. Cite any reference on the spread.

Stuck → **move.** Start from a noun you keep drawing (a window, a hand, a kitchen table) and ask what it stands for.

In-home — The monthly page review

- **Time:** 20 minutes, once a month
- **Materials:** Sticky tabs
- **Mess / safety:** None
- **The pull:** Seeing a month of work at once is usually encouraging.
- **The skill:** Reflecting on your own practice; feeding the archive

Steps. Your student pages through the month and tabs three pages worth returning to, writing on each tab why. Those tabs later feed the archive and the portfolio (Chapter 8).

Stuck → move. You name one page you'd frame, if invited, and your student says why they agree or don't.

In-home (17–18, only if oils or sprays arrive) — Rags and sprays

- **Time:** 10 minutes each, before the first use
- **Materials:** A lidded metal can or bucket of water; safflower oil and two rags; soap; brush-on clear acrylic polymer; an outdoor spot
- **Mess / safety:** No solvents at home. No sprays indoors.
- **The pull:** Oil paint, if your family chooses it, trusted to them
- **The skill:** The two routines that make adult paint safe at home

Oils. Optional, 17–18 only, solvent-free only. Cleanup is the two-rag method one oil-paint maker publishes: wipe the brush on the first rag, work a little safflower oil through it, wipe on the second rag, then wash with soap and water.¹⁴ Rags go into water or the closed can during the session and out of the house at the end of the day. The book keeps turpentine, mineral spirits, and thinners out of the house entirely. Even so, oil-soaked rags are the fire risk, which is why the rag rule comes first. Chapter 4 teaches the painting.

Sprays. Fix drawings with a brush-on clear acrylic polymer instead of a spray.¹³ Skip fixative on sketchbook pages altogether; a sheet of glassine paper between pages protects charcoal. If a spray is truly needed, it happens outdoors, downwind, with you present.

Stuck → move. Tape the rag rule to the can's lid. **Exit:** no oily rag ever left in a pile, and no spray ever opened indoors.

Out-of-home — A pocket-sketchbook afternoon

- **Time:** 1–2 hours
- **Materials:** A small sketchbook; a pen or pencil
- **Mess / safety:** People at a distance only; no close-up studies of a stranger's face; no photographs of strangers; stop if anyone objects
- **The pull:** Drawing in the world feels like a small secret.
- **The skill:** Taking the daily habit out of the house; fast decisions

Steps. Go somewhere with things to look at: a train station, a park, a café, a hardware store parking lot, a church lobby between services. Your student makes ten gesture drawings (fast drawings that

catch the movement or shape of something in under two minutes) of places, objects, and people at a distance. Date the page and write where you were.

Stuck → **move**. Start with things that hold still (benches, bikes, lampposts), then people who are waiting, who move less. At 15–16, sit nearby with your own sketchbook.

Talk box — this chapter

Opening (locked): “Show me a page that went wrong — what did it teach you?”

Use it on Friday, or during the monthly page review. At 17–18, your student can ask it of you about your own warm-up page or daily page. Answer honestly; your wrong pages are useful here.

Follow-ups:

1. **Evidence:** “What were you trying to do?”
2. **Seeing:** “What on the page would you keep?”
3. **Choice:** “What would you change first?”
4. **Next:** “Where does this lead next?”

How to wait. Ask, then count a slow three. After the answer, wait again. The lesson a bad page taught usually comes out in the second answer.

What stuck silence usually means. Most often: the student thinks a bad page is a bad mark on *them*, and showing it feels like handing over evidence against themselves. It can also mean they have no page they’re willing to call “wrong,” which usually means the sketchbook has become a gallery. Treat any wrong page as data, not a verdict, and say so: “A wrong page is information. What’s the information?” Describe something neutral if needed (“The left side of this one is much darker than the right”). “Not today” is allowed.

Don’t say / say instead. Don’t say: “That one’s not so bad.” Say instead: “What did that page find out?”

Reassurance still grades the page. A question about what it found treats the page as an experiment, which is what it was.

Blocked and mixed practice

Blocked, for the new habit. For one week, nine thumbnails before every piece, however small. By day five, most students start the thumbnails without being asked.

Mixed, for choosing when. The next week, thumbnails before a long observation drawing, then the drawing itself across two sessions. Your student practices deciding how much planning a piece needs.

Retrieval. On Friday, without notes: “What does D-4236 on a label mean?” “Where do oily rags go?” “What’s the rule for a new CL product?” One-sentence answers.

One incorrect example to diagnose

Describe this to your student, or make a quick version on scrap. (It is an illustration, not a real student's sketchbook.)

A sketchbook of twenty pages. Every page is finished: a polished drawing, centered, carefully shaded, signed in the corner. No page is dated. There are no thumbnails, no notes, no crossed-out attempts, no studies of the same thing twice. Two pages near the back have ragged edges where pages were torn out.

Ask: **“Where’s the thinking?”**

Let your student find it: no dates, so no record of time; no thumbnails, so no evidence of decisions; torn pages, so missing evidence; every page performed for an audience. It is a portfolio pretending to be a sketchbook. Then: “A reviewer would learn that this person can finish a drawing. They wouldn’t learn how this person thinks. Your sketchbook gets to show that.”

For the student

This section is for you.

Here is the idea. Your sketchbook is your lab, not your gallery. It’s where you try things, get them wrong, and figure out what you think. Nobody is grading it. Your sketchbook has no followers. That’s the point. The portfolio, the part other people see, gets chosen later, from finished work. The sketchbook is where that work gets figured out.

What goes in it. A daily page from life. Nine thumbnails before anything that matters. Ugly pages with new tools. Copies of work you admire, labelled. At 17–18, a question log in the back and planning spreads for bigger pieces. Date every page. Tear none out.

A tiny worked example: labelling a copy. You find an old still life in a museum’s free online collection and copy just the folded white cloth in the corner. Underneath, in the sketchbook, you write the word *after*, then the painter’s name, the painting’s title and date, and the museum, exactly as the collection’s credit line gives them. Then add what you did: *copied the cloth only, 45 min.*

Now anyone reading your sketchbook, including you in two years, knows exactly what’s yours (the looking and the marks) and what isn’t (the composition and the painting). That’s “sign only what you made” in one line.

Reading a label. Before you open any new product:

- Look for the ACMI seal. **AP** means labelled for students in sixth grade or younger. **CL** means for seventh grade and up, and you read the whole label before opening.
- Find “conforms to ASTM D-4236.” It means the product was reviewed and labelled for long-term hazards. It doesn’t mean non-toxic.
- Read the warnings, and do what they say.

Your studio rules, short version. Window open, fan pulling air out. No food or drink at the table. Blades: mat, metal ruler, glove on the holding hand, used blades in the lidded box. No solvents in

the house. Sprays only outside, with a parent. Oily rags (if you ever paint in oils) into water or the closed can, out of the house every day. Poison Control: 1-800-222-1222.

Try 1: nine thumbnails. Before your next piece, draw nine small versions, about two inches across, on one page. Change one thing each time: crop, viewpoint, light, where the darks go. Star two. Make one.

Try 2 (17–18): a visual journal spread. Plan your next bigger piece on two facing pages: your question in one corner, what it might look like in another, a quick materials test in the third, and what comes next in the fourth. Cite any image you looked at.

Explain it back. In one or two sentences: *Why can't a product be called safe just because it says D-4236?*

Challenge: twenty dated pages this month. Daily pages, thumbnails, ugly pages, copies: they all count. At the end of the month, tab the three you'd most want to come back to, and write why on each tab.

Write the rules. If you'd rather not be reminded, write the studio rules card yourself and post it. Rules you wrote are yours.

If it isn't clicking

Snag 1: the daily page keeps getting missed

Some days it happens, most days it doesn't.

Next move. Attach it to something that already happens every day: right after breakfast, or before the phone comes out in the morning. Keep the sketchbook open on the table so starting takes no effort. Shrink it to ten minutes if fifteen is the barrier.

Snag 2: only polished pages

Every page looks finished. Nothing is ever tried and dropped.

Next move. Buy a second, deliberately cheap sketchbook, the kind with thin paper, just for ugly work. It removes the pressure from the good one. Do a week of ugly-page licenses. And look together at the incorrect example above.

Snag 3: studio sprawl

Setup takes twenty minutes because nothing has a place.

Next move. The two-bin rule: the current project in one bin, everything else in the other. The daily-page kit (sketchbook, two pencils, pen, eraser) lives on the table, not in either bin.

Snag 4: eye-rolling at the safety rules

“I know. I know. Rags in the can.”

Next move. Hand over authorship. Your student writes the studio rules card, including the reason for each rule, and posts it. Then point to the card instead of repeating yourself. Teenagers keep rules they wrote, and they explain them better than any parent.

An illustration: the student who won’t show anything

(A composite, not a real family.) A sixteen-year-old draws most evenings but won’t show anyone a single page. The talk box goes nowhere. Asked for a page that went wrong, they say every page went wrong.

The parent stops asking to see pages. The monthly check becomes: “Did pages happen?” Yes. Fine. In the Art Hour, critique moves to other people’s work for a month: a museum postcard, a painting from a free online collection, the parent’s own ugly daily page. On the fourth Friday, without being asked, the student opens the sketchbook to a page of a crumpled paper bag and says, “This one went wrong in an interesting way.” The parent asks what it taught them, and waits.

The sketchbook was always private. Privacy is what made the showing possible.

When to slow down, go ahead, or find another teacher

Slow down on tools if any safety routine isn’t being kept without reminders. Go back to the simpler material for a week. That’s what careful studios do.

Go ahead when there are twenty dated pages in a month, the studio can be set up in two minutes and cleaned up in five, and labels get read without prompting.

Find another teacher when your student wants to use tools and processes this book keeps out of the house: printmaking presses, ceramics kilns, a darkroom. Those belong to community studios and college courses with instructors and proper ventilation. Enrolling is a good next step, not a failure.

Tools, including AI

The full rules are in the AI box in The Art Hour.

One chapter-specific note: you may use an assistant to draft a studio safety checklist for the materials in your house, and then check every line against the federal art-safety guide and the product labels themselves. No AI goes in the sketchbook, ever: no generated images, no prompts pasted in as ideas, no model-written notes. The sketchbook is the one place that is entirely your student’s hand.

What “done enough” looks like

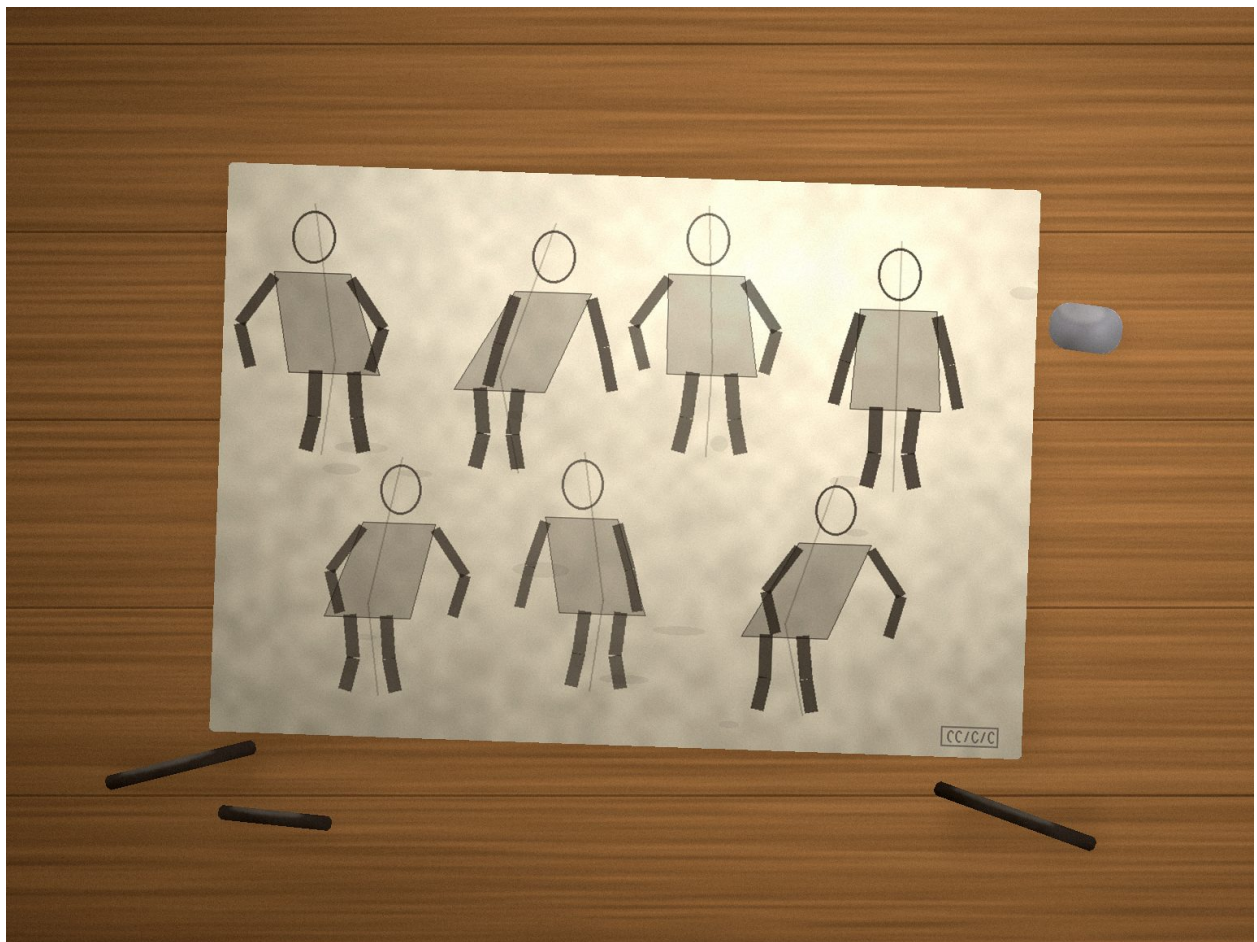
Before moving on to Chapter 3, check:

- ☐ Twenty dated sketchbook pages in a month, including at least one page of nine thumbnails and one ugly page.
- ☐ No pages torn out.
- ☐ Any copies are labelled “after,” with the source.
- ☐ The studio can be set up for the daily page in two minutes and cleaned up after an Art Hour in five, by your student.
- ☐ A studio rules card is posted, with Poison Control on it (written by your student at 17–18).
- ☐ Every new product this month had its label read before opening.
- ☐ Blades live in a lidded container; if oils are in use (17–18), rags are handled right every session.
- ☐ Three pages are tabbed, with a reason on each tab.
- ☐ At 17–18: the question log has at least four questions.

Placement by skill. If the daily page is steady but the safety routines aren’t yet automatic, go on to Chapter 3’s drawing (pencil and paper are gentle) and keep practicing the routines before paint arrives in Chapter 4.

Done enough is not perfect. It is: the pages are happening, the corner works, and the rules are habits.

Chapter 3 — Drawing from life: figure, portrait, and place



Why this matters

Set a chair in the middle of the room and ask your student to draw it. Most people draw the chair they already know: four legs of equal length, a square seat seen from nowhere in particular, a back that stands up straight like a picket fence. Then ask them to hold a pencil at arm's length, close one eye, and compare the height of the back with the width of the seat. Something odd happens. The

seat is a thin slice, not a square. The far legs are shorter than the near ones. The back leans. The chair in the room was never the chair in their head.

That gap between what we know and what we see is the whole subject of this chapter. Drawing from life means drawing from the real thing in front of you (an object, a room, a face in a mirror, a person who has agreed to sit), not from a photograph or from memory. At fifteen to eighteen, it is the skill that separates careful copying from real seeing. It is also the skill art schools ask for by name. Several of the best-known ones say in plain words that they want to see work from direct observation, and at least one warns against work copied from photographs.^{33,34,19} Life drawing isn't nostalgia. It is what reviewers look for, and more importantly, it is how artists learn to see.

Chapter 1 made the case that most drawing trouble is seeing trouble. The research behind that line comes from adults: when people draw badly, the main problem is how they perceive the object, not how steady their hand is.³² That is good news. Perception can be trained. Measuring, squinting, comparing one angle with another — these are learnable moves, and they work at seventeen exactly as they work at forty. A related study found that art students were better than non-art students at drawing and at some visual tasks, in a pattern that looks like trained attention (knowing where and how to look) rather than sharper eyesight.⁴⁰ It was a comparison of two groups at one moment, not a before-and-after study, so read it as an encouraging picture, not a promise.

This chapter covers three subjects that grow out of one habit. **Figure** means the whole human body, drawn clothed, from a person who has said yes. **Portrait** means a face and head, most often your student's own in a mirror, sometimes a family member's. **Place** means rooms, streets, buildings and landscapes, drawn on the spot. The habit underneath all three is the first clause of the book's focus line: **See long before you judge; sketch before you polish; sign only what you made.** Here "see long" means staying with the real subject for forty minutes instead of four. "Sketch before you polish" means gestures, envelopes and value thumbnails before a careful rendering. "Sign only what you made" means a drawing done from life, not a traced photograph wearing a life drawing's clothes.

One more thing belongs at the front. Drawing people involves real people, so consent is part of the craft, not a form to fill in afterwards. Clothed, consenting models only. Ask first; the sitter can stop anytime; show them before you share. Your student will learn to say that sentence as naturally as they learn to sharpen a pencil.

What your student can try today: measure and draw a chair in twenty minutes. What you can learn this week: how to hear a proportion drawn from a rule instead of from a person.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You don't need to draw well to co-teach life drawing. You need to understand what measuring is for, recognize the common wrong turns, and know the consent rules well enough to hold the line kindly.

The everyday picture. Think of a carpenter who measures twice before cutting. Nobody thinks the tape measure is cheating. It is how the carpenter sees the board accurately, because eyes are

easily fooled by length and angle. A pencil held at arm's length is the artist's tape measure. It doesn't replace looking. It checks looking.

The precise picture. Artists who draw from life use a small set of moves again and again:

- **Measuring (comparative measuring).** Hold a pencil at arm's length with the elbow locked, close one eye, and line the tip up with the top of something. Slide your thumb down to mark the bottom. That length becomes a unit — say, the height of a head or the width of a mug. Every other length is compared with it: “The body is about seven of those. The table is two and a half.” The locked elbow matters; if the arm bends, the unit changes.
- **Sight-size.** A related method in which the drawing is placed right beside the subject and drawn at the same apparent size, so you can step back and compare them directly. It is a fine method. Teach comparative measuring first because it works anywhere, including a café or a street corner.
- **Angles against verticals.** Hold the pencil perfectly upright or level and compare the slope of an edge with it. “That roofline drops about this much from level.”
- **The envelope.** The big outer shape of the subject, drawn lightly with straight lines before any detail — like the box a present comes in.
- **Negative space.** The shapes between and around things: the gap between a chair's legs, the space between an arm and a waist. These shapes have no name, so the brain doesn't argue with them, and drawing them correctly makes the object come out correctly.
- **Value before detail.** Value means how light or dark something is. A five-value study (paper white, light, middle, dark, darkest) sorts the big lights and darks before anyone draws an eyelash.
- **Plumb lines.** An imagined vertical line dropped from one point (a chin, a doorframe) to see what lines up under it.

On faces, one measurement does most of the work: on most adult heads, the eyes sit about halfway down the head, not near the top. On a person, the halfway point is a rough check, not a law. The whole point of measuring is to trust the person in front of you over any rule in a book.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear. These are patterns you will see on the page. Each one tells you what to ask next.

1. **The head drawn too big for the body.** This usually means the student drew a symbol of “person,” where heads are important and therefore large. Ask: “How many heads tall is she, if you measure?”
2. **Features floating high on the face.** The eyes sit near the top, leaving a huge chin. This is the most common portrait error at every age. Ask: “Where's the halfway point of the head? Measure it.”
3. **Hard outlines everywhere, nothing in between.** Line before value. The drawing looks like a coloring book. Ask: “Squint. Where are the big darks?”
4. **“I traced a photo for accuracy.”** The student skipped the seeing, which was the point. A tracing can be a labelled study; it is never an observation drawing and never goes in the observation set.
5. **A close-up of a stranger's face, drawn without asking.** This is a consent problem, not a drawing problem. Ask: “Did they know? Would they be all right with it?” Distant, quick

gestures of people in public are ordinary sketchbook practice. Close studies of a stranger's face are not, unless the person has agreed.

Consent, plainly. The rules for this chapter are short, and they don't change by band:

- Clothed, consenting models only. This book prints no nude references and sends no one under eighteen to an adult-only session.
- The consent line, said before every sitting: *"May I draw you for twenty minutes? You can say no or stop anytime; I'll show you before I share it."*
- Distant gestures in public are fine; close face studies of strangers need a yes; no photographs of strangers for portfolio work.
- Any open studio or community figure session: you check the venue's age rules and model policy first. Policies vary from place to place, and there is no single rule to point to.¹⁰
- If a drawing of a person will be entered in a contest or posted, you need that person's permission first (and a parent's signature if the sitter is a minor). Chapter 5 covers releases in detail.

Your parent warm-up. Sit as the model for a ten-minute gesture session. Your student draws ten quick poses of you (thirty seconds to two minutes each) while you hold still, stretch, lean on a broom, sit on a stool. You'll learn in ten minutes what a sitter needs: breaks, warmth, a clock you can see, and a say in what happens to the drawings. You'll also notice how hard it is to hold even a simple pose for two minutes. Afterwards, look at the drawings together only if your student offers. You modelled; that was your job.

How to teach it this week

The shape of the week. Keep the five beats of The Art Hour — See, Sketch, Make, Critique, File — and the student in the chair. A good first week in this chapter is three Hours: measuring on Monday, the first session of a mirror self-portrait on Wednesday, the second session plus a short critique on Friday. The daily page carries the chapter on other days (hands, a corner of the kitchen, the chair again). If the weather cooperates, a Saturday afternoon of people-in-the-park gestures makes a fine outing.

The first try-it: measure a chair. Put one ordinary chair where the light is good. Your student sits eight to ten feet away with a board, paper and a pencil. Here is how to open the See beat:

"Five minutes of looking before you draw. No drawing yet. Just measure."

Show the move once, on yourself, without paper: arm straight, elbow locked, one eye closed, pencil tip at the top of the chair back, thumb at the seat. Then hand the pencil over. Say:

"Pick one unit. Everything else gets compared with it."

Let your student measure silently. If they look up at you for approval, look at the chair.

The Sketch beat. Light tick marks only, no lines: the top of the back, the seat, the floor, the left and right edges. Then the envelope: a few straight lines that hold the whole chair. Say:

"Ticks before lines. You can move a tick. A dark line argues back."

The Make beat. Now the drawing proper, twenty minutes or so. The student draws the negative shapes between the legs and rungs before the legs themselves. They check every major angle against a level or upright pencil. Say little. If you say anything, make it one of these:

“Measure it — trust the person in front of you, not the rule.” (It works on chairs too.)

“Which is longer, that leg or the gap beside it?”

“Squint. What’s darkest?”

One good question. Near the end, ask only: “Where did the real chair surprise you?” Almost every student will say the seat was thinner than they expected, or the far legs were shorter. That is the lesson, arriving in their own words.

The consent line, taught as craft. Before the first figure or portrait session with another person, have your student practise the consent line aloud, in their own words, until it sounds natural. Then they ask the sitter, not you. Say to your student:

“Ask first; they can stop anytime. Tell them what the drawing is for.”

For a mirror self-portrait, the student is both artist and sitter, which is why it is always available and always consenting. It is the best portrait subject your student will ever have: patient, free, available at midnight.

How to fade your help. In the first session, you set up the chair and say the opening lines. In the second, your student sets up and runs the See beat aloud for you (“Five minutes, just measuring”). By the third, you should be passing through with a cup of tea and one question. When you hear your student murmur “that’s two and a half heads” to nobody in particular, stop talking. Your job is now protecting the time and filing the dated page.

When to stop talking. During the Make beat. Measuring is quiet work. If you notice a floating eye line, write “eye line?” on a sticky note for yourself and bring it to the Critique beat as a question. The rescue order from The Art Hour applies: ask, wait, hint, short demonstration on scrap, then hand the pencil back. In life drawing, the demonstration is almost never a drawing. It is you holding up a pencil to show the move, then giving the pencil back.

Try this sentence when frustration spikes. Life drawing produces sharp frustration at this age, because the student can see exactly how their drawing is wrong. “Your eye is ahead of your hand right now. That’s what the next forty drawings are for.” Then leave the room for five minutes.

Band moves

15–16. Still life, hands and feet, a mirror self-portrait over two sessions, measuring from furniture and rooms, a family gesture session with the consent line, and places (a room corner, a porch, a view from a window). The parent is in the room for the first gesture session with a family member, mainly to help the model take breaks. Graphite and charcoal are the core media. Charcoal makes dust; the dust rules are in the safety spine in The Art Hour and in Chapter 2. If a finished charcoal drawing needs fixing, a brush-on clear acrylic polymer works; any spray goes outdoors under the spine’s rules.¹³

17–18. Long poses (twenty to forty minutes, with breaks) from a clothed family member or friend who has agreed; a portrait sitting with a written consent card (sit, stop, share); perspective of streets and interiors checked by measuring; and community clothed-model sessions only after you have checked the venue. A student aiming at art school starts building an **observation set** now: three to five of their strongest direct-observation drawings (a self-portrait, a figure, a still life, a place), gathered and refreshed through senior year. Chapter 8 shows how that set fits into a portfolio.

Placing by skill, not birthday. A fifteen-year-old who has drawn from life for years may be ready for long poses and portrait sittings. An eighteen-year-old coming to drawing late starts with the chair, the hand and the mirror, and that is exactly right. Nobody in this chapter is behind.

Practice that actually builds learning

Practice in this chapter moves in a clear order. First, **blocked practice**: one move repeated until it feels ordinary — a week of measuring, or a week of five-value studies. Then **mixed practice**: a session that asks for more than one move and lets your student decide which to use when — a gesture warm-up followed by a long pose, say. Along the way, quick **retrieval**: “Where does the eye line usually fall?” without looking it up. And one incorrect example to diagnose, which is often where the idea finally settles.⁴¹

In-home — The long still life

- **Time**: three 45-minute sessions across a week
- **Materials**: three to five objects with different surfaces (a mug, an onion, a folded cloth, a glass bottle); one lamp; good drawing paper; graphite or charcoal; tape
- **Mess / safety**: low with graphite; charcoal dust handled by the spine’s rules (tap into a bin, wet-wipe, never blow)
- **The pull**: it is the first drawing many students ever stay with long enough to be surprised by
- **The skill**: composition, value and edges in three separate passes; staying power

Steps. Session one is composition and big shapes: measure, tick, envelope, negative spaces. Session two is value: squint, block in the five values, darkest dark first. Session three is edges and detail, only where the eye will land. Photograph the drawing at the end of each session. Those three photos are process evidence of exactly the kind AP portfolios and admissions readers look for.^{17,33}

Stuck → move. If the setup keeps changing between sessions, tape around the base of every object and mark the lamp’s position on the table.

Exit. A resolved drawing plus three dated process photos.

In-home — Mirror self-portrait

- **Time**: 60–90 minutes across two sessions
- **Materials**: a mirror fixed in place (a propped bathroom mirror or a large hand mirror clamped to a stack of books); one lamp from the side; paper on a board; pencil or charcoal

- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** the one sitter who never cancels, never complains, and can't object to the result
- **The skill:** measuring a face; seeing shadow shapes instead of features

Steps. Fix the mirror and the lamp so neither moves between sessions; mark the chair's position with tape. Measure the head: top to chin. Mark halfway — that's roughly where the eyes sit. Mark the bottom of the nose and the line of the mouth by measuring, not guessing. Block the light side and the shadow side as two big shapes. Only in the second session do features get detail, and then only as shapes of light and dark.

Stuck → move. If the face looks like a mask, stop drawing features entirely for ten minutes and draw only shadow shapes: the dark under the brow, the shadow side of the nose, the dark under the lower lip.

Exit. A self-portrait drawn from observation. This one is portfolio-eligible and belongs in the observation set.

In-home — Hands and feet

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** a mirror (optional), pencil, sketchbook
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** hands are the famous hard part, and they're attached to you
- **The skill:** simplifying complex forms into boxes and wedges before detail

Steps. Ten 2-minute studies of the non-drawing hand in different poses: flat, fist, holding a cup, pointing, relaxed. Then one 15-minute study. Draw the box of the palm first, then the fingers as blocks, then the curves. Feet the same way, from the student's own feet, socks allowed.

Stuck → move. Fingers like sausages usually mean the student drew each finger as an outline. Draw the negative spaces between the fingers instead.

Exit. One convincing hand page.

In-home — Clothed family gesture

- **Time:** 20 minutes
- **Materials:** newsprint or cheap paper; charcoal or a soft pencil; a timer
- **Mess / safety:** low; the model has a chair and a clock nearby
- **The pull:** it's fast, loose and a bit ridiculous, which is exactly why it works
- **The skill:** **gesture** (a fast drawing of a pose's movement) and the **line of action** (the one curve that runs through a pose)

Steps. The student asks with the consent line. The model, fully clothed, takes ten 30-second poses and five 2-minute poses: reaching, twisting, leaning on a counter, sitting sideways. The student draws the line of action first, then the big masses. No faces, no fingers, no detail. The model can stop anytime.

Stuck → **move**. Stiff stick figures mean the student is drawing parts. “One line for the whole pose first — how is the body leaning?”

Exit. Figures that lean, twist and stand. Offer the model a look before anything leaves the sketchbook.

Out-of-home — People in public, respectfully

- **Time**: 30 minutes on site
- **Materials**: a small sketchbook that fits in a pocket; pen or pencil
- **Mess / safety**: low; choose a public place where sketching is ordinary (a park, a station waiting area, a café, a church lobby before a service)
- **Venue rules**: ask the café or building if you’re unsure; people at a distance only; no photographs of strangers; stop at once if anyone objects
- **The pull**: nobody knows you’re drawing them, as long as you stay far away and quick
- **The skill**: gesture under real conditions; seeing whole figures in seconds

Steps. Sit where you can see people at a distance. Draw quick gestures only — ten seconds to a minute each. Start with people who are waiting (queues, benches, bus stops); they move less. When someone moves, leave the drawing unfinished and start another. Fill a page.

Stuck → **move**. If nerves win, draw the place first (benches, trees, the counter) and add people as small shapes within it.

Exit. A page of ten or more gestures, and nobody bothered.

Out-of-home — Perspective checked by sight

- **Time**: 45 minutes
- **Materials**: pencil, sketchbook or board; a ruler optional
- **Mess / safety**: low; pick a safe spot off the pavement, or a church or library interior where drawing is welcome (ask first)
- **Venue rules**: in any building, ask before you sit and draw; many welcome it
- **The pull**: buildings hold still, and the lines really do converge
- **The skill**: finding eye level; measuring converging angles instead of guessing them

Steps. Choose a street corner or a long interior (a nave, a hallway, a library aisle). Find **eye level** (where a horizontal line at your own eye height would cross the scene) by holding the pencil level at eye height. Draw that line lightly. Measure the angle of each major edge against the level pencil. Notice that edges above eye level slope down toward it and edges below slope up.

Stuck → **move**. If the drawing looks like it’s falling over, check the verticals first. In ordinary street views, upright edges stay upright.

Exit. Lines that converge believably and a student who can point to eye level.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “Where did you look longest — and what did you find there that you didn’t expect?”

At 17–18, your student may ask the opening of themselves, or chair the talk box for a sibling or friend who drew alongside.

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Seeing and evidence:** “How did you measure that?”
2. **Seeing:** “Where’s the lightest light and darkest dark?”
3. **Process:** “What did you put down first, and would you do it in the same order next time?”
4. **Choice and revision:** “What would you correct first?”
5. **Consent and craft:** “What did the model need from you?”

How to wait. Ask, then count a slow three in your head before you say anything else. It’s a classroom habit rather than something art research has tested, and it still helps. Look at the drawing, or at the chair, not at your student. That tells them the subject is the point, not their answer.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. Most often, your student sees the flaw clearly and fears that naming it will confirm a verdict. Sometimes the question sounded like a verdict already. Sometimes they’re hunting for the “right” art word (envelope? plumb line?) and don’t want to guess. Sometimes your face spoke before the question did. Name one thing that genuinely works — “the angle of that roofline is exactly right” — and ask again, smaller: “Just point to where you looked longest.” “Not today” is an allowed answer.

Don’t say / say instead. Don’t say: “The eyes are too high.” Say instead: “Let’s measure where halfway is, on you and on the drawing.”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked. A week of five-value studies: every day, one object under one lamp, three small thumbnails using only five values. Hold the value scale up to the object and match. Same object, three lights, three days. The point is that the student stops seeing “white mug” and starts seeing “value 2, value 4, value 5.”

Mixed. One session, two tempos: fifteen minutes of 1-minute gestures from a clothed family member (or from the mirror), then a 25-minute long pose of the same person in one position. The student decides where measuring earns its time and where speed matters more. At 17–18, add a portrait sitting on the same day as a perspective drawing, and let the student plan which comes first.

Retrieval (two minutes, any day). “Without looking, where do the eyes usually sit on a head?” “What does ‘envelope’ mean?” “Say the consent line.” Quick and low-stakes, then back to drawing.

One incorrect example to diagnose

This is an illustration, not a real student’s work. Describe it or draw it yourself on scrap:

Two portraits of the same woman, side by side. The first is built from a textbook proportion diagram: perfectly symmetrical, eyes exactly halfway, nose exactly one eye-width, mouth centred, neck a neat cylinder. It is tidy and smooth. The second is a measured drawing from life: one eye slightly higher than the other, the nose longer than the diagram says, the jaw heavier on one side, the neck leaning because she is turning.

Ask: “Which one is her?”

Most students will say the second, then pause. The first drawing looks more “correct.” That is the lesson. A proportion rule describes an average that nobody is. The measured drawing is a portrait of one person. Rules can serve as a rough check — “about halfway” — but the person in front of you wins every argument. Let your student put a sticky note on the first drawing that says why.

The daily page this week

On days without an Art Hour, the daily page (Chapter 2) carries the chapter. Suggestions: the chair from a new angle; your own hand holding your phone; the view from the kitchen table, eye level marked; a five-value thumbnail of a lamp-lit corner; three 1-minute gestures of a family member who agreed while they wash dishes. Dated, private by default.

For the student

This section is for you.

Drawing from life means drawing from the real thing in front of you: an object, a room, your own face in a mirror, a person who has agreed to sit. Not a photo. Not memory. The real thing.

Here’s the honest reason it matters. Your brain has a stored picture of almost everything — “chair,” “eye,” “hand” — and when you draw, it hands you that picture instead of the one in front of you. The stored version is always a bit wrong. Measuring is how you catch it. It isn’t cheating, and it isn’t a beginner’s crutch. Experienced artists measure constantly. So do carpenters.

A tiny worked example: the eye line.

1. Sit in front of a mirror with a lamp to one side.
2. Hold a pencil at arm’s length, elbow locked, one eye closed.
3. Line the tip up with the top of your head. Slide your thumb to your chin. That’s one head.
4. Now find halfway. On most adult heads, the eyes sit about there — lower than most people draw them.
5. Check your own face. Maybe your eyes sit a little above halfway, maybe a little below. Whatever you find, draw that. The rule is a check. You’re the subject.

Mark it with a light tick before you draw any eye. Ticks before lines, always. A tick is easy to move. A dark line isn’t.

Value before detail. Squint at your face in the mirror. The detail disappears and you’re left with big shapes of light and dark. Draw those first — the shadow side of the face, the dark under the brow, the shadow under the chin. Eyelashes come last, if at all.

The consent line, in your words. Before you draw anyone but yourself, ask. Something like: “May I draw you for twenty minutes? You can say no or stop anytime, and I’ll show you before I share it.” Say it your way, but keep all three parts: the ask, the stop, the share. In public, draw people only at a distance, quickly, and stop if anyone minds. No photos of strangers for your portfolio.

Try 1. A 60-minute mirror self-portrait over two days. Tape the chair’s position and don’t move the lamp between sessions. Day one: measure, envelope, big shadow shapes. Day two: features, as shapes of light and dark.

Try 2. Ten 2-minute gestures of a family member who has agreed. Line of action first — the one curve through the whole pose. No faces. Thank your model and offer to show them.

Explain it back. In two or three sentences, write in your sketchbook margin: why does measuring beat a rule of proportion? (Hint: think about whose face you’re drawing.)

Challenge. One long observation piece a month — at least ninety minutes across sessions, from life, with a process photo at the end of each session. By the end of a year that’s twelve drawings, and your best three to five become your observation set, the part of a portfolio art schools most often ask for.

A few honest things. Your first self-portrait will probably look older, sadder or more surprised than you are. Almost everyone’s does; the cause is usually eyes placed too high and shadows drawn too dark around them. Measure again. People in public won’t notice you nearly as much as you think. Hands are hard for everyone, including the artists in museums. And if a drawing goes wrong, keep it. Next month’s version will be better, and you’ll want the pair.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1: Proportions keep drifting. Heads are too big, legs too short, the chair’s seat is a square every time.

Next move: Tick marks before any line, for a week. The student measures and places six to ten ticks and shows you the ticks before drawing a single contour. If drift continues, go back to one unit and compare everything aloud: “The seat is one-third of the back.” Speaking the comparison slows the eye down.

Diagnostic 2: Overworked, muddy drawings. Every drawing ends grey and smeared, with no clear lights.

Next move: A timer and a rule: stop at 45 minutes, no matter what. Then, for a week, five-value studies only, where the paper white must stay white. At 17–18, add a kneaded eraser for lifting lights rather than more rubbing.

Diagnostic 3: No models. Nobody in the family wants to sit, or the student feels awkward asking.

Next move: The mirror, hands, feet and places are always available. For family sessions, keep them short (ten minutes), offer a chair and a show, and pay in snacks. Siblings often agree to pose while doing something they’d be doing anyway: reading, gaming, playing an instrument.

Diagnostic 4: Nervous in public. The student freezes in the park or won't take the sketchbook out.

Next move: Start far away with people who are waiting. Draw the place first and add people as tiny shapes. Bring a sibling or parent to sketch too, so it's a shared activity rather than a performance. A local sketch group can also help; drawing beside other artists makes it ordinary.

When to slow down. If the eye line is still floating after three self-portraits, stay with mirrors and measuring for another two weeks. Portrait proportions reward patience.

When to go ahead. When the student measures without being reminded, keeps whites clean in a value study, and can finish a three-session still life without losing the setup, move on to the next chapter and keep one long observation drawing a month going.

When to find another teacher. When the student wants long clothed-figure sessions, anatomy instruction, or cast drawing beyond what you can demonstrate, a community drawing class or a dual-enrollment Drawing I course is a gift, not a failure. For a 17- or 18-year-old attending a community figure session, you check the venue first: age rules, clothed-model policy, instructor. Chapter 10 has a fit checklist. Keep corrections kind and specific: "Let's measure where halfway is" is always better than "that's wrong."

A composite illustration, not a real family: a seventeen-year-old with a strong digital portfolio of characters drawn from screens, and almost no work from life. The first chair drawing is humbling. The family's move is small and steady: one mirror self-portrait and one long still life a month, a Saturday gesture page at the park, a community drawing class in the spring. By fall, the observation set has four pieces in it, and the student's digital work starts to look different — heavier, better lit, more believable — because the eye has changed.

Tools, including AI

The physical tools for this chapter are simple and cheap: graphite pencils (a range from hard to soft is nice, one 2B is enough), vine and compressed charcoal, a kneaded eraser, newsprint for gestures, better paper for long drawings, a drawing board and clips, a skewer or knitting needle for measuring (straighter than most pencils), a mirror, a lamp with a movable head, and a pocket sketchbook for outings. A handheld viewfinder — a small card with a rectangular window cut in it — helps frame places.

For AI, the rules in the AI box in *The Art Hour* apply here unchanged. One note specific to this chapter: no faces into AI tools, ever — not your student's, not a family model's, not a stranger's — and no generated "reference poses" behind any portfolio drawing. A pose that nobody held isn't observation, and a drawing made from one can't go in the observation set.

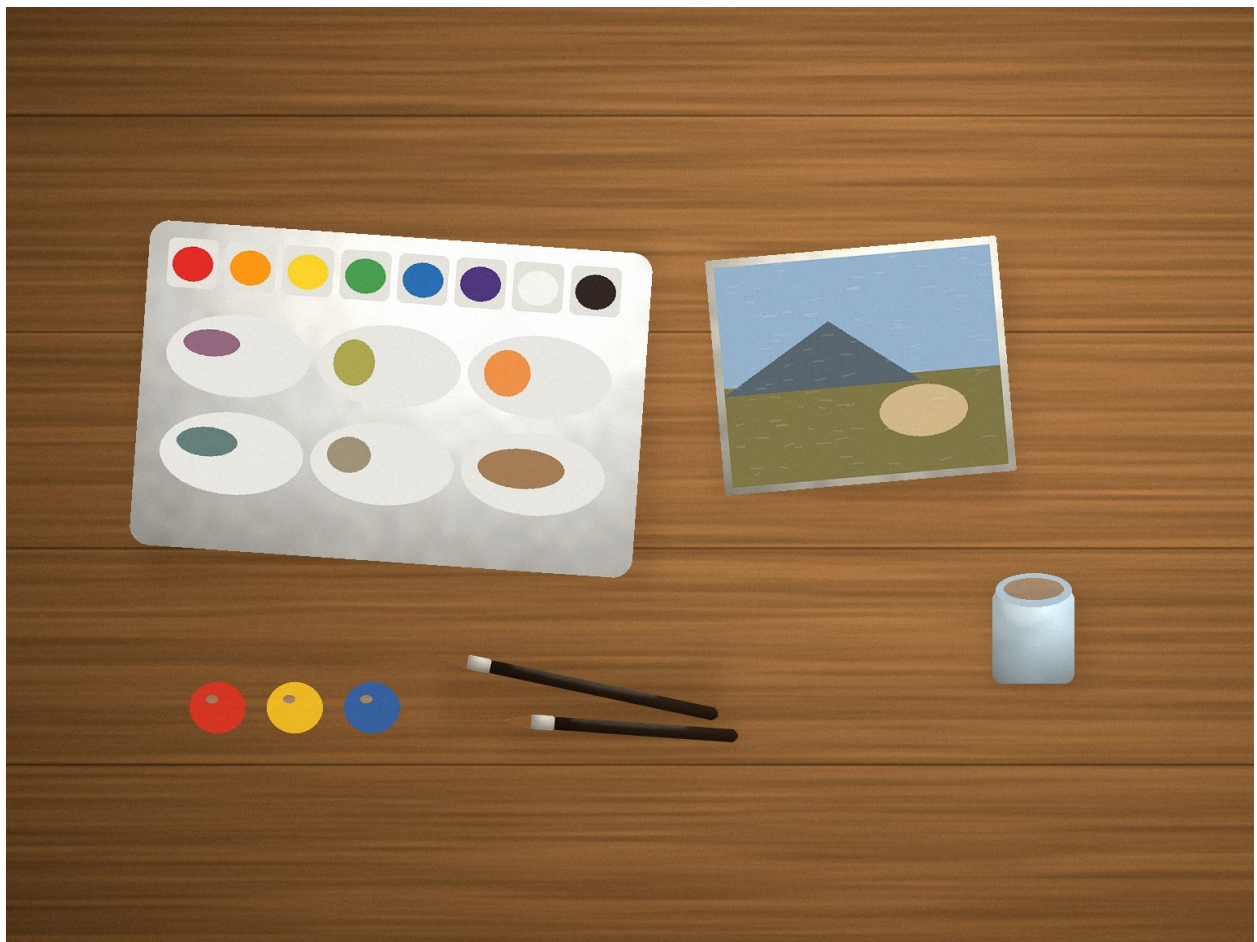
What "done enough" looks like

Before leaving this chapter for good (you'll keep returning to it), check these with your student. They don't need to be flawless. They need to be steady.

- ☐ A resolved mirror self-portrait, drawn from observation over at least two sessions.
- ☐ A page of clothed gestures from a family member who agreed, plus a page of people in public at a distance.
- ☐ A three-session still life with a dated process photo from each session.
- ☐ One perspective drawing from life with eye level marked.
- ☐ One convincing hand page.
- ☐ The student measures without reminders and can explain why measuring beats a rule.
- ☐ Consent noted for every drawing of another person, and the student can say the consent line in their own words.
- ☐ The talk box used with the locked opening at least twice, with the student answering by pointing at the drawing and the subject.
- ☐ At 17–18: a long pose or portrait sitting with a consent card on file, the first pieces of an observation set gathered, and any community figure session attended only after you checked the venue.

Place by skill, not birthday. A student new to life drawing may live in this chapter for two months; one who arrives with experience may move through in three weeks and keep the monthly long drawing going. Both are on track.

Chapter 4 — Painting: watercolor, gouache, and acrylic



Why this matters

Watch a teenager paint for the first time in a while and you'll see a particular kind of struggle. The drawing underneath was careful. Then the brush arrives, and everything the student knows about drawing seems to leave the room. The colors go dull. The lights disappear. They add more paint to fix it, and the painting gets darker and muddier, and at some point they put the brush down and

say, “I’m just not a painter.”

They are, or they can be. What they’ve met is the central fact of painting: paint is a material with its own habits, and every medium asks for a different order of work. Watercolor must go light to dark, because you can’t paint white back in. Gouache can cover its mistakes, but it dries lighter or darker than it looks wet. Acrylic dries fast and builds in layers, which is wonderful until it dries on the brush. None of this is talent. It’s knowledge, and it can be learned in weeks.

Painting is also where many teenagers discover patience. A drawing can be rushed to the end. A painting punishes rushing — the wet passage bleeds into the next, the overworked corner turns to mud — and rewards the student who stops, waits for a layer to dry, looks, and decides. That is the focus line in action: **See long before you judge; sketch before you polish; sign only what you made.** In painting, “see long” means reading value and color before mixing. “Sketch before you polish” means thumbnails, value studies and small color notes before the good paper. “Sign only what you made” means the painting’s decisions are the student’s, start to finish.

This chapter teaches three water-based paints well. **Watercolor** is transparent paint thinned with water; the white of the paper provides the lights. **Gouache** (say “gwash”) is opaque watercolor: flat, matte, able to cover what’s beneath it. **Acrylic** is a water-based paint that dries fast into a flexible plastic film and can be layered thick or thin. Together they cover almost everything a high-school painter needs, and all three clean up with water.

For students 17 to 18 who are ready, the chapter also offers an optional unit in oil paint, done **solvent-free**, which means cleaning up with a drying oil and soap instead of turpentine or mineral spirits. No solvents come into the house under this book’s rules, and oily rags have a rule of their own. Many families will skip oils entirely, and a student can have a full painting life without them.

What your student can try today: a five-step value scale in one watercolor. What you can learn this week: how to hear the difference between a painting that went muddy from overmixing and one that went dull from graying with white.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You don’t need to paint to co-teach painting. You need a working grasp of value and color, a sense of how each medium behaves, and the safety habits cold.

The everyday picture. Think of cooking. Watercolor is a sauce you can’t un-reduce: once it’s too dark, it stays dark, so you start light and build. Gouache is a paste you can spread over the top of a mistake. Acrylic is a quick-drying glaze you build in thin layers, each one dry before the next. Oils, if they ever arrive, are a slow braise: they stay workable for a long time, and you clean the pot differently.

The precise picture. Painters describe any color with three questions:

- **Value:** how light or dark it is. This does most of the work. A painting with the values right and the colors odd still reads; a painting with gorgeous colors and muddled values doesn’t.
- **Hue and temperature:** which color family it belongs to (red, yellow-green) and which way it leans — toward the orange side (painters say “warm”) or the blue side (“cool”). These are

painters' words for a color's direction, not claims about mood.

- **Intensity (also called chroma or saturation):** how vivid or muted it is. A tomato is intense red; a brick is a muted one.

Two ideas follow from those three. First, a **limited palette** — three primaries (a red, a yellow, a blue) plus white — teaches mixing faster than a 24-tube set, because the student has to find every color instead of squeezing it out. Colors mixed from the same few tubes also tend to sit together naturally. Second, to make a color less intense without making it chalky, painters mix in a little of its **complement**, the color opposite it on the color wheel (red with green, blue with orange, yellow with violet). Adding white makes a color lighter and paler; adding black often makes it dirty. The complement mutes it cleanly.

Each medium has one habit worth memorizing:

- **Watercolor:** light to dark. Plan and protect the whites before you start (“reserving” them), because the paper is the only white you’ll get.
- **Gouache:** mix the biggest color area first, and mix plenty; remixing the same color later is hard. It dries a little differently from how it looks wet, so test on scrap.
- **Acrylic:** keep it wet on the palette (a mist of water helps) and wash brushes before paint dries in them. Dried acrylic in a brush is permanent.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear.

1. **Mud.** A brownish-gray sludge across the painting. This usually means overmixing on the paper, or too many colors in one mix. Ask: “How many tubes went into this color?”
2. **Chalky shadows.** Shadows that look pale and powdery. This usually means the student grayed the color with white instead of darkening and muting it with the complement. Ask: “What’s the opposite of this color? Try a touch of that.”
3. **No lights left in a watercolor.** Every part of the paper has been painted over. This usually means the whites weren’t planned. Ask: “Where were the whitest whites? Could they have stayed paper?”
4. **“I’ll use turpentine, because real painters do.”** Some painters do; this book doesn’t, at home, at any age. The oils unit below is solvent-free by design.
5. **A balled-up oily rag in the bin.** A fire risk, not a housekeeping issue. Rags soaked in linseed oil or solvent can heat up and catch fire on their own.¹³ The rag rule below is non-negotiable.

Safety, pointing back. The safety spine in *The Art Hour* covers labels, air, food, powders and sprays in full, and Chapter 2 turns it into studio habits. For painting, three points matter most. Read every label before opening, and remember that a “conforms to ASTM D-4236” line means the product was reviewed and labelled for chronic hazards, not that it’s harmless.¹² Use premixed paints rather than dry pigment powders, and don’t point brushes with your lips.¹³ And keep the air moving even with water-based paints: some acrylics contain small amounts of ammonia or formaldehyde, which can irritate sensitive people.¹³

Your parent warm-up. Paint a five-step value scale in one color. Any color, any water-based paint. Five boxes: paper white, light, middle, dark, darkest. It will take ten minutes and you’ll get the middle wrong the first time; almost everyone does. Squint at it and fix one box. That scale is the whole secret of painting, and you now know it better than many beginners.

How to teach it this week

The shape of the week. The five beats of The Art Hour hold. A good first week: watercolor washes and a one-color value study on Monday, gouache color notes on Wednesday, a limited-palette mixing chart on Friday. Daily pages carry the chapter: a quick watercolor thumbnail of the breakfast table, a value study of a window. One outing every week or two: a small watercolor from life, outdoors.

The first try-it: washes and a one-color value study. Set out a watercolor set, one round brush (a size 8 or 10 holds plenty of water), cold-press watercolor paper (it has a slight texture and handles water well), two jars of water (one to rinse, one clean), and paper towels. Tape the paper down on all four sides to a board so it stays flat.

Open the See beat:

“Before we paint, look at the lamp and the mug for five minutes. Where are the whitest whites? Those stay paper.”

The Sketch beat. Three small value thumbnails in pencil — three values only (paper, middle, dark). Say:

“Decide the darks before you touch the paint.”

The Make beat. Three washes first, each on a small strip: a flat wash (even color across), a graded wash (dark to light, adding water each stroke), and a wet-into-wet wash (paint dropped into wet paper so it blooms). Then the study: the mug in one color, five values, light to dark.

Wording that helps, sparingly:

“Light to dark.”

“More water, tilt the board, less fiddling.”

“Let it dry. Then decide.”

That last one does more work than any correction. Most watercolor trouble comes from touching a wash while it’s drying.

One good question. Near the end: “Where did the paint surprise you?” Watercolor always surprises — a bloom, a hard edge, a granulating blue. The student’s answer tells you what they noticed, and noticing is the skill.

How to fade your help. Session one, you set up the kit and say the opening. Session two, the student sets up and says “light to dark” aloud before starting. By session three, you shouldn’t be needed for anything but a timer and the question. When your student walks away from a wet wash to let it dry without being told, stop talking.

When to stop talking. While the paint is wet. A wet passage is a time-sensitive decision, and a comment at that moment steals it. Note anything on a sticky note and bring it to the Critique beat as a question. If the student is truly stuck, the rescue order from The Art Hour applies: ask, wait, hint, a short demonstration on scrap, and hand the brush back. In painting, the demo is usually a two-inch swatch showing a mix, never a stroke on their painting.

Useful sentences for the week.

- “Mix the biggest area first.”
- “Gray it with its opposite.”
- “Stop while it’s fresh.”
- “Which passage is working? Protect it.”

Band moves

15–16. Watercolor, gouache and acrylic, on small supports (postcard to 9 × 12 inches). Value scales, mixing charts, gouache color notes, a limited palette, acrylic in layers, a small watercolor outdoors. You’re in the room the first time a new paint or product comes out, and you read the label together. Oils wait, or happen in a community class you’ve checked.

17–18. All of the above, plus a **series of five** (one motif painted five ways, changing one thing each time), **alla prima** painting (a painting finished wet in one sitting), larger supports if the student wants them, and the optional solvent-free oils unit below — once the rag rule is a habit, not a rule.

Placing by skill. A careful 16-year-old who has painted for years may be ready for a series of five. An 18-year-old picking up a brush for the first time starts with washes and scales. That’s the right place for them, not a step back.

The optional oils unit (17–18, solvent-free only)

Oil paint is pigment ground in a drying oil, usually linseed. It dries slowly, by taking in oxygen rather than evaporating, so it stays workable for hours and blends beautifully. Historically, painters thinned it and cleaned brushes with turpentine or mineral spirits. Those solvents give off vapors and are flammable; the federal art-safety guide lists turpentine and mineral spirits among solvents to avoid.¹³ This book’s rule is simple: **no solvents at home**. The oils unit uses a solvent-free method instead.

Is your student ready? Three yes answers first. They’ve done a limited palette and a layered acrylic painting and can explain their mixing. They set up and clean the studio in five minutes without reminders. They’ve kept the rag rule (below) on a trial run with an empty can, without being reminded, for two weeks. If any answer is no, gouache and acrylic keep going and oils wait. Nothing is lost; the skills carry straight over.

The setup. A small set of oil colors (a limited palette again: a red, a yellow, a blue, a white); a bottle of safflower oil sold for painting; two rags; a small lidded jar for the cleaning oil; bar soap; a palette knife; a small panel or canvas board; and — before any paint is opened — a closed, lidded metal can or a jar of water for rags. Window open, fan pulling air out, no food in the room. Read every tube’s label; adult materials often carry the CL seal, which means read the whole label before opening.¹²

The method (the paint maker’s own advice). One oil-paint maker, Gamblin, publishes a solvent-free method that this book follows. In the maker’s words and practice: wipe excess paint from the brush with one rag, dip the brush in safflower oil, then wipe the oil and remaining pigment out with a second rag, and carry on painting. After the session, wash brushes with soap and water.¹⁴

The same maker advises against using mineral oil or cooking oil to clean brushes during painting, because non-drying oils can interfere with drying, and describes its solvent-free materials as best suited to direct, one-sitting painting — *alla prima* — rather than thin washes or glazing.¹⁴ That fits this book well: the oils unit is a series of small direct studies, not a layered old-master technique. Where the maker suggests a small amount of solvent for thin underpainting, this book skips it. Paint straight from the tube, thinly where you need to, and stay direct.

If paint feels too stiff, add a drop of safflower oil, not a solvent. For hands, soap and water; the federal guide suggests vegetable or baby oil or artists' soap to remove paint from skin rather than solvents.¹³

Water-mixable oils. Some makers sell oil paints formulated to be thinned and cleaned with water. That's the makers' description of their product; read the label on the tubes you buy and follow it.⁴² The rag rule still applies, because the rags still carry drying oil.

The rag rule. Oily rags go into a jar of water or a closed metal safety can at the end of every session, and out of the house — into the outdoor trash — the same day. Never in a pile, never in a kitchen bin, never in the laundry basket. Rags soaked in linseed oil or solvent can heat up and catch fire on their own; the federal guide recommends a covered container that doesn't let air in.¹³ The paint maker gives the same advice: at minimum a safety can, and better, rags soaked in water in a jar and put out with the household trash.¹⁴ Tape the rule to the lid. At 17–18 the student owns this job; you check it on your way past, every time, without making it a speech.

Varnish and sprays. None needed for studies. If a finished acrylic or oil painting ever needs varnishing, choose a brush-on product and follow the safety spine; any spray goes outdoors, downwind, with you present.¹³

Practice that actually builds learning

Practice in painting moves from **blocked** (one move, repeated — a week of one-color value studies) to **mixed** (a single session asking the student to choose: value study or color note first? which medium for this subject?). Retrieval is quick: “What's the complement of orange?” “Which medium goes light to dark?” And one incorrect example to diagnose, below.⁴³

In-home — Value-and-chroma chart

- **Time:** 45 minutes
- **Materials:** gouache or acrylic; white; the color's complement; grid paper or a ruled sheet
- **Mess / safety:** low to medium; water jar and paper towels; wash brushes before acrylic dries
- **The pull:** it turns “I can't mix” into a chart you can point at
- **The skill:** separating value from intensity; mixing on purpose

Steps. Pick one color. Across a row, make it lighter with white in steps, then darker (with a darker neighboring color, not black). Down a column, mute it step by step with its complement. Paint each swatch big enough to judge — at least an inch.

Stuck → move. Swatches too small to read: redo at double size.

Exit. A chart taped in the sketchbook that the student uses when mixing.

In-home — Limited palette

- **Time:** 45 minutes
- **Materials:** three primaries plus white in gouache or acrylic; a simple still life (a lemon, a blue mug, a red apple) under one lamp
- **Mess / safety:** low to medium
- **The pull:** the discovery that three tubes make almost everything
- **The skill:** mixing, value control, color harmony the student can explain

Steps. Mix a small chart first: each primary with each other one, and each with white. Then paint the still life using only that palette. Mix the biggest area first. Gray colors with their complements, not black.

Stuck → **move.** When a mix goes dull, start a fresh puddle rather than rescuing the old one.

Exit. A small painting and a sentence: “I chose these three because...”

In-home — Acrylic in layers

- **Time:** two 45-minute sessions
- **Materials:** acrylics; a panel or canvas board; a spray bottle of water; brushes; a jar; retarder optional (a medium that slows drying)
- **Mess / safety:** medium; wash brushes before paint dries; ventilate
- **The pull:** it looks terrible halfway through and then suddenly doesn’t
- **The skill:** planning in stages; building from big shapes to refinement

Steps. Tone the whole panel with a thin middle color. Do the underpainting in one color — value only. Block in the big color masses. Refine: edges, small color shifts, the few details that matter. Photograph each stage.

Stuck → **move.** If the palette keeps drying, mist it with water and work in smaller batches.

Exit. A layered painting with stage photos. Those photos are process evidence for the portfolio (Chapter 8).

In-home — Warm light, cool shadow

- **Time:** 45 minutes
- **Materials:** a white object (an egg, a cup), a warm incandescent-style lamp, window daylight; gouache or acrylic
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** white turns out to be every color but white
- **The skill:** seeing color temperature in light and shadow

Steps. Paint the object under the lamp alone, then under lamp plus window light. Compare the color of the lit side with the color of the shadow side directly. Under a warm lamp, many painters

find the shadows read cooler; your student’s job is to check that by looking, not to take it on trust.

Stuck → **move**. Hold a swatch of the light color next to the shadow and ask, “Is the shadow warmer or cooler than this?”

Exit. A pair of small paintings with the temperature shift named in a sentence.

In-home — Swatch a master

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** a public-domain painting image from an open-access museum collection; gouache or acrylic; a card
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** it’s like reverse-engineering a recipe
- **The skill:** reading color as value, temperature and intensity

Steps. Choose a painting from a museum’s open-access collection (the Art Institute of Chicago, for example, releases tens of thousands of public-domain images for free use).³⁷ Mix the ten main colors as swatches, starting with the largest area. Label the card “after [Artist], [Title], [Date]” with the museum’s name.

Stuck → **move**. Squint at the image. Mix the big dull colors first; the bright accents last.

Exit. A labelled palette card. It’s a study “after” the artist and never filed as original work.

Out-of-home — Small watercolor from life

- **Time:** 45 minutes on site
- **Materials:** a travel watercolor set, a water jar with a lid, a 5 × 7-inch block of watercolor paper, one or two brushes, a pencil, a clip, paper towels, sun protection, water to drink
- **Mess / safety:** low; stay on paths; carry out everything you bring
- **Venue rules:** public parks usually welcome sketchers; in gardens or private grounds, ask first; many museums don’t allow wet media inside, so paint outdoors
- **The pull:** light changes while you paint, which forces decisions
- **The skill:** simplifying; working light to dark in three passes; stopping early

Steps. Pick a simple view: a tree against sky, a building corner, a bench. Pencil the envelope lightly. Decide what stays white. First pass: the lightest colors over everything that isn’t white. Second pass, once dry: middle values. Third pass: darks and a few accents. Stop.

Stuck → **move**. Reserve the whites before starting; if the light changes, paint the light you chose, not the light you have now.

Exit. A fresh small painting from observation, dated, with the place and time written on the back.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “Which passage is working, and which would you repaint first — and why?”

A “passage” is painters’ shorthand for any area of a painting — a corner, a shadow, a sky. At 17–18, the student can ask the opening of themselves at the end of every session, or chair it for a sibling.

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Evidence:** “Where’s your value range? Point to your lightest light and darkest dark.”
2. **Choice:** “What palette did you choose, and what did it rule out?”
3. **Process:** “Where did the paint surprise you?”
4. **Revision:** “What will you keep in the next one?”

How to wait. Ask, then count a slow three before speaking. It’s a classroom habit, not something art research has tested, and it gives the student room. Look at the painting while you wait, not at your student.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. The painting feels precious — hours went into it, and any answer feels like damage. Or the student hears “repaint” as “it failed.” Or they’re hunting for a technical word. Or your face already reacted. Try looking at a stage photo together instead of the finished piece; the earlier stage is less loaded and often shows exactly when the passage was working. “Not today” is allowed.

Don’t say / say instead. Don’t say: “That part’s muddy.” Say instead: “How many colors went into this passage? What happens if you try it with two?”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked. A week of value studies in one color: the same mug, three lights, three days, five values each time, in watercolor or gouache. The student stops seeing “blue mug” and starts seeing values.

Mixed. One session, two jobs: a one-color value study of a scene, then a gouache color note of the same scene. The student decides how much time each earns and compares them: did the color note keep the values the study found? At 17–18, stretch it to a series of five (below, in the student section).

Retrieval (two minutes, any day). “Complement of blue?” “Which medium can’t go back to white?” “What’s the rag rule?”

One incorrect example to diagnose

This is an illustration, not a real student’s work. Describe it or paint a rough version on scrap:

Two small watercolors of the same view: a white house, a tree, a summer sky. The first has been worked over and over. The sky is streaked gray-blue, the white house has been painted a dull beige, the tree is a dark brownish-green blot, and there are hard-edged blooms where paint went into half-dry washes. The second was painted in three passes: pale washes over everything except the house walls, which stay paper white; middle values once dry; a few darks under the eaves and in the tree. It’s quicker, simpler, and full of light.

Ask: “Where did the light go?”

Most students will spot the lost white house straight away. The better answers go further: the first painting has no plan for its whites, no waiting between passes, and too many colors in each mix. Let the student write three “because” notes beside the first painting, then paint the three-pass version themselves.

The daily page this week

On days without an Art Hour, the daily page can be a two-inch color note, a one-color value thumbnail, a swatch of something in the fridge, or a quick watercolor of the sky at the same time each day. Dated, private by default.

For the student

This section is for you.

Painting is drawing with a material that has opinions. Each paint wants to be handled a certain way, and once you know how, most of the frustration goes away.

Three paints, three habits.

- **Watercolor:** light to dark. The paper is your white. Decide what stays white before you begin, and let each layer dry before the next.
- **Gouache:** opaque and flat. Mix the biggest area first and mix plenty. Test on scrap, because it dries a bit differently from how it looks wet.
- **Acrylic:** fast and layered. Keep the palette misted. Wash your brush before the paint dries in it, or the brush is done.

Value does most of the work. If your lights and darks are right, the painting reads, even if the colors are strange. If they’re wrong, no color will save it. That’s why every good painting starts with a value decision.

A tiny worked example: graying without chalk. You’ve painted an orange and the shadow side looks too bright. Don’t add black (it goes dirty) or white (it goes chalky). Add a small touch of orange’s complement — blue. The orange darkens and quiets down, and stays clean. Same for red (add a touch of green) and yellow (a touch of violet). A little goes a long way; add it on the tip of the brush.

Limited palette. Try painting with only a red, a yellow, a blue and white for two weeks. It sounds restrictive. It’s the fastest way to learn mixing, and the colors will sit together better than anything from a big set.

If you’re doing oils (17–18, solvent-free). No turpentine or mineral spirits, ever, at home. Clean up the paint maker’s way: wipe the brush on one rag, dip in safflower oil, wipe on a second rag. Soap and water at the end. Rags go into a jar of water or a closed metal can, and out to the outdoor trash the same day. Oily rags in a pile can catch fire on their own. That rule isn’t fussy; it’s chemistry.

Try 1. A five-step value scale in one color: paper white, light, middle, dark, darkest. Squint. Fix the jump that looks biggest.

Try 2. A six-note gouache series: six 2-inch flat color notes of the same view (a window, a tree, a street) at different times of day. Mix the biggest area first in each. Lay them in a row. What changed?

Explain it back. In two sentences in your sketchbook margin: why gray a color with its complement instead of with black or white?

Challenge: a series of five. Choose one motif — a teapot, the view from your window, a bike against a wall. Paint it five times, changing one thing each time: time of day, palette, crop, scale, or the kind of light. Lay all five out. Pick your favorite and write three sentences on why. That's a sustained investigation in miniature: one question pursued across several works.

A few honest things. Your first watercolors will have hard-edged blooms where you touched a drying wash; everyone's do, and some painters grow to love them. Mud happens to everyone; the fix is fewer colors and more waiting, not more paint. Cheap paper for studies is fine. Save good paper for when you know what you're doing on it — and then use it, because good paper that stays in the drawer teaches nothing.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1: Everything turns to mud.

Next move: Three colors only, for two weeks — a red, a yellow, a blue — plus white for gouache and acrylic. Rinse the brush between every mix. Mix on the palette, not on the paper. If mud continues in watercolor, the student is probably working into half-dry washes; add the rule “Touch it wet or touch it dry, never in between.”

Diagnostic 2: Fear of wasting good paper. The student hovers, won't commit, or paints tiny and timid.

Next move: Cheap paper for studies, lots of it, and permission to use a whole sheet on swatches. Good paper later, once a study has solved the painting's problems. Some students relax once they've been told a study doesn't count.

Diagnostic 3: Overworking. The painting was good twenty minutes ago.

Next move: A timer. Forty-five minutes, then brushes down. Photograph the painting at the halfway point every session so the student can see where it peaked. For alla prima (17–18), set the rule that after fifty minutes nothing gets repainted.

Diagnostic 4: Wants oils now.

Next move: Gouache and acrylic first; oils when the rag rule is a habit. Offer an acrylic with a slow-drying medium as a bridge, or a community painting class you've checked, where oils happen in a studio set up for them. A student who is 15 or 16 can have that conversation again next year.

When to slow down. If the value scale is still lumpy after three tries, or a limited-palette still life keeps going muddy, stay with scales and charts another week. Value and mixing are the foundation of everything else in this chapter.

When to go ahead. When the student can make a clean value scale, mix a given color with three primaries plus white, and finish a small painting from life without losing the lights, move on and keep one painting a month going.

When to find another teacher. When the student wants to go further than you can support — larger oil work, portrait painting, a demanding plein-air practice — a community painting class, a sketch group that paints outdoors, or a dual-enrollment painting course is a gift, not a failure. Chapter 10 has a fit checklist, including what to ask about a studio’s solvent and ventilation practice.

Tools, including AI

A solid painting kit doesn’t need to be large: a student-grade watercolor set; a small set of gouache (a red, a yellow, a blue, white and black is plenty); acrylics in the same limited set; two or three round and flat brushes per medium; cold-press watercolor paper; mixed-media paper and a few panels or canvas boards for acrylic; a palette (a white plate works); two water jars; paper towels; a spray bottle; tape; a board. For oils at 17–18: the short list in the oils unit, and the lidded can before the paint.

For AI, the rules in the AI box in *The Art Hour* apply here unchanged. One note specific to painting: no AI “paint-over” of a student’s painting to show them how it “should” look, and no generated image as a painting reference for portfolio work. If your student wants a reference beyond life, it should be their own photograph, cited on the whose-mark card.

What “done enough” looks like

Before moving on, check these with your student. Steady matters more than perfect.

- ☐ A clean five-step value scale and a value-and-chroma chart, taped in the sketchbook.
- ☐ Three small finished paintings in at least two media, at least one from life outdoors.
- ☐ One layered acrylic painting with stage photos.
- ☐ A limited-palette painting and a sentence explaining the palette.
- ☐ A labelled “after” swatch card from a public-domain painting.
- ☐ The student can explain complements, value and why watercolor goes light to dark.
- ☐ The talk box used with the locked opening at least twice.
- ☐ At 17–18: a series of five with a written reason for the favorite, an alla prima study, and — only if the oils unit happened — a clean studio and rags handled right every single session.

Place by skill, not birthday. Some students spend six weeks here; others move through in three and keep a painting a month going through the year. Both are on track.

Chapter 5 — Photography, digital art, and design



Why this matters

Your student probably takes more photographs in a week than most painters in history made pictures in a lifetime. They may draw on a tablet more readily than on paper. They have opinions about fonts. None of that is a problem to be fixed. It's a starting point — and a serious one. The lens and the screen are real art media, with their own craft, their own history and their own standards, and a

15- to 18-year-old can learn to use them well.

What makes them different from paint is how easily the line between *making* and *getting* can blur. A stylus stroke on a tablet is as much your student's mark as a pencil line. A chosen frame, a crop, an exposure adjusted by hand — those are decisions, and decisions are authorship. But a picture generated from a typed prompt isn't anyone's mark, and a background filled in by software isn't a choice the photographer made. The skill this chapter teaches is to work freely inside the first kind of tool and to recognize the second kind on sight.

That's the third clause of the focus line, doing its most important work: **See long before you judge; sketch before you polish; sign only what you made.** In photography, “see long” means walking around the subject and taking twenty frames before choosing one. In digital art, “sketch before you polish” means a rough layer and saved versions before the finished file. In design, it means nine thumbnails before the software opens. And “sign only what you made” becomes something your student can *show*: the original file, the layers, the time-lapse, the edit log. Evidence settles questions that suspicion can't.

This chapter covers three linked fields. **Photography** — with a phone or a camera, digital at home. **Digital art** — drawing and painting on a tablet or computer, from life and from the student's own drawings. **Design** — posters, lettering, layouts and symbols made for a purpose and, often, for a real client. It also teaches two practical skills every portfolio needs: photographing flat artwork properly, and keeping files and permissions organized.

What your student can try today: twenty frames of one ordinary object, then choose one and say why in a sentence. What you can learn this week: the difference between an edit that adjusts a picture and one that invents part of it.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You don't need to be a photographer or a designer. You need to understand which decisions belong to the student, what an honest edit is, and the consent rules for pictures of people.

The everyday picture. A recipe you cook versus a meal you order. Both end on a plate. Only one shows your hand, and only one lets you say what you did at each step. A photograph your student framed, exposed and cropped is a meal they cooked. A generated image is a meal they ordered, however carefully they described it.

The precise picture.

Photography. Every exposure balances three settings, often called the **exposure triangle**. **Shutter speed** is how long the sensor takes in light: fast freezes motion, slow blurs it. **ISO** is how sensitive the sensor is: higher ISO works in dim light but adds grain (speckle). **Aperture** is the size of the lens opening, which also affects how much of the scene is sharp. Many phones have a fixed aperture but offer a “pro” or manual mode that exposes shutter speed and ISO. That's enough to teach the whole idea. Beyond exposure, photographers make decisions about **frame** (what's in and out), **viewpoint** (where the camera stands), **light** (which light, from where), and **moment** (when to press).

Digital art. A drawing tablet records the student’s own strokes. **Layers** are transparent sheets stacked in the file — sketch on one, color on another — and **versions** are saved copies at stages (v1, v2, v3). Many drawing apps can also record a **time-lapse**, a short video of every stroke. Together, these are the digital version of a sketchbook trail.

The line between an edit and an invention. A **non-generative edit** changes the student’s own image without creating new content: crop, exposure, contrast, color correction, straightening, removing a dust speck. A **generative** feature makes new content: “generative fill,” “expand,” object creation, background replacement, or an image made from a prompt. The AP Art and Design program, for 2026–27, allows non-generative edits at every stage and prohibits generative AI in final submitted work, including those features built into editing software. It allows generative tools only in research, ideation, practice, experimentation and revision, requires students to disclose any AI use, and treats AI-generated content as outside source material that must be cited.^{16,18} Its scoring guidance puts it in one line: “Automated imagery is not evidence of skill” — and its definition of automated imagery includes one-step filters and effects as well as generative AI.¹⁷ The U.S. Copyright Office draws a similar line from a different direction: protection depends on a human determining the expressive elements, “not the mere provision of prompts.”¹⁵

This book’s rule is stricter than AP’s, which keeps your student inside AP’s rules and every college’s and contest’s too. A generated image or a generative fill is not your student’s mark, and it never goes in the portfolio, on a contest entry, or on the transcript as their work. The full AI rules are in the AI box in The Art Hour.

Design. Designers use a handful of working words — **hierarchy** (what you see first, second, third), **contrast**, **alignment** (things lined up to shared edges), **repetition**, and **proximity** (related things grouped together). They’re useful vocabulary, not laws. A design has a job, usually set by a client in a **brief** (a short written description of what’s needed, for whom, by when).

Wrong answers you should be able to hear.

1. **“I used generative fill to fix the background.”** The fix isn’t the student’s. Next move: reshoot, crop, or accept the background. Undo the fill in the portfolio copy.
2. **No original file.** Only the edited version survives. That leaves no evidence of what was shot and what was changed. Next move: keep every original, edit copies, and log edits.
3. **Twenty filters on one photo.** Editing has replaced seeing. Next move: a month of exposure and crop only.
4. **A stranger’s face in a contest entry, with no release.** A consent problem. Next move: get a signed release, or choose another image.
5. **A poster with six fonts and no clear first thing to read.** No hierarchy. Next move: two typefaces at most, and the squint test — what do you see first?

Darkroom, briefly. Film photography in a darkroom uses chemistry that needs serious ventilation — the federal guide calls for at least ten room air changes an hour — along with gloves and goggles.¹³ This book keeps darkroom work at community venues (a college, an art center, a photo co-op) with their equipment and supervision. At home, photography is digital, and phones count.

People and privacy, plainly. Ask before photographing anyone. Get a signed release before any photo of a person is entered in a contest or posted; for a minor, a parent signs. Contests generally

put this responsibility on the student; the Scholastic Awards, for one, say so directly.¹¹ Photos of your student, siblings or friends stay off AI tools and off shared hosted workspaces, because those aren't privacy boundaries. Keep the archive on a drive your family controls, with a backup.

Your parent warm-up. Take twenty photos of one ordinary object — a colander, a boot, a house-plant. Move around it. Get low, get high, get close. Change the light if you can. Then choose one and write one sentence about why. You'll notice that frames eight through fifteen are better than one through seven. That's the lesson.

How to teach it this week

The shape of the week. The five beats of The Art Hour stay. A good first week: exposure and twenty frames on Monday, a tablet drawing from life with time-lapse on Wednesday, a design audit on Friday. Daily pages keep going — on paper, even for a digital-first student. An outing every week or two: a photo walk with one question.

The first try-it: twenty frames, one choice. Pick one subject: a bicycle, a kitchen chair, a fence post, a sibling who has agreed (hands only, if faces are a no). Open the See beat:

"Five minutes of looking before any photos. Walk all the way around it."

Then:

"Twenty frames. Move your feet, not the zoom."

Zooming often just crops the picture, and it never changes where you're standing; moving closer changes the viewpoint, which is a real decision.

The Make beat. The student shoots twenty, then puts the phone face down for two minutes. Then they scroll, choose one, and write one line: "I chose this because..." Before any editing, say:

"Keep the original. Edit a copy."

Exposure, in the same session or the next. Switch the phone to pro or manual mode. Same scene, three shutter speeds (a running tap is perfect: fast freezes droplets, slow turns it silky), then three ISO settings in a dim corner. The student changes one setting at a time and notes what happens. The exit is a prediction: "If I slow the shutter, the water will..."

The second try-it: tablet from life. Set a simple still life in front of the student — a shoe, a mug and an apple. Tablet, stylus, one brush, and one rule: no undo for the first ten minutes. Say:

"Turn on the time-lapse."

"One brush. Draw what's in front of you, not what's on a screen."

If the app has a smoothing or stabilizer setting, turn it down so the student feels their own hand.

One good question. At the end of either try-it: "Which of these choices would you defend?" It's the question AP readers, art-school reviewers and clients are all quietly asking.

How to fade your help. In the first session you say the opening lines. By the second, the student names the rules aloud before starting (“originals kept, time-lapse on”). By the third, you’re passing through with one question. When your student starts saving v1, v2, v3 without being reminded, stop talking.

When to stop talking. While the student is shooting or drawing. A comment mid-frame steals the decision. Bring your observations to the Critique beat as questions. If the student is stuck, the rescue order from The Art Hour applies: ask, wait, hint, a short demo on scrap, and hand the device back. In this chapter, the demo is usually you showing where a setting lives, not taking the picture.

Useful sentences for the week.

- “Show me the original.”
- “What did you change, and why?”
- “Which parts did you decide?”
- “What’s the job of this design?”

Band moves

15–16. Phone photography (exposure, twenty frames, four lights, honest editing), digital drawing from life with process capture, layers and versions, photographing 2-D work, design audits and lettering. You hold any AI account and sit beside; in practice, this chapter needs none. Portraits with consent happen in the family first.

17–18. A **photo series** (8–12 images sequenced around a question), **digital painting after observation** (painting digitally over the student’s own scanned drawing), a **poster for a real client**, **grid and layout**, **mark to vector** (turning a hand sketch into a clean digital symbol), screen versus print, and one **generated-image comparison** with you present — a looking exercise explained below, never filed. Darkroom work only at a community venue you’ve checked.

Placing by skill. A 15-year-old who already shoots seriously can start a series. An 18-year-old new to cameras starts with twenty frames, and that’s the right place.

Practice that actually builds learning

Practice here moves from **blocked** (a week of single-subject photo studies, or a week of tablet drawings of one object) to **mixed** (a photo study and a digital drawing of the same subject, in one session; the student chooses which comes first). Retrieval stays quick: “Which setting blurs motion?” “Name two non-generative edits.” And one incorrect example to diagnose.⁴⁴

In-home — Four lights

- **Time:** 45 minutes
- **Materials:** one object with texture (a pinecone, a shoe, a crumpled paper bag); window light; a lamp; a flashlight; a phone
- **Mess / safety:** low

- **The pull:** the same object looks like four different objects
- **The skill:** choosing light on purpose

Steps. Turn off overhead lights. Photograph the object by window light, lamp from the side, flashlight from low, and flashlight from behind. Lay the four images side by side and compare shadows, texture and mood (in the photographer’s sense: bright and even versus dramatic and dark).

Stuck → **move.** If all four look alike, the overheads are still on.

Exit. The student chooses a light for a stated reason.

In-home — Honest editing

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** one of the student’s own photos; an editing app
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** small adjustments that make a real difference
- **The skill:** non-generative editing with a record

Steps. Duplicate the original. On the copy, adjust only crop, exposure, contrast and color. Write an edit log: what changed, and why. If any tool offers to “fill,” “expand,” “remove” by inventing pixels, or “replace sky,” leave it alone.

Stuck → **move.** If an edit invents content, undo it.

Exit. A before/after pair with an edit log.

In-home — Layers, versions and process capture

- **Time:** 45 minutes, then ongoing
- **Materials:** a drawing app with layers; time-lapse or screen recording if available
- **Mess / safety:** low; screens at eye level, short breaks often
- **The pull:** it’s satisfying to watch your own drawing assemble itself in thirty seconds
- **The skill:** organizing a digital file so it shows the path

Steps. Name layers as you make them (sketch, color, detail). Save v1, v2, v3 at clear stages. Turn on the time-lapse and export a short clip for each finished piece. If the app has no time-lapse, save a version every fifteen minutes.

Stuck → **move.** A single flattened layer by the end usually means the student merged to “tidy up.” Keep a layered master; export flattened copies.

Exit. A file history that shows the path. One honest caution: AP’s scoring guidance notes that process documentation alone doesn’t prove authorship; readers look for real connections between the process and the finished images.¹⁷ The time-lapse helps because it shows those connections.

In-home — Photographing flat artwork

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** a phone; window light on an overcast day (or two lamps at 45 degrees); tape; a sheet of white paper
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** your paintings suddenly look like themselves on a screen
- **The skill:** archive-quality images — a portfolio skill in its own right

Steps. Tape the work flat to a wall. Stand square to it, camera level with the center, so the edges are parallel. Fill the frame. Include the white sheet in one test shot to check color. Crop to the edge of the artwork. Compare screen and original side by side and adjust exposure and color, non-generatively, until they match.

Stuck → **move.** Glare means light from the front; move it to the sides.

Exit. Clean images of three works, ready for the archive (Chapter 8).

In-home — Design audit, then lettering

- **Time:** 30 minutes plus 45 minutes
- **Materials:** three real posters, flyers or packages from around the house; pencil, marker, grid paper; a computer with two typefaces
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** once you see hierarchy, you can't unsee it
- **The skill:** reading and building visual order

Steps. For each piece, number what you see first, second and third. Mark the alignments and the contrasts. Redraw one of them better in pencil. Then hand-letter one word in three styles, set it digitally in two typefaces, and compare.

Stuck → **move.** Squint: what do you see first? For lettering, draw light guidelines before any letter.

Exit. The student names why one layout works, and has one readable, deliberate piece of lettering.

In-home, 17–18 — Digital painting after observation, and mark to vector

- **Time:** 60 minutes; two sessions
- **Materials:** one of the student's own observation drawings; a scanner or phone; a tablet; a vector drawing app
- **Mess / safety:** low; breaks
- **The pull:** the drawing you made from life becomes something new, and it's still yours
- **The skill:** growing digital work from the student's own seeing

Steps. For the painting: scan the student's own drawing, paint over it on new layers, and keep the drawing visible in the process files. Limit to five colors. For the symbol: twenty hand sketches of a simple mark (a monogram, a leaf, a tool); pick one; redraw it by hand in a vector app, reducing it to one shape plus one detail.

Exit. A digital painting grown from the student’s own drawing, and a symbol whose sketch trail proves authorship.

In-home, 17–18 — Grid, layout, and screen versus print

- **Time:** 45 minutes plus 30 minutes
- **Materials:** layout software or ruled paper; three archive photos of the student’s own work; a printer or a print-shop proof; a sheet of white paper or a gray card
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** a portfolio page that looks like it was made on purpose
- **The skill:** alignment and structure; matching images to originals across screen and print

Steps. Build a simple grid (twelve columns is a common designer’s choice) and lay out one portfolio page: image, title, medium, size, year, all aligned to shared edges. Then print the page and hold it beside the original artwork and the screen. Where colors drift, adjust the image non-generatively and print again. Include the white sheet or gray card in a test photo as a reference.

Stuck → move. Align everything to one left edge first; add complexity later.

Exit. A clean page template and portfolio images that match their originals.

In-home, 17–18 with you present — The generated-image comparison

This is the only activity in the book that uses a generated image, and it’s a looking exercise, not art-making.

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** the student’s own drawing of a subject; one generated image of the same subject, made or chosen by you on your account (no faces, no people, no uploads of the student’s work)
- **Mess / safety:** low; you hold the account; the image is deleted or kept only in your files, labelled
- **The pull:** it answers “why does it matter?” better than any rule
- **The skill:** naming where the decisions are

Steps. Put the two side by side. List what each one “decided”: light direction, crop, which details, which mistakes. Ask, “Where is the evidence of looking?” Label the generated image “not my mark.” Don’t file it.

Exit. The student can explain in two sentences why only one is their work.

In-home — Portrait with consent and release

- **Time:** 45 minutes
- **Materials:** camera; a simple release form (who, what the photo is for, where it may appear, signature; a parent signs for a minor)
- **Mess / safety:** low

- **The pull:** portraits of people you know are some of the best photographs you'll ever make
- **The skill:** consent as part of the craft

Steps. Ask. Explain what the photo is for. Offer to show every frame. Get a release before any entry or posting. If a face isn't agreed, photograph hands, a silhouette, or the person's workspace instead.

Exit. A portrait plus signed permission in a permissions folder.

Out-of-home — A photo walk with one question

- **Time:** 1–2 hours
- **Materials:** a phone or camera; water; a notebook
- **Mess / safety:** stay on public paths; a buddy; watch traffic, not the screen
- **Venue rules:** public spaces are generally fine for photography; shops, museums and private property may not be — ask; photographs of strangers aren't for the portfolio without a release
- **The pull:** a question turns a walk into a hunt
- **The skill:** seeing with a frame; editing a take down to one keeper per stop

Steps. Choose one question before leaving: "Where does light pool in this town at four o'clock?" "What does waiting look like?" Stop five times. Twenty frames per stop, one keeper each.

Stuck → **move.** Nothing interesting? Get lower, or closer, or come back when the light changes.

Exit. Five keepers and a one-line answer to the question.

Out-of-home — A poster for a real client

- **Time:** three sessions over two or three weeks
- **Materials:** a real client (a church, a co-op, a library program, a family business), a written brief, sketchbook, paint or digital tools
- **Mess / safety:** low; you make the first contact with an adult client at 15–16
- **Venue rules:** the client decides where the poster goes; get their permission before using the finished piece in the portfolio
- **The pull:** somebody actually needs this
- **The skill:** designing for a purpose, a reader and a deadline

Steps. Write the brief with the client: what, for whom, where it will hang, what must be on it, by when. Nine thumbnails. The client picks two. Revise one. Deliver, and ask the client for one sentence about how it worked.

Color with a job. At 17–18, build three small palettes for the same layout and test them. The job is practical: can the key words be read from across the room, does the important thing stand out, does the palette fit the client's existing colors? Test on real viewers and ask the client, rather than relying on claims about what particular colors "make people feel."

Stuck → **move.** Reread the brief aloud.

Exit. A delivered piece and a client sentence.

Out-of-home, optional — A community darkroom session

- **Time:** a class or open session
- **Materials:** as the venue provides
- **Mess / safety:** chemistry; the venue's gloves, goggles and supervision
- **Venue rules:** you check first: age rules, supervision, and ventilation (the federal guide's standard is at least ten room air changes an hour)¹³
- **The pull:** watching a print appear in the tray never gets old
- **The skill:** exposure and contrast by hand, in another medium

Exit. A print or two, and a note in the sketchbook on what the darkroom let you control that the phone didn't.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “Which marks, frames, and choices here are yours — and how would a stranger know?”

At 17–18, the student asks it of themselves before anything goes into the archive.

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Evidence:** “Show me the original.”
2. **Process:** “What did you change, and why?”
3. **Choice:** “What would you cut?”
4. **Seeing:** “Where does your eye go first?”

How to wait. Count a slow three before speaking. It's a classroom habit rather than an art finding, and it works. Look at the screen, not at your student.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. Often the student hasn't yet separated “I used a tool” from “the tool made it,” and doesn't know which side a particular step falls on. Sometimes the question sounds like an accusation. Sometimes they're hunting for a technical term. Walk the version history together, calmly, as a matter of interest: “What happened between v2 and v3?” “Not today” is allowed.

Don't say / say instead. Don't say: “Did you actually make this?” Say instead: “Walk me through the file, from the first version.”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked. A week of single-subject photo studies: the same object every day, one variable changed (light on Monday, viewpoint on Tuesday, time of day on Wednesday).

Mixed. In one session, a photo study and a digital drawing of the same subject. The student decides which comes first and compares what each medium let them decide. At 17–18, a series: shoot to a question, print thirty small, lay them on the floor, cut half, sequence 8–12, and title the series.

Retrieval (two minutes). “What does a slow shutter do?” “Two non-generative edits?” “What goes on a release?”

One incorrect example to diagnose

This is an illustration, not a real student's work. Describe it, or make it yourself on your account with a photo you took (no people):

Two versions of the same photograph: a bicycle leaning on a wall. Version one is honestly edited: cropped a little tighter, brightened, the color warmed slightly. The wall behind is plain and a bit scuffed. Version two has the same bicycle, but the wall has been replaced with a glowing sunset street created by a generative fill. It's prettier. The shadows under the bike point one way; the light in the new background comes from another.

Ask: "Which parts did the photographer decide?"

In version one, almost everything: the viewpoint, the frame, the moment, the crop, the adjustments. In version two, the photographer decided the bike and the prompt; the software decided the street, the sky, the light and the mismatched shadows. Let your student write two sentences explaining why only version one can go in the portfolio.

For the student

This section is for you.

Photography, digital art and design are real media. Phone photos count. Tablet drawings count. The standard is the same as for charcoal or paint: the marks and choices are yours, and you can show it.

What's yours. Your frame (what's in and out). Your viewpoint (where you stood). Your moment. Your light. Every stylus stroke. Your crop, your exposure, your color adjustments. Your layout, your lettering, your palette. Your file history.

What isn't. An image generated from a prompt. Anything a "generative fill," "expand," or "replace background" tool invented. A filter preset that did all the deciding. None of those go in your portfolio, on a contest entry, or on your transcript as your work. AP and art schools draw nearly the same line; this book draws it a little stricter, so following it keeps you safe everywhere.

A tiny worked example: crop versus fill. Your photo of a dog has a trash can at the edge. *Cropping* moves the frame inward until the trash can is gone. Everything left is what you shot. That's yours. *Generative fill* paints over the trash can with invented grass. The grass never existed; software made it. Not yours. Same goal, completely different answer.

Honest editing, in three rules. Keep the original. Edit a copy. Log what you changed.

People. Ask before you photograph anyone. Get a signed release before a photo of a person goes into a contest or online; a parent signs for anyone under 18. Photos of you, your siblings or your friends don't go into AI tools or shared online workspaces. If someone says no to their face, photograph their hands or their workspace. Some of the best portraits don't show a face at all.

Screens and posture. Take short breaks often, keep the screen at eye level, and keep your wrist neutral. Stand up every time you save a version — it's an easy habit to hang on something you

already do.¹³

Try 1. Twenty frames, one choice. One subject, twenty frames, moving your feet, not the zoom. Choose one. Write one line on why.

Try 2. A digital drawing from life with time-lapse on. Real object, one brush, no undo for the first ten minutes. Export the clip.

Explain it back. In two sentences: what's the difference between cropping and generative fill?

Challenge. A series of 8–12 photographs around one question, with a 100-word statement: what you were after, what you did, what you learned. Print thirty small, lay them out, cut half, and sequence the rest. Statements are your words only; Chapter 7 shows how.

A few honest things. Your first twenty frames will include ten boring ones; that's how everyone works. Files get lost, so back them up weekly. Filters are fun, and some are fine in the sketchbook; they're just not a substitute for light. And if you've ever used a generative tool on a piece, say so on the whose-mark card and pull that piece from the portfolio. That's what integrity looks like in practice, and nobody will think less of you for it.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1: Screen-only student. Won't touch paper; all work is digital.

Next move: Fine — from life. A digital drawing from a real object counts as observation. Add one analog day a week (the daily page is enough), and keep process capture on. Many strong digital artists keep a paper sketchbook for exactly this reason.

Diagnostic 2: The filter habit. Every photo has a preset on it.

Next move: No filters for a month; exposure and crop only. Then compare a month of honest edits with the old filtered set. Most students prefer the new work.

Diagnostic 3: Lost files. Originals gone, versions overwritten, the final saved over the master.

Next move: A simple folder system — one folder per piece, with “originals,” “working,” and “exports” inside — plus a weekly backup on a family-controlled drive during the Friday File beat.

Diagnostic 4: Design without purpose. Posters for imaginary events, logos for nothing.

Next move: A real client and a written brief. A church, a co-op, a grandparent's small business, a library program. A real deadline sharpens every decision.

Diagnostic 5: A generated image turns up in the folder.

Next move: A calm conversation, not a verdict. At 17–18, the generated-image comparison above, then the whose-mark card filled out honestly. At 15–16, you show a labelled example and talk it through. Move the image out of the portfolio folder together.

When to slow down, go ahead, or find another teacher. Slow down if originals keep going missing — the archive matters more than any single photo. Go ahead when the student can predict an

exposure change, edit honestly with a log, and show a full version history. When the student wants film, studio lighting or professional design software beyond what you can support, a community class, a darkroom program you’ve checked, or a dual-enrollment photography or 2-D design course is a gift, not a failure.

A composite illustration, not a real family: a farm family two hours from any museum, with a sixteen-year-old who photographs everything — calves, machinery, weather coming in over the fields. The parent’s contribution isn’t technical. It’s three questions on the way back from chores (“Where was the light?” “What did you cut?” “Show me the original”), a family-controlled drive, and a release form for the neighbors’ kids. By spring, there’s a twelve-image series about one field across a season, sequenced on the kitchen floor.

Tools, including AI

The physical tools can be modest: a phone with a pro or manual mode (or any camera), a basic editing app that shows its edit history, a drawing tablet and stylus if the family has one, a free or low-cost drawing app with layers and time-lapse, a vector app for design work, grid paper and markers, a family-controlled drive with a backup. A tripod is helpful for photographing artwork; a stack of books works too.

For AI, the rules are in the AI box in The Art Hour, and they apply here unchanged. Two notes specific to this chapter. First, the generated-image comparison above is the only generated-image activity in the book — a labelled looking object, never filed. Second, many editing apps now include generative features beside ordinary ones, often in the same menu. Before any portfolio file is edited, the student should know which tools adjust their pixels and which invent new ones, and use only the first kind.

What “done enough” looks like

Before moving on, check these with your student.

- ☐ Twenty frames and one reasoned choice, and a prediction about an exposure change that came true.
- ☐ A four-lights study with light chosen on purpose.
- ☐ An honestly edited photo with its original and an edit log.
- ☐ A digital drawing from life with a full version history or time-lapse.
- ☐ Archive-quality images of three 2-D works.
- ☐ A design audit and one piece of deliberate lettering.
- ☐ A permissions folder for every person shown in any photo.
- ☐ The talk box used with the locked opening at least twice.
- ☐ At 17–18: a sequenced photo series with a 100-word statement, or a design delivered to a real client with the client’s sentence; the generated-image comparison done with you present; darkroom work only at a venue you checked.

Place by skill, not birthday. A student new to cameras may take two months here; one who already

shoots seriously may start a series in week two. Both are on track.

Chapter 6 — Art history and contemporary art



Why this matters

Stand a teenager in front of a painting that's four hundred years old and ask what they think. Often you get a shrug, a polite "it's nice," or a quick glance at the label and a move to the next room. Stand the same teenager in front of a contemporary work — a room of stacked chairs, a canvas painted one flat color, a video of someone slowly folding cloth — and you may get something much more

definite: “A kid could do that.”

Both reactions come from the same place. The student hasn’t yet been given a way to look. Art history, taught well, isn’t a list of names and dates to memorize. It’s a long conversation among people who made things, across every culture and century, about what’s worth making and how. Contemporary art is the part of that conversation still happening, by living artists whose choices are sometimes hard to read at first glance. A student who learns to look at both — patiently, with evidence — gains something they’ll use every time they stand in front of a work of art for the rest of their life, including their own.

This is where the first clause of the focus line meets its hardest test: **See long before you judge; sketch before you polish; sign only what you made.** Seeing long in front of an old master is fairly easy; the skill is obvious. Seeing long in front of a work that looks deliberately plain or strange is harder, and it’s exactly where the habit earns its keep. Ten minutes of looking and a short reading of the artist’s own words change most first reactions. Not always to admiration — but to a judgment the student can back up. “Sketch before you polish” becomes drawing what you study: a small sketch of every work on a timeline, three sketches at every museum. And “sign only what you made” becomes citation: when a student’s own work borrows from an artist, they say so.

The chapter also gives your student a working map. Not a complete one — nobody has that — but a map across time and across several world regions, with depth in a few places the student chooses. Serious high-school art rooms name “understanding art worlds” as one of the habits they teach: knowing some of the history and people your work talks to.⁶ That’s the aim here.

What your student can try today: ten minutes with one work of art, listing twenty things they see before a single opinion. What you can learn this week: how to hear the difference between a description, an interpretation and a verdict.

For the parent: understand it yourself

You don’t need an art-history degree. You need a way of looking you can model, a sense of the order it goes in, and a few honest resources.

The everyday picture. Meeting a new relative at a family reunion. You listen before you decide what you think of them. You find out where they’re from, who their people are, what they’ve been through. Your first impression may survive, or it may not. Either way, it’s better informed. Meeting a work of art goes the same way.

The precise picture. Good looking has an order.

1. **Look first.** Before the label, before any reading. Visual Thinking Strategies (VTS), a method developed in museum education, uses three questions that work at any age: “What’s going on in this picture? What do you see that makes you say that? What more can we find?”⁷ The middle question does the heavy lifting: it ties every idea to something visible.
2. **Describe the form. Formal analysis** means describing how a work is made before saying what it means: line, value (light and dark), color, space (flat or deep), and composition (how the parts are arranged). It’s the evidence.

3. **Then context.** Who made it, when, where, for whom, from what materials, and for what purpose — a church, a home, a ceremony, a market, a gallery.
4. **Then interpretation.** What might it mean? Readings can differ, and several can be right, as long as each one points to evidence.
5. **Judgment comes last**, if at all. Chapter 7 develops this order into a written method of describe, analyze, interpret and judge.

Contemporary art adds one wrinkle. Many living artists make their argument through method or context rather than through visible skill alone: *how* a work was made, *where* it's shown, *what* it's made from. That's why the artist's own words matter so much for contemporary work, and why free resources like Art21, which films living artists talking about their work in their own studios, are so useful.⁴⁵

For families whose student wants it, the **AP Art History** course and exam are an option, not a requirement. As of this writing, the College Board describes it as equivalent to a two-semester introductory college art-history course, organized in ten units from Global Prehistory to Global Contemporary, with no prerequisite; the 2027 exam is on Wednesday, 12 May.⁴⁶ Everything in this chapter supports that route, and a student can have a full art-history year without it.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear.

1. **“A kid could do that.”** A verdict before looking. Next move: the ten-minute rule (below), then the artist's own words, then a real judgment.
2. **A timeline that's entirely European.** Half a map. Next move: every month, add works from at least two regions outside Europe.
3. **A museum label copied out as an “interpretation.”** Borrowed thinking. Next move: “What do *you* see that makes the label say that?”
4. **“I don't like it, so it's bad.”** Preference presented as judgment. Next move: separate the two out loud — “I don't like it” is allowed; “it's bad” needs evidence.
5. **A chatbot's art “fact” quoted without checking.** Chatbots produce confident errors, including invented sources.²¹ Next move: check every claim against a museum page or a book before it goes in the sketchbook.

Museum visits and the human body. You'll meet nude figures in most large museums — in ancient sculpture, in European painting, in many cultures' art. That's an ordinary part of art history, and there's no need for either alarm or a lecture. This book's own figure work is clothed, and the works suggested in these pages are chosen with that in mind. Families set their own standards for museum visits. A few calm, practical moves help: preview the museum's floor plan and online collection before you go; choose the rooms that fit your family and your question; mention beforehand, matter-of-factly, that some galleries will include nude figures and what you'll do (walk through, or skip that room); and let your student make some of those choices at 17–18. The same preview habit applies to contemporary galleries, where subject matter varies; read the current exhibition page before the visit.

Visitor rules. Check each venue's rules before you go. Many museums allow pencil only (no pens, no wet media), and some have rules on bags, stools and photography. Ask at the desk if you're unsure.

Your parent warm-up. Spend ten minutes with one contemporary work online — from Art21 or a museum’s website — before reading anything about it. Set a timer. List twenty things you see: materials, colors, size, what’s repeated, what’s missing. Only then read the artist’s words or the museum’s description. Notice whether your first impression survived. That’s the experience you’ll be asking of your student.

How to teach it this week

The shape of the week. The five beats of The Art Hour hold. A good first week: the ten-minute rule and a timeline start on Monday, a 150-word formal analysis on Wednesday, an Art21 watch-and-sketch on Friday. Daily pages keep going, often as small sketches of the week’s works. Plan a museum or gallery visit within the next two weeks.

The first try-it: see long. Choose one work your student is likely to find hard to like. A contemporary piece works well; so does an unfamiliar object from a culture new to them. Put a high-resolution image on a screen or a printout on the table. Open the See beat:

“Ten minutes. No opinions yet. Just list what you see.”

Set a timer. Your student lists at least twenty facts: “It’s about as tall as a door. The paint is thick at the edges. There are seven repeated shapes. One corner is unfinished.” If they stall at eight, say:

“What’s the material? What’s the biggest shape? What’s missing?”

When the ten minutes end, read the artist’s own words or a museum’s description together. Then, and only then, ask for a judgment:

“Now: what do you think, and what do you see that makes you say that?”

The Sketch beat. A small sketch of the work in the sketchbook, just the big shapes. It goes on the timeline.

Starting the timeline. A long strip of paper on a wall, or a double page in the sketchbook, ruled into centuries (closer spacing for recent centuries is fine). Each work studied gets a small sketch, placed by date and region, with a one-line label: artist or culture, title, date. Different regions get different rows or colors of label. Add a few works every week.

Wording that helps, sparingly.

“What do you see before what you think?”

“What did the artist have to decide?”

“Who was this for?”

“Check that against the museum page.”

How to fade your help. In the first session, you choose the work and hold the timer. By the second week, your student chooses the work and runs the ten minutes themselves, maybe with you as the one listing facts. At 17–18, the student plans the month’s works and regions. When your student says “wait, I haven’t looked long enough” before you do, stop talking.

When to stop talking. During the ten minutes. Your observations, however good, set the student's reading for them. If you notice something important, save it and offer it later as a question: "Did you see the small figure in the corner? What do you make of it?" If the student is stuck, the rescue order from The Art Hour applies: ask, wait, hint, a short model on a different work, and hand the looking back.

Band moves

15–16. The drawn timeline, museum visits with one question, comparisons across cultures, 150-word formal analyses, Art21 watch-and-sketch, and a gallery visit. VTS-style talk. The parent co-plans which works and regions each month.

17–18. All of the above, plus an **artist study** with a **response piece** (a new work of the student's own that answers an artist's method, cited), a conversation with a living artist you've arranged, and — only for students planning to take the exam — **AP Art History prompt practice** using the free-response questions and scoring guidelines the College Board releases. The student plans the month.

Placing by skill. A 15-year-old who reads widely and loves museums may be ready for an artist study in the first term. A 17-year-old meeting art history for the first time starts with the timeline and the ten-minute rule, and that's the right place.

Building the map, a month at a time

Nobody covers all of art history in a year, and nobody needs to. What your student needs is a map with a few well-lit places on it. Here is a simple way to plan it without a textbook.

At the start of each month, your student chooses one region to study in depth and one theme to follow across regions. A month might pair West Africa (in depth) with the theme "objects made for ceremonies" (across regions). The next might pair East Asia with "landscape," then the ancient Mediterranean with "how rulers want to be seen," then the Americas with "vessels and containers." Each month adds eight to twelve small sketches to the timeline: most from the region, a few from elsewhere on the theme.

Keep one rule: every month, at least two regions outside Europe appear on the timeline. That isn't a quota to satisfy. It's how the map stops being half a map.

At 15–16, you plan the first two months together and your student plans the rest. At 17–18, your student plans the semester on one page in September, and you ask to see it. For exam-bound students, the ten AP units make a ready-made sequence; the College Board's course page lists them.

Reading an artist's own words

Contemporary artists often explain their work in statements, interviews and films. Those words are evidence, but they're a particular kind: they tell you what the artist was after, not whether the work gets there. Teach your student to read them in three steps. First, look for ten minutes without them.

Second, read or watch, and underline one sentence that changes how you see the work. Third, go back to the work and check: can you see what the artist describes? If yes, the reading has grown. If no, that's worth writing down too. Either way, the student's judgment now rests on the work and the words together, which is what a fair judgment needs.

Practice that actually builds learning

Practice here moves from **blocked** (a month of one region's art, studied closely) to **mixed** (two regions a week, compared). Retrieval is the timeline itself: once a week, your student walks you through a stretch of it from memory, pointing at the sketches. And one incorrect example, below.⁴⁷

Choosing works. For these exercises, reach first for works that open looking rather than arguments: still lifes, landscapes, buildings, portraits, textiles, ceramics, tools, prints — public-domain works from museum collections are ideal. Contemporary work from Art21 or a local gallery's current show fits well once you've previewed it. The aim is looking, not debate. There's plenty to see in a teapot.

In-home — A drawn timeline

- **Time:** 20 minutes a week
- **Materials:** a long roll of paper or a sketchbook double page; pencil; small labels
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** by midyear it's a wall your student can actually walk someone along
- **The skill:** placing works in time and region; remembering by drawing

Steps. One small sketch per work studied, placed by date and region, with artist or culture, title and date. Big shapes only; a timeline sketch takes two minutes.

Stuck → move. Too slow? Sketch only the outer shape of each work and one defining detail.

Exit. A timeline the student can walk someone through, with works from at least four world regions.

In-home — Formal analysis in 150 words

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** one work, as a public-domain image from an open-access museum collection or a printed reproduction
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** it's the difference between having an opinion and being able to explain one
- **The skill:** describing form before meaning; writing from evidence

Steps. Describe what's there. Then analyze the form — line, value, color, space, composition — before saying anything about meaning. End with one sentence of interpretation, tied to something visible.

Stuck → move. Start every sentence with "I see..." for the first hundred words.

Exit. 150 words that stay with the evidence.

In-home — Across cultures

- **Time:** 45 minutes
- **Materials:** two works from different cultures on the same theme — a landscape, a portrait of a ruler, a vessel for water, a textile made for a ceremony
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** two very different answers to the same question
- **The skill:** comparing purpose, materials and audience without ranking

Steps. Choose a theme and two works. A Chinese hanging-scroll landscape and a Dutch landscape painting, say, or a West African woven cloth and a Navajo weaving. Compare three things: purpose (what was it for?), materials, and audience (who was meant to see or use it?). Sketch both.

Stuck → **move.** Draw a Venn diagram first, then write.

Exit. A written comparison that avoids “better” and “worse.”

In-home — Art21 watch-and-sketch

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** one Art21 artist film (free online), sketchbook
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** you see a living artist’s hands at work and hear them explain their own choices
- **The skill:** connecting an artist’s process to your own

Steps. Watch one artist segment. Pause three times and sketch what you see the artist doing — a gesture, a tool, a material. Write one question you’d ask them.

Stuck → **move.** Pause and draw the artist’s hands at work.

Exit. A sketchbook page connecting the artist’s process to your own.

In-home, 17–18 — Artist study and response piece

- **Time:** three sessions for the study; three for the response
- **Materials:** museum pages, a book or two from the library, Art21 if the artist is living, sketchbook, materials for the response
- **Mess / safety:** depends on the medium
- **The pull:** you end up in conversation with an artist, not just reading about one
- **The skill:** research, a labelled study, and transforming a method into your own work

Steps. Session one: life and context, from museum pages and books (every fact checked). Session two: a labelled “after” copy of a passage, marked “after [Artist], [Title], [Date],” with the source. Session three: plan the response. Then make a new work that answers the artist’s *method* — their way of working, their question, their constraints — not their image. Cite them in two lines on the whose-mark card.

Stuck → **move**. Choose an artist whose work you don't yet like. It makes a better study. For the response: borrow a method, not an image.

Exit. A study spread plus a response work, cited. The "after" copy is never filed as original work; the response piece can be.

In-home, 17–18, exam-bound only — AP Art History prompt practice

- **Time:** 30 minutes
- **Materials:** released free-response questions and scoring guidelines from the College Board; a timer
- **Mess / safety:** low
- **The pull:** timed writing on an unfamiliar work gets less frightening every time
- **The skill:** fast formal analysis and context under exam conditions

Steps. Choose a released question on a work your student hasn't studied. Outline for three minutes. Write within the time allowed. Score it against the published guidelines, then compare with your own reading of the guidelines.

Stuck → **move**. Outline for three minutes before writing a word.

Exit. A self-scored response and one note on what to practice next.

Out-of-home — Museum with a question

- **Time:** about two hours
- **Materials:** a sketchbook and pencil (pencil only is the safest assumption); a question written on the first page
- **Mess / safety:** low; comfortable shoes
- **Venue rules:** check the museum's visitor rules (pencils, bags, stools, photography); preview the floor plan and choose rooms that fit your family; phones only for photographing labels where allowed
- **The pull:** a question turns a museum from a maze into a hunt
- **The skill:** looking with purpose; sketching from real objects

Steps. Before you go, your student writes one question: "How have artists shown water?" "What did people make to hold food?" "How do rulers want to be seen?" At the museum, find three works that answer it. Sketch each for at least ten minutes. Afterwards, write a paragraph answering the question from the three works.

Stuck → **move**. Sit in one room for twenty minutes. Let the room come to you.

Exit. Three sketches and a paragraph.

Out-of-home — Gallery visit

- **Time:** 1–2 hours
- **Materials:** sketchbook, pencil

- **Mess / safety:** low
- **Venue rules:** read the current exhibition page first; in small galleries, ask before sketching; read the artist's statement after looking, not before
- **The pull:** the art on the walls was made by someone alive, maybe local, maybe there
- **The skill:** meeting contemporary work with the ten-minute rule

Steps. Visit a local, university or co-op gallery. Choose one work and give it the ten minutes. Sketch it. Then read the statement. Write a note on the artist.

Stuck → **move.** Ask the gallery sitter one question about the work.

Exit. One sketch and a note on a living artist.

Out-of-home, 17–18 — An artist conversation

- **Time:** about 30 minutes, plus preparation
- **Materials:** a contact you've arranged (a local artist, a community-class teacher, a college art instructor); five written questions
- **Mess / safety:** you make the first contact and are present or nearby; a public place, a studio visit you've arranged, or a video call you set up
- **Venue rules:** the artist's time and rules; ask before taking photographs of their studio
- **The pull:** artists are usually generous about their work when asked real questions
- **The skill:** asking good questions; carrying one idea back to the studio

Steps. Your student prepares five questions. One of them should be about something that didn't work. Afterwards, they write a thank-you note and try one idea from the conversation in the studio that week.

Stuck → **move.** Ask about a failure, not a success.

Exit. Notes, a thank-you sent, and one idea tried.

Talk box

Opening (locked): "What do you see, what might it mean, and what did the artist have to decide?"

At 17–18, your student can ask the opening of themselves at every museum stop, or chair it with a sibling or a co-op group.

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Evidence:** "What do you see that makes you say that?"
2. **Context:** "Who made it, and for whom?"
3. **Choice:** "What would you have decided differently?"
4. **Carrying it home:** "What will you borrow — a method, not an image?"

How to wait. Count a slow three before speaking. It's a classroom habit, not an art-research finding, and it gives the student room to think. Look at the work while you wait.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. Most often the student fears a “wrong” interpretation, especially with contemporary work. Sometimes they’re hunting for the right art-history term. Sometimes an opinion is already in the air — yours, or a label’s. Say plainly that readings backed by evidence can differ, and that you’re interested in what they see, not in a correct answer. Then offer a smaller question: “Just tell me one thing you see.” “Not today” is allowed.

Don’t say / say instead. Don’t say: “It’s about grief.” Say instead: “What do you see that might make someone read it as sad?”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked. A month on one region, studied closely: its materials, its purposes, a few works in depth, all added to the timeline. Depth first gives the map an anchor.

Mixed. Two regions a week, compared: one work from each, on a shared theme, with the across-cultures questions. The student decides which region and theme come next. At 17–18, mix an old work and a contemporary one on the same theme in one session.

Retrieval (five minutes, weekly). Your student walks you along a stretch of the timeline from memory, pointing at the sketches and saying what each work was for.

One incorrect example to diagnose

This is an illustration, written for this book, not a real student’s work. Read it aloud:

“This still life is really beautiful and peaceful. I think the artist must have loved food and wanted to show how important family meals are. It makes me feel calm. The colors are nice and it’s very realistic. I think it’s one of the best paintings in the museum because it’s so detailed. The artist was clearly very talented and worked hard. I would hang it in my house.”

Ask: “Where’s the evidence?”

Almost every sentence is an opinion or a guess about the artist’s feelings. There is one piece of description in it (“it’s very realistic”), and even that is vague. Now show a better version, also written for this book:

“I see a table edge running across the lower third, with a white cloth folded back to show dark wood. A lemon, half peeled, hangs over the edge; the peel spirals down toward the viewer. The background is nearly black, so the lit objects stand out sharply. The strongest light falls from the upper left across a metal cup and the cloth. The paint on the lemon is thicker than the paint on the background.”

Every sentence points to something a stranger could check. Let your student rewrite the first version in their own words, using only what they could see in a real painting of their choice.

The daily page this week

On non-Art-Hour days, the daily page can be a two-minute timeline sketch, a ten-minute study of one detail from a museum’s open-access collection, or a list of twenty things seen in one work.

Dated, private by default.

For the student

This section is for you.

Art history is a long conversation among people who made things, in every culture and every century. You don't need to memorize it. You need a way to look, a map that grows, and the honesty to check your facts.

How to look for ten minutes. Set a timer. List twenty things you see before any opinion: materials, size, colors, shapes, what repeats, what's missing, where the light falls, what's in the corners. It will feel slow at minute three and surprisingly full by minute nine. When the timer goes, read the artist's words or the museum's description. Then decide what you think.

Formal analysis, in plain words. Describe how it's made before you say what it means. Line (sharp, soft, broken), value (light and dark), color, space (flat or deep), composition (how the parts are arranged). That's your evidence.

A tiny worked example. A portrait of a woman in a dark dress. Not: "She looks sad and lonely." Instead: "Her face is the lightest area in the painting. The background is dark and plain. She's turned slightly away, and her eyes look past the viewer. Her hands are folded, and one is in shadow." *Then* interpretation: "The plain background and the look past us make her seem thoughtful, or distant." Every word of that reading points to something visible.

How to cite. For any work you study or borrow from, record the artist or culture, the title, the date, and where you saw it. For an open-access image, a museum's own suggested caption works well: for example, "Artist. Title. Date. The Art Institute of Chicago."³⁷ A copy you make is labelled "after [Artist], [Title]" and never filed as your original work. A response piece — your own new work answering an artist's method — gets a two-line citation on your whose-mark card.

Try 1. A 150-word formal analysis of one work you haven't studied before. Describe first, analyze the form, end with one sentence of interpretation tied to something visible.

Try 2. An Art21 watch-and-sketch page: one film, three sketches of what the artist does, one question you'd ask them.

Explain it back. In two sentences: why describe before you interpret?

Challenge. An artist study with a response piece. Choose an artist whose work you don't yet like. Research their life and context from museum pages and books. Make a labelled "after" copy of one passage. Then make a new work of your own that borrows their *method* — their way of working, their question — not their image. Cite them.

A few honest things. You're allowed to dislike a work after ten minutes of looking. What you're not allowed to do, in this studio, is dislike it after ten seconds and call that a judgment. Art history has more cultures in it than any single book or course covers; follow what interests you and keep adding regions. And anything a chatbot tells you about art gets checked against a museum page or a book before it goes anywhere near your notes.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1: Bored by dates.

Next move: Draw the timeline instead of reading it. Dates attach to pictures, and sketched pictures stick. Walk the timeline together once a week and let your student tell the stories.

Diagnostic 2: Hates contemporary art.

Next move: The ten-minute rule, then the artist's own words (an Art21 film is ideal), then a real verdict. The verdict can still be "I don't like it." What changes is that it comes with reasons. Many students find one contemporary artist they unexpectedly love; that's often enough.

Diagnostic 3: No museum nearby.

Next move: Open-access museum collections, where many public-domain works can be downloaded free in high resolution and studied up close, plus one real museum trip a semester, planned around a question. A composite illustration, not a real family: a farm family two hours from the nearest museum keeps a timeline on the kitchen wall built from open-access images, watches an Art21 film on Friday evenings, and plans one long museum day each semester around a single question the student chooses in advance. The trip is better for the waiting.

Diagnostic 4: Writing stalls.

Next move: Talk first. Your student describes the work aloud while you type their exact words, without improving them. Then the student edits. The words stay theirs. Over a few weeks, move to the student typing their own notes, then writing directly.

When to slow down. If analyses keep sliding into opinion, stay with "I see..." sentences for another two weeks before adding interpretation.

When to go ahead. When the timeline has twenty-plus works across at least four regions, analyses stay with evidence, and the ten-minute rule happens without prompting, move on and keep the timeline growing.

When to find another teacher. When the student wants more depth than you can support — a full survey, a specific period, AP Art History preparation — a dual-enrollment art history survey course, a museum's teen program, or a community lecture series is a gift, not a failure. Chapter 10 has resources by fit, and Chapter 9 covers how an art-history year appears on a transcript.

Tools, including AI

The main tools are free: a public library; open-access collections from the Art Institute of Chicago, the National Gallery of Art and the Metropolitan Museum of Art;^{37,38,39} Smarthistory, a free online art-history resource;⁴⁸ Art21's films and educators' guides; and, for exam-bound students, the College Board's AP Art History pages, which link to free video lessons from Khan Academy.⁴⁶ A long roll of paper for the timeline and a pocket sketchbook for museums complete the kit.

For AI, the rules in the AI box in The Art Hour apply here unchanged. One note specific to this chapter: art-history questions to an assistant are fine if every claim is checked against a museum

page or a book before it's used. Ask the assistant to name its sources, then go and read them. Where the assistant and the museum disagree, the museum wins.

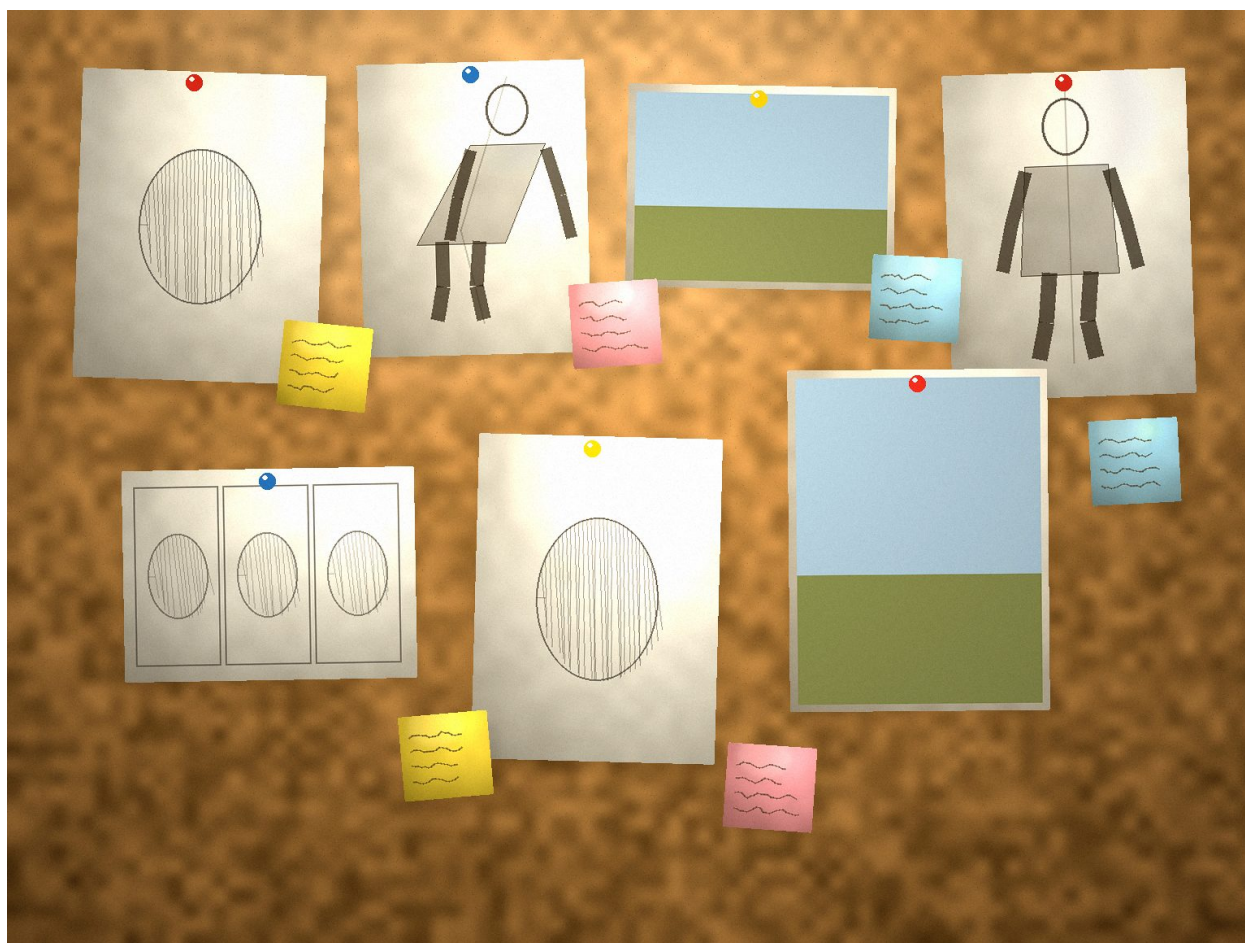
What “done enough” looks like

Before moving on, check these with your student.

- ☐ A drawn timeline with at least twenty works across at least four world regions, which the student can walk someone through.
- ☐ Two museum or gallery visits, each with sketches and a paragraph.
- ☐ Three 150-word formal analyses that stay with the evidence.
- ☐ One across-cultures comparison that avoids “better” and “worse.”
- ☐ The ten-minute rule used on at least one work the student found hard to like, with a judgment backed by evidence.
- ☐ The talk box used with the locked opening at least twice.
- ☐ At 17–18: one artist study with a cited response piece; an artist conversation, if one could be arranged; for exam-bound students, regular prompt practice against released scoring guidelines.

Place by skill, not birthday. Some students take this chapter as a single unit; others weave it through the whole year, a few works a week. Both are on track.

Chapter 7 — Critique and the artist statement



Why this matters

Sooner or later someone will look at your student's work and say something about it. It might be a co-op parent, a portfolio reviewer, a contest juror, a friend with a phone, or an AP scorer who never meets them. Some of those words will be useful, and some won't. This chapter makes sure your student is ready for both. They'll know how to ask for the feedback they need, how to hear it

without flinching or arguing, and how to say in their own plain words what they were trying to do.

That's the work of critique and the artist statement. At 11–14, talk about art was a conversation the parent led. At 15–18 it becomes a skill the student runs. Your student chairs the session, asks the questions they want answered, decides whether to hear opinions, and writes about their own work for real readers.

The focus line runs through all of it. *See long before you judge* applies to your student's own work as much as a museum painting. A drawing gets described before anyone calls it good or bad. *Sketch before you polish* applies to words as well. A statement starts as notes, a spoken answer, and a messy draft before it gets anywhere near a portfolio field. *Sign only what you made* means every word of that statement is the student's. No model writes it, no parent rewrites it, and borrowed jargon doesn't stand in for thinking.

The stakes are real now: AP Art and Design asks for short written responses beside every piece, and many applications ask for a statement. Mostly, though, hearing about your work is part of making it. Artists who can take a hard note calmly get better faster, and artists who can say what they were after can tell when they've gotten there.

There's a tender side too. Teenagers tend to feel being watched and judged more sharply than younger children or adults do.⁹ That doesn't mean they can't handle critique. It means critique needs a shape: evidence first, questions without hidden verdicts, and opinions only when the artist asks for them. Those shapes already exist, and this chapter teaches three. None of them needs an art degree. All of them need a parent willing to go last.

For the parent: understand it yourself

The everyday picture: a good editor. Think of the best editor or teacher who ever read something you wrote. They asked what you meant before they told you what was wrong. They pointed to the exact sentence where your point landed and the exact one where it slipped. And they never picked up your pen and rewrote the paragraph for you, because then it would have been theirs. That's your job in this chapter. Ask, point, wait, and hand the pen back.

The precise picture: three doors into critique. You'll use three methods. Each one puts looking before judging, and each suits a different situation.

Visual Thinking Strategies (VTS) comes from museum education. It's three questions, asked as written: "What's going on in this picture?" "What do you see that makes you say that?" "What more can we find?" Between answers, the person leading paraphrases what was said and points to the spot, without praising or correcting.⁷ At 15–16, your student learns to *lead* VTS rather than answer it. They ask the questions and you answer them, about a master's work first and then about their own.

Liz Lerman's Critical Response Process (CRP) was built for artists showing work in progress, and it puts the artist in charge.⁸ It has four steps. First, responders offer **statements of meaning**: what struck them or stayed with them, with no fixes. Second, the **artist asks questions** about what they want to know. Third, responders ask **neutral questions**, which are questions with no opinion

tucked inside. Fourth come **permissioned opinions**. The responder says, “I have an opinion about the edges. Would you like to hear it?” and the artist may say no. CRP is the main method at 17–18, because it lets a near-adult run their own critique.

Feldman’s four steps are **describe, analyze, interpret, judge**, in that order.⁴⁹ They work best in writing, on finished work by someone not in the room. They’re also the bones of a good artist statement and of the short written answers AP Art History asks for.

Here’s the quick way to keep them straight. VTS is for looking together at anything. CRP is for work by someone present, including your student. Feldman is for writing about a finished piece.

What a neutral question is. A neutral question leaves the verdict with the artist. “Why is the background so busy?” sounds like a question, but it carries an opinion (too busy). “Tell me about the background” or “What were you going for in the background?” doesn’t. Most adults need practice at this. We were raised on the other kind.

What an artist statement is. An artist statement is a short, plain account of what you were after and how you went about it. It isn’t a biography, a sales pitch, or a list of influences. The house shape has three parts: *what I was after, what I did, what I learned*. At 15–16, that’s 100 words about one piece. At 17–18, it grows into a 300-word statement about a body of work, plus short captions written to exact limits.

The limits your student will meet. AP Art and Design asks for short typed fields beside the work, each with a hard character limit, spaces included. For each Selected Works piece, those are Idea(s) (250 characters), Materials (150), and Processes (250), along with an Image Citation (200) and Digital Tools (200) where they apply. The Sustained Investigation asks for Materials (150) and Processes (350) for each image, plus two longer written responses, up to 850 characters each, about the inquiry and how it developed.¹⁷ Two hundred and fifty characters is about two plain sentences. Writing to that limit is a skill, and practicing it long before May saves a lot of grief.

The words stay theirs. Pratt’s current application rules don’t allow AI-generated text in essays or descriptions.¹⁹ AP requires students to disclose any AI use in their portfolio fields.¹⁶ This book goes further and more simply: a model never writes a statement, caption, or essay, and neither do you. You can ask questions, type while your student talks, and point to a sentence that says nothing. The words come from the student.

Why opinions come last. The CRP order isn’t politeness. When the artist asks their own question first, they hear the answer as help instead of judgment. When a verdict lands first, a lot of teenagers stop listening, and some stop showing work. Going last costs you nothing, and it keeps the door open.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. “It’s good.” “It’s bad.” And nothing else. *What it usually means:* a verdict came before any looking. Sometimes it’s a way of ending the conversation. *Your move:* “Hold that for the end. What’s happening in the top third?”

2. Arguing back during feedback. “No, but I *meant* it to look like that.” *What it usually means:* the student is defending instead of listening. Feedback feels like a trial. *Your move:* the notes-only

rule (below). “Write it down. You can answer tomorrow.”

3. “I have always loved art” as a first line. *What it usually means:* the student doesn’t know what a statement is for, so they reached for the most common opening there is. *Your move:* “Cut that line. Start with the moment you knew what this piece was about.”

4. A statement stuffed with borrowed jargon. “My work interrogates the liminal space between presence and absence.” *What it usually means:* hiding. Big words feel safer than a plain claim someone could disagree with. *Your move:* “Point to the part of the drawing where that happens.” If nobody can point to it, the sentence goes.

5. A statement a chatbot drafted, or one you smoothed. *What it usually means:* worry about sounding good enough, or a helping instinct. *Your move:* go back to the student’s own notes and spoken words. A clunky sentence the student means is worth more than a polished one they don’t recognize.

Your warm-up (ten minutes, alone)

Write 100 words about something you made recently: a meal, a garden bed, a spreadsheet you were proud of. Use three sentences, one each for what you were after, what you did, and what you learned. Then cross out every adjective you can’t point to. (“Delicious” goes. “The onions went in before the garlic” stays.)

Notice how hard the first sentence was, and how much better the piece got once you cut. You’ve just written your own 100-word statement, and you’ll be kinder about your student’s first draft.

How to teach it this week

First try-it: a student-led VTS session, then a 100-word statement.

Start with someone else’s work so nobody’s pride is on the table. Choose one open-access museum image with plenty going on, hand your student a card with the three VTS questions, and say:

“You’re leading today. Ask me the three questions, and paraphrase what I say before you ask the next one.”

Answer honestly and at some length, so there’s something to paraphrase. After ten minutes, switch to one of your student’s recent pieces, still with your student leading. When they paraphrase you accurately (“You’re saying the left side feels empty because the table edge runs out of the frame”), they’re hearing a comment about their own work as information. That’s the most useful critique skill there is.

Later that day, or the next, ask for 100 words on the same piece. “What were you after, what did you do, what did you learn? A hundred words. Plain ones.” If the page stays blank, say: “Tell me instead. I’ll type exactly what you say.” Type it word for word, then hand it back to edit. That’s the fastest route from a blank page to their own words.

Exact wording to keep in your pocket.

- “What were you after?”
- “What question do you want answered today?”
- “Would you like my opinion on that?”
- “Write it down; answer tomorrow.”
- “Cut every adjective you can’t point to.”
- “Where in the work does that sentence happen?”

How to fade your help. In week one, you answer VTS questions and type if needed. In week two, your student leads VTS on their own work with you as the only responder, and writes the statement without typing help. By the end of the month, at 17–18, they run a full CRP session with you and one other person as responders, and you speak only in the order CRP allows.

When to stop talking. Stop after you ask any question, and count a slow three. Stop completely when your student is writing notes during feedback. And stop the moment you notice you’re about to say “What I’d do is...” That sentence belongs in step four, with permission, or not at all.

Band moves.

15–16. Your student leads VTS, first on master works and then on their own. Feldman’s four steps come in writing, on works by others. Every portfolio candidate gets a 100-word statement. The notes-only rule applies to all feedback. You’re the main responder, and you always go last.

17–18. Your student chairs CRP on work in progress. They write captions to AP limits, whether or not they’re taking AP, because the discipline helps every reader. They write the investigation question, draft and revise a 300-word artist statement, cite every reference, and find outside eyes: a co-op critique, a community class, or a portfolio review. A 17-year-old can ask the talk-box opening of themselves, in the sketchbook, before anyone else sees the work.

Place by skill and independence, not birthday. A confident fifteen-year-old who already writes well can take the 300-word statement early. An eighteen-year-old new to critique starts with VTS on someone else’s painting, and that’s the right start.

This week, sketched

- **Monday:** Art Hour. See and Sketch as usual, then the first student-led VTS in the Make beat, on a master work. Critique beat: VTS on their own piece.
- **Every day:** the daily page. On one day, the student writes three lines under the drawing (after, did, learned). It’s a 30-word rehearsal.
- **Wednesday:** Art Hour on the current piece. Critique beat: the notes-only rule. You offer one statement of meaning and one neutral question. They write, and don’t answer.
- **Thursday:** the student answers Wednesday’s note in writing, in two or three sentences.
- **Friday:** Art Hour, then File. The student writes a 100-word statement for one portfolio candidate and staples it to the whose-mark card.
- **Within two weeks, out of the house:** outside eyes, meaning a co-op critique, a community class, or a portfolio review (see below).

Many families thread this chapter through the year rather than giving it a month: a critique beat every Hour, a wall critique monthly, a statement for each new portfolio candidate.

Practice that actually builds learning

Each try-it lists time, materials, mess and safety, the pull (why a teenager might actually want to do it), and the skill. Pick one or two at a time. Nobody needs all of them this week.⁵⁰

In-home try-its

Critical Response Process at the kitchen table (17–18; modeled at 15–16)

- *Time*: 20 minutes
- *Materials*: one work in progress; a card with the four CRP steps; the student's sketchbook for notes
- *Mess/safety*: none, except emotional safety. The artist chooses the piece and the responders.
- *The pull*: the artist runs the room. For a lot of teenagers, being in charge of their own critique is the first time feedback has felt like something they asked for.
- *The skill*: the student states what the piece is for, then asks two or three questions they genuinely want answered. "Is it good?" is too big. "Does the shadow side read as one shape?" works. Responders give statements of meaning, answer the artist's questions, ask neutral questions, and offer opinions only with permission. If a "why didn't you...?" slips out, turn it into a neutral question on the spot: "Tell me about the choice to crop there." The session ends with the artist naming one change they choose to make, and they're allowed to choose none.

Describe, analyze, interpret, judge — in writing (both bands)

- *Time*: 30 minutes
- *Materials*: one finished work, by a master (an open-access image) or by the student from months ago; paper or a document
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The pull*: it's the one place in the book where you're allowed a full verdict, as long as you earn it.
- *The skill*: four short paragraphs in order. *Describe* what's there. *Analyze* how it's arranged, covering light, value, color, space, and composition. *Interpret* what it might mean, with evidence. *Judge* what you think, with reasons. If a verdict sneaks into paragraph one, move it to paragraph four. This is Chapter 6's formal analysis, turned into a full critique.

The monthly wall critique (both bands)

- *Time*: 30 minutes
- *Materials*: a wall, corkboard, or shared digital folder; pins or tape; two colors of sticky notes
- *Mess/safety*: none. Hang only what the student chooses, and nothing from the private sketchbook unless offered.
- *The pull*: a month of work, all at once. Most students are surprised by how much they made.
- *The skill*: pin the month's finished pieces and chosen studies. Each viewer leaves one "I noticed..." note and one "I wondered..." note per piece. The parent goes last, every time. The student reads the notes alone first, then chooses next month's focus and writes it at the top of the Monday plan.

Notes, not arguments (both bands)

- *Time*: 10 minutes during any critique, plus 10 the next day
- *Materials*: the sketchbook, open to a fresh page
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The pull*: permission to say nothing. You don't have to defend anything in the moment.
- *The skill*: during feedback, the artist writes only. The one allowed spoken reply is "Thank you." The next day, they read the notes and write a short response: what they'll use, what they'll set aside, and why. Many students find that half the notes they would have argued with turn out to be useful by morning.

The 100-word statement (both bands)

- *Time*: 20 minutes
- *Materials*: one finished piece; a word counter
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The pull*: short enough to finish tonight.
- *The skill*: three sentences or three short paragraphs, covering what I was after, what I did, and what I learned. No "I have always loved art." Every adjective has to point at something in the work. If the student stalls, they say it aloud, you type exactly what they say, and they edit.

Captions to the limit (17–18)

- *Time*: 20 minutes per piece
- *Materials*: a character counter (most word processors have one); the piece or a good photo of it
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The pull*: it's a puzzle with a hard edge, like fitting a suitcase into an overhead bin.
- *The skill*: write three fields for one work, Idea(s) in 250 characters, Materials in 150, and Processes in 250 (or 350 for Sustained Investigation images), spaces included.¹⁷ Cut adjectives first, then repeated ideas, then anything a viewer can already see. The goal is fields under the limit that say something only this piece could say.

The 300-word artist statement, drafted and revised (17–18)

- *Time*: three sessions over a week or two
- *Materials*: the current portfolio pull; all the 100-word statements written so far; the sketchbook
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The pull*: it's the statement they'll actually use, for a portfolio, an application, a show, or a contest.
- *The skill*: in session one, the student reads every 100-word statement they've written and highlights sentences that still sound true. Session two is a 300-word draft that opens with one specific studio moment ("The fourth time I drew the stairwell, I stopped drawing the stairs and started drawing the light on them"). In session three, they read it aloud to you, you ask neutral questions only, and they revise. Then they revise once more a few days later. No AI-written text at any stage, and no rewording by you. When it's done, they should be able

to defend every sentence in conversation with a stranger.

The investigation question (17–18)

- *Time:* 20 minutes
- *Materials:* the question log in the back of the sketchbook (from Chapter 2)
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The pull:* a good question makes the next fifteen pieces easier to start.
- *The skill:* write the question that guides a sustained investigation, which means one question pursued across many works. Then list three works so far and one line on how each answers it. Replace “explore” with a verb you can see. “How can I explore family?” becomes “How does the kitchen table change across one day of use?” A question you can see is a question you can draw. Chapter 8 builds the plan from here.

Citing sources (both bands)

- *Time:* about 10 minutes per referenced piece
- *Materials:* a running reference list in the sketchbook or a document
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The pull:* it’s what professionals do, and it protects the student’s own work.
- *The skill:* for every image the student looked at while making a piece (a master painting, a photograph, a pose reference), record the artist or photographer, title, date, and source. A clear credit line looks like “Artist. *Title*, Date. Museum name.” That’s the format the Art Institute of Chicago suggests for its open-access images.³⁷ For AP, the Image Citation field allows 200 characters.¹⁷ The student’s own photographs make the simplest references (“reference: my own photo, 3 March 2027”). Any AI use goes on the whose-mark card, described exactly (Chapter 8).

Out-of-home try-it

Outside eyes (17–18; a first taste at 15–16 with a trusted group)

- *Time:* one to three hours, depending on the venue
- *Materials:* 10–12 pieces or good images of them; the sketchbook; one written question per piece
- *Mess/safety:* the student chooses what to bring. You check the venue first: who runs it, whether a parent should stay, and how feedback is given.
- *Venue rules:* co-op critiques and community classes set their own formats. National Portfolio Day events, run with more than 90 member art schools, offer short reviews of about 10 to 15 minutes, welcome works in progress, and suggest bringing up to 10–12 pieces.⁵¹ Check the current event page before you go.
- *The pull:* a stranger who knows art looked at your work and took it seriously.
- *The skill:* the student asks their one question per piece, takes notes instead of arguing, and says thank you. Afterward, they pick one note to act on this month. If the reviewer moves fast, the student leads with their most important question. If a co-op critique has no format, bring a printed card of the four CRP steps and offer it. Most adults are relieved to have one.

Talk box (this chapter)

Opening (locked): “Say what you were after — then show me where the work gets there and where it doesn’t.”

At 17–18, the student can ask this of themselves first, in the sketchbook, before anyone else responds.

Follow-ups:

1. “What question do you want answered today?” (the artist sets the agenda)
2. “Show me the spot where it gets there.” (evidence: a finger on the work)
3. “What did you try that didn’t make it in?” (process)
4. “May I offer an opinion?” (permission, and the answer can be no)
5. “What will you change, and what will you keep?” (revision, their choice)

How to wait. After you ask, count a slow three in your head. That’s a classroom convention, not an art study, but it works. After they answer, wait again, because the second answer is usually more honest than the first. Look at the work, not at your student. This question asks them to say where their own piece falls short, which is harder than anything in Chapter 6.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. They’re bracing for a verdict. They suspect your “question” is really a judgment. They’re hunting for the right art word instead of the plain one. Or an opinion is already in the air: yours, a sibling’s, or one from last week. Let them ask their own question first. If silence holds, point to one small thing neutrally (“The shadow under the cup is the darkest thing on the page”) and wait again. “Not today” is allowed. The work will still be there next week.

Don’t say: “I think it’s great, but the hands are off.” **Say instead:** “Say what you were after — then show me where the work gets there and where it doesn’t.”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked: for a month, run VTS and Feldman only on other people’s work: master paintings, a sibling’s drawing, a gallery piece. The questions become automatic before your student’s own pride is involved. This is especially good for a student who dreads critique.

Mixed: in one Art Hour, run Feldman on a master work that shares a problem with your student’s current piece (two still lifes lit from the side, say), then CRP on the student’s piece. The master’s solution often shows up in the student’s own questions.

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration)

Two statements about the same charcoal drawing of a kitchen chair, both written by a composite student. Read them side by side and ask: “Which one tells you what she did?”

Version A (about 60 words of a 300-word draft): “Through my practice I interrogate the liminal boundaries between object and void, presence and absence, destabilizing the viewer’s relationship to domestic space. Drawing on a lifelong passion for art, my

work seeks to evoke a profound emotional resonance that transcends the everyday and invites contemplation of the ineffable...”

Version B (100 words): “I wanted to see if an empty chair could feel like someone had just left. I drew our kitchen chair from life over three sessions, with one lamp low on the left so the shadow ran long across the floor. I drew the negative spaces between the rungs first, because every time I drew the rungs themselves they came out too thick. The long shadow ended up doing most of the work. The chair alone felt like furniture; the chair plus the shadow felt like a moment. Next I want to try the same chair at three times of day.”

Version A could describe almost any artwork ever made. There’s nothing in it to point at, and its only personal claim is a cliché. Version B names the question, the method, the problem, and what the student learned, and every sentence points to something in the drawing. It’s the one she could defend in conversation. Ask your student to find three sentences in Version A that could be deleted without losing anything. (All of them.)

A composite: the student who won’t show anything (illustration)

This is a composite drawn from common situations, not a real family. A sixteen-year-old draws every day and shows no one. Critique of any kind ends with her closing the sketchbook.

Her parent stopped asking to see the work. For a month they did VTS only on museum images, the student leading. Then she offered a drawing from a year earlier (“It’s not me anymore, so it’s fine”). Two weeks later she offered a current piece and asked her own question first: “Does the window look bright enough?” The parent answered only that question. The student wrote the answer in her notes and said thank you.

Nothing dramatic happened. She learned that she controlled the room. By spring she was leading a CRP session with a co-op friend.

For the student

Critique isn’t about finding what’s wrong with your work. It’s about looking long enough, and asking good enough questions, to tell for yourself where a piece gets where you wanted and where it doesn’t. Other people’s eyes help. You decide what to ask them.

You’ll use three tools:

- **VTS** for looking at anything. Three questions: “What’s going on in this picture?” “What do you see that makes you say that?” “What more can we find?”
- **The Critical Response Process** for your own work in progress. You say what the piece is for. You ask your questions. Responders ask neutral questions. They offer opinions only if you say yes.
- **Describe, analyze, interpret, judge** for writing about a finished piece. Judgment comes last, with reasons.

How to take a note. When someone gives you feedback, write it down and say “thank you.” That’s all. Don’t explain, and don’t defend. Tomorrow, read your notes and decide what to use. You’re not obliged to take every note. You are obliged to hear it.

How to write 100 honest words. Answer three questions about one piece:

1. What was I after?
2. What did I actually do?
3. What did I learn?

Cut every adjective you can’t point to in the work. Don’t open with “I have always loved art.” Everyone opens with that, and it tells a reader nothing about this piece.

Worked example

Here’s a 100-word statement about a gouache study. The notes in brackets aren’t part of it.

“I wanted to paint the exact color of late-afternoon light on a white wall. [*after*] I made six small gouache notes of the same wall between four and six o’clock, fifteen minutes each, mixing the biggest area first every time. [*did*] The first three came out as ‘white with some yellow.’ By the fifth I saw the wall was actually a pale orange and the shadow was violet, not gray. [*learned*] The light changed faster than I could paint, so I learned to mix before I looked back up. Next I want to try the same wall on an overcast day.”

It’s plain, specific, and entirely yours. A reader can check every sentence against the paintings.

How to cite

For every image you looked at while making a piece, write down the artist or photographer, the title, the date, and where you found it. For a museum work, that looks like “Artist. *Title*, Date. Museum name.” For your own photo, it’s “reference: my own photo” and the date. A copy you made to learn from is labelled “after” the artist (“after [Artist], [*Title*]”). It’s yours, as a study, and never passed off as your original.

Two tries

1. Pick a painting from a museum’s open-access collection. Lead a VTS session with someone at home, and paraphrase every answer before you ask the next question. Ten minutes.
2. Write a 100-word statement for your most recent finished piece. Then cut ten words.

Explain it back

Why do opinions come last in a critique? Explain it to someone at home in two or three sentences, using an example from your own work if you can.

Challenge

Write a 300-word artist statement about the body of work you're making now. Open with one specific moment in the studio. Read it aloud to someone. Then imagine a stranger asks you about each sentence: "What do you mean by that? Where can I see it?" Rewrite any sentence you couldn't defend.

Your words are yours

Every word of your statement has to be yours. No chatbot drafts it, and no one smooths it for you. Pratt doesn't allow AI-written text in application essays or descriptions, and AP requires you to disclose any AI use.^{19,16} The real reason is simpler: a statement is your thinking made visible, and someone else's sentence can't show that.

You're also allowed to say "not today" when someone offers an opinion. That's part of how critique works, and it isn't rude.

If it isn't clicking

1. Every note lands as an attack. The student goes quiet, argues, or stops showing work. *What it usually means:* critique is happening in the wrong order, or before trust is built. This is common and not a character flaw. *Next move:* the notes-only rule, with replies the next day, for every session this month. Critique other people's work for a few weeks before returning to theirs. Let the student ask their question first, every time.

2. They can't write about their own work. The page stays blank, or it fills with "I think it turned out pretty well." *What it usually means:* writing about yourself is harder than writing about anything else. *Next move:* talk first. Ask the three statement questions aloud, record or type the answers word for word, and hand the transcript back to edit. Most students can say 100 good words long before they can write them.

3. Your opinions keep leaking in first. You mean well, and it comes out before you notice. *What it usually means:* you're a caring adult who sees what could be better. That's not a problem. It's just in the wrong place. *Next move:* write your opinion on a sticky note and put it face down. At the end, ask permission. If the answer is no, the note goes in the bin, and that's fine.

4. Every statement sounds the same. Same opening, same adjectives, any piece. *What it usually means:* the student is writing a statement shape, not about a piece. *Next move:* start every statement from one specific studio moment, like a mistake, a surprise, or the second the piece changed. No two pieces have the same moment.

When to slow down. If critique still stings after a month, stay with VTS on master works and the notes-only rule for longer. Nothing is lost. A student who can lead VTS well has a real skill.

When to go ahead. If your student starts asking specific questions about their own work without being prompted ("Does the edge on the left feel too hard?"), move to full CRP and invite a second responder.

When to find another teacher. When your student is ready for more than family eyes, find a co-op critique group, a community studio class with a regular critique, or a portfolio review. That's a sign the chapter worked, not that you fell short. Check each venue's age rules and format first.

The rescue order holds here as everywhere: ask, wait, hint, a short demonstration (here, you describing one small thing out loud), then hand the critique back.

Tools, including AI

The Art Hour's AI box has the full rules. For this chapter:

- **After your student's own critique**, you may ask an assistant for three neutral questions about a cropped photo of the work, with no faces, no grade, and no redraw. Read them aloud as extra prompts, and your student decides whether any are useful. The student's critique comes first, always.
- **A model never writes the statement, the captions, or any part of either.** It doesn't draft, outline, "improve," or "check the tone." If AI was used anywhere in making a piece, the student describes that use exactly on the whose-mark card and in any field that asks.
- **A character counter and a timer** are the only tools most of this chapter needs.

What "done enough" looks like

Before moving on, or as a check each term:

- ☐ Four monthly critiques held, with the student chairing at least two.
- ☐ One critique from outside the family: a co-op, class, or portfolio review.
- ☐ A notes page and a next-day reply exist for at least one critique.
- ☐ A 100-word statement for every portfolio candidate, in the student's own words.
- ☐ At 17–18: captions for three works written under the AP limits, a written investigation question, and a 300-word artist statement the student can defend in conversation.
- ☐ Citations on every piece that used a reference.
- ☐ The student can explain why opinions come last.

Placement is by skill and independence, not birthday. A fifteen-year-old who chairs CRP calmly is doing 17–18 work. An eighteen-year-old meeting critique for the first time starts with VTS on a museum painting. Both are doing the real thing.

Chapter 8 — Portfolio, assessment, and progress checks



Why this matters

Every family has a drawer or a box somewhere with a child's old drawings in it. Open it, and you can see a person growing up: the tadpole figures, the careful horses, the first drawing that actually looked like the dog. Nobody graded those. They're still the best evidence anyone has.

This chapter turns that drawer into something a stranger can read. At 15–18, your student’s art has readers outside the family for the first time: an evaluator, a registrar, an admissions reader, an AP scorer, a contest juror, and, most importantly, the student, who deserves to see what they’ve done. All of them need the same thing, which is evidence. That means dated work, honest labels, a record of time, and a small set of pieces chosen for a reason.

Here is what assessment means in this book. It isn’t a percentile, and it isn’t a stack of worksheets. It’s:

- a **dated archive** of everything finished, photographed and logged
- a **monthly progress check** on the eight studio habits
- a **whose-mark card** on every piece that might be shown
- **before/after pairs** that make growth visible
- at 17–18, **self-scoring against a published rubric**
- a **semester grade** you can explain from the evidence
- a **credit evidence file** for the transcript
- and, for students who want one, a **curated portfolio** built to current, dated requirements

The focus line holds all of it together. *See long before you judge* now points at the student’s own year of work, looked at fairly before anyone decides what it adds up to. *Sketch before you polish* shows up as process, and AP, RISD, and National Portfolio Day reviewers all ask to see it. And *sign only what you made* is the whose-mark card: an honest account of whose marks are on each piece.

One more thing, said once. The portfolio is a by-product of a good studio year, not its purpose. A student can finish this book without AP, without art school, and without ever uploading anything, and still have a full, credit-bearing art life. For those who do want those doors, this chapter gives accurate, dated facts and a calm way to meet them.

For the parent: understand it yourself

The everyday picture: the family photo album and the slideshow. You keep every photo in the album, even the blurry ones. That’s the archive. When there’s a wedding or a birthday, somebody picks thirty photos, puts them in order, and makes a slideshow for that particular room. That’s a portfolio. You’d never make the slideshow by deleting the album, and you’d never show the whole album at a wedding. Keep everything, then choose for each audience.

The precise picture: evidence plus judgment. Assessment at this age has two parts. The evidence is the log, the archive, the monthly checks, the cards, and the pairs. The judgment is a grade, a self-score, or a portfolio selection that someone can trace back to that evidence. If you can put your finger on the page behind every line of your records, your assessment is sound.

The eight studio habits. Researchers who videotaped 38 visual-arts classes in two arts-intensive high schools, Walnut Hill School for the Arts and Boston Arts Academy, described eight habits that serious art teachers teach.^{6,2} They were observed in high-school studios, which makes them a natural measure for this age. In plain words:

Habit	What it looks like
Develop Craft	You can control the tool and keep a tidy, safe studio.
Engage and Persist	You stay with a hard piece past the boring middle.
Envision	You can picture what isn't there yet and plan for it.
Express	The work says something beyond "I can draw."
Observe	You look longer and more closely than people usually do.
Reflect	You can say what's working, what isn't, and why.
Stretch and Explore	You try things you might fail at, on purpose.
Understand Art Worlds	You know some of the history and people your work talks to.

These are described teaching goals, not measured outcomes, and nobody has shown that practicing them raises scores in other subjects. They're simply a fair, specific language for what a year of art built.

The whose-mark card, grown up. One card or form per filed piece:

1. **Title, medium, size, date, hours.**
2. **My marks:** what I made by hand or by my own decisions (drew, painted, shot, edited, designed).
3. **Tools:** analog and digital, including editing steps (crop, exposure, color).
4. **References:** every image or work I looked at, cited (artist or photographer, title, date, source).
5. **Help:** who helped and how (a demonstration, a critique note, a model who sat).
6. **AI:** "none," or exactly what, when, and how. Never in the final work.
7. **Consent:** for any person shown, plus a release if the piece is entered or posted.
8. **Signature line:** "I made the marks and choices described here."

The rule is simple. If "My marks" can't be filled in honestly, it isn't portfolio work. Notice what the card doesn't ban. Grids, references, a community teacher's demonstration, and a critique note are all fine when they're named. The card simply makes the naming a habit, and it's the same habit AP, art schools, and contests now ask for.

AP Art and Design, as of this writing. AP Art and Design (2-D Art and Design, 3-D Art and Design, and Drawing) is a portfolio, not a sit-down exam. For 2026–27 it has two sections.¹⁷

- **Sustained Investigation, 60% of the score.** Fifteen digital images of work united by one guiding inquiry, including images of process, plus typed written responses.
- **Selected Works, 40%.** Five works that show skill and a synthesis of materials, processes, and ideas. For 3-D Art and Design, that's ten images, two views each of five works.

The submission deadline is **Friday, 7 May 2027, 11:59 PM ET**. Homeschooled students submit

through a **local authorized school**. An AP coordinator there sets up an exam-only section, and exam orders are due in mid-November, so start looking for a school in early fall.^{52,53} The coordinator can review submissions and may report policy violations.

The scoring guidance is plain about one thing: “Automated imagery is not evidence of skill.”¹⁷ AP’s 2026–27 AI policy allows generative AI only for **research, ideation, practice, experimentation, and revision**, never in final submitted work, and all AI use must be disclosed.¹⁶ There’s a wrinkle, though. AP’s Digital Portfolio terms and conditions, dated January 2026, still say generative AI is “categorically prohibited at any stage of the creative process.”¹⁸ The newer policy guide acknowledges that earlier materials may show older restrictions. This book’s rule is stricter than both for the work itself: no generated image anywhere in the portfolio, process images included, and no model-written words. For an AP student, the simplest course is to use no AI at all in making the portfolio. That satisfies either document. The sketchbook does the ideation job better anyway. If your coordinator gives you different guidance, follow the coordinator and keep to the house rule.

Art schools, as of this writing. Requirements differ by school and change every year. Here’s what the admissions pages said on 28 September 2026:

- **RISD:** 12–20 examples, with up to three process slides. Drawing from direct observation is strongly recommended.³³
- **SAIC:** 10–15 pieces. It discourages work copied or rendered directly from photographs, and asks applicants to list collaborators.³⁴
- **Pratt:** 10–20 resolved works from the last 18 months, including 3–5 from direct observation, labelled with medium, dimensions, and year. It bans images fully rendered by AI and AI-written text in essays and descriptions.¹⁹
- **National Portfolio Day:** bring up to 10–12 pieces. Works in progress are welcome.⁵¹
- **Scholastic Art & Writing Awards:** final work generated by AI is ineligible.¹¹

Re-check every requirement every year, at the start of the student’s senior-year planning and again before submitting. Copy the requirement onto a sheet and date it. That dated sheet prevents most November surprises.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **“I didn’t photograph that one. It’s at Grandma’s.”** *What it usually means:* no archive habit yet. *Your move:* photograph work the day it’s finished, before it leaves the house. For pieces already gone, ask for a photo and log what you can.
2. **“My portfolio is everything I’ve made.”** *What it usually means:* the archive and the portfolio haven’t been separated. *Your move:* keep everything in the archive. The portfolio is chosen, for one reader at a time.
3. **A semester grade that’s really a grade for effort.** “She worked so hard, so it’s an A.” *What it usually means:* a kind heart and no written standard. *Your move:* write the standard before the semester, grade the evidence, and keep effort in the conversation as a note beside the grade rather than as the grade itself.
4. **The November scramble.** Fifteen images due, eight made, no process photos, requirements

never read. *What it usually means:* nobody checked the dated requirement in August. *Your move:* requirement sheets in late summer, a sustained investigation plan by early fall, and a monthly check that includes “on track?”

5. A strong piece with outside help and no card. A community-class painting where the teacher repainted a corner, or a photo with a background someone “fixed.” *What it usually means:* an authorship gap, usually confusion rather than deceit. *Your move:* fill the card honestly. If the teacher’s marks are in the piece, it’s a class study, not portfolio work. A generated background means reshooting.

Your warm-up (fifteen minutes, alone)

Photograph and log five pieces your student made this year: title, medium, size, date, and a guess at hours. Then look at what’s missing. Can you find the process? The references? The date? Most parents find that the finished work is easy to find and everything else has evaporated. That gap is what this week fixes.

How to teach it this week

First try-it: the archive, then a monthly progress check.

Start with the archive, because it’s practical and nobody’s work is being judged. Pick a spot near a window on an overcast day, or anywhere with soft, even light. Tape the work flat, hold the phone square to it, fill the frame, and crop to the edge. Chapter 5 covers photographing 2-D work in detail. Set up a simple spreadsheet or notebook with one line per piece:

Date finished · Title · Medium · Size · Hours · Photo file name · Card? (Y/N)

Say: “Let’s get this year into the archive. You hold the camera. I’ll type.”

Log everything finished, including studies and pieces that didn’t work. The archive is the album, not the slideshow.

Then run the first **monthly progress check**. Your student pulls three pieces from the past month, looks at the eight studio habits, and marks each habit for each piece as *clear here*, *starting*, or *not here yet*. That three-step scale is a house convention, not a validated instrument. The student then writes two sentences: one about a habit that grew, one about next month’s focus. You add one sentence of your own, something you can point to. File it with the date.

Exact wording to keep in your pocket.

- “Log it the day it’s done.”
- “Which habit grew this month?”
- “Which of these would you defend to a stranger?”
- “What’s the current requirement, and what’s today’s date?”
- “Can you fill in ‘My marks’ honestly?”

How to fade your help. In month one, you type the log and sit beside the check. By month two, the student logs during Friday File and runs the check alone, and you add your one sentence. At 17–18, the student runs the whole system, including requirement sheets and the investigation calendar, and you initial the monthly check the way you initial the Monday plan.

When to stop talking. When your student starts laying pieces out and moving them around. Sorting is where the real judgment happens, and a parent’s “Oh, I love that one” tilts it. Stay quiet until they ask.

Band moves.

15–16. Keep the archive, run the monthly check, make two before/after pairs a year, and put whose-mark cards on every candidate. A semester grade comes from evidence, and 100-word statements go with the strongest pieces. No portfolio pressure. At this age the archive is the achievement.

17–18. Add everything portfolio: pull the best 20, edit and sequence, plan a sustained investigation of 15 images, gather an observation set, check dated requirements for each program, and prepare for a review. The student self-scores against a published rubric, and the credit evidence file becomes their job, with you checking it.

Place by skill and independence, not birthday. A sixteen-year-old with a clear question can start a sustained investigation. A seventeen-year-old who began art last spring stays with the archive and monthly checks, and that’s a sound year.

A year of assessment, sketched

- **Every Friday:** File. Log new pieces, write cards for candidates, and add hours.
- **Monthly:** the progress check, a wall critique (Chapter 7), and a sketchbook page review.
- **Twice a year:** a before/after pair.
- **Each semester:** a review and grade, and the evidence file updated.
- **For 17–18 applicants:** requirement sheets in late summer; the investigation plan in September; the observation set gathered by fall of senior year; a portfolio review in the fall; the AP exam order through the coordinator by mid-November if AP is in the plan; submission by the dated deadlines.

Practice that actually builds learning

Each try-it lists time, materials, mess and safety, the pull, and the skill.⁵⁴

In-home try-its

The whose-mark card (both bands)

- *Time:* about 5 minutes per piece
- *Materials:* printed cards or a form; the reference list from Chapter 7
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The pull:* it’s the card that lets a student say, flatly and truthfully, “All of this is mine.”

- *The skill:* fill in all eight lines for every portfolio candidate. Be exact about tools and references. If “My marks” can’t be filled in honestly, the piece stays in the archive as a study.

Before/after pair (both bands)

- *Time:* 45 minutes
- *Materials:* a piece from about six months ago; the same kind of subject set up again
- *Mess/safety:* whatever the medium needs
- *The pull:* proof, in your own hand, that you’ve improved. For many students, this is when they stop believing in “talent” and start believing in practice.
- *The skill:* redo the old subject under similar conditions. Pin both side by side and name three specific differences (“the ellipse on the cup rim is measured now”; “there are five values instead of three”). If the student can’t see any, you name one first, then they find two.

Self-score against a published rubric (17–18)

- *Time:* 45 minutes
- *Materials:* the current AP Art and Design scoring guidelines (or a college’s published rubric); the student’s current portfolio section
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The pull:* seeing your work the way a scorer will, before the scorer does.
- *The skill:* AP scores the Sustained Investigation on four criteria, with these weights for 2026–27. *Inquiry* (a clear guiding question, stated in writing) counts 20%. *Practice, experimentation, and revision* counts 30%. *Synthesis* of materials, processes, and ideas counts 30%. *Skill* in 2-D, 3-D, or drawing counts 20%.¹⁷ The student scores their own section one row at a time, and you score separately. Then compare. Where you differ, look for the evidence together. The aim is a realistic self-assessment, not a predicted score.

Sustained investigation plan (17–18)

- *Time:* one session to plan, then all year
- *Materials:* the investigation question (Chapter 7); a calendar; a wall or board
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The pull:* fifteen images sounds impossible until it’s three chapters of five on the wall.
- *The skill:* write the question at the top. Plan fifteen images in three chapters of five, with process images included (thumbnails, studies, stage photos, a revision that failed). Put monthly checkpoints on the calendar. Each chapter can shift the question slightly. The AP guidance expects inquiry to develop, and a question that changes with evidence is a sign of real investigation. If the plan stalls, narrow the question until you can see it.

Pull, edit, and sequence (17–18)

- *Time:* two 45-minute sessions
- *Materials:* prints or thumbnails of the archive; floor or table space
- *Mess/safety:* none
- *The pull:* it’s curating a small show of your own work.
- *The skill:* session one, pull 20 and sort them into *strong*, *maybe*, and *no*. The test is “Which would I defend to a stranger?” Session two, cut to the target number for one reader (the program’s current count) and put them in order. Open and close with the strongest, and

let the middle show range and thinking. Make sure the observation work is visible. Each program gets its own sequence, drawn from the same archive.

The observation set (both bands; gathered at 17–18)

- *Time*: ongoing
- *Materials*: the best work from Chapter 3
- *Mess/safety*: consent noted for any person drawn
- *The pull*: this is what art-school reviewers ask for by name.
- *The skill*: gather the three to five strongest pieces drawn from direct observation, such as a mirror self-portrait, a clothed figure, a long still life, or a place. Schedule one long observation piece a month so the set keeps improving. Aim to have it ready by fall of senior year.

Semester review and grade (both bands)

- *Time*: 45 minutes
- *Materials*: the hour log, the archive, the monthly checks, the cards, the done-enough lists, and the written standard
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The pull*: a grade the student helped reach and understands.
- *The skill*: lay out the evidence. Check it against the written standard (see below) one line at a time, agree on a grade, and write a two-sentence semester line with reasons. Grade the evidence, not the effort alone. If you disagree, the evidence decides.

The credit evidence file (both bands; the student's job at 17–18)

- *Time*: 30 minutes a semester
- *Materials*: a folder, paper or digital
- *Mess/safety*: none
- *The pull*: a file a stranger could audit, which is a quietly satisfying thing to own.
- *The skill*: the hours log, the course description, samples (photos of about ten pieces plus tabbed sketchbook pages the student chose), monthly checks, before/after pairs, and the grade with its reasons. Chapter 9 turns this file into a transcript line.

A written standard for the semester grade

This is a method, not a validated rubric. Write it at the start of the semester, adjust it to your year, and keep it in the file.

1. **Habit**: hours logged weekly; daily pages on most days.
2. **Range or depth**: at 15–16, finished work in at least three chapters' media; at 17–18, investigation work on schedule.
3. **Seeing**: at least one long observation piece a month.
4. **Critique and words**: monthly critiques held; statements in the student's own words for candidates.
5. **Honesty**: a whose-mark card on every candidate; citations where references were used.
6. **Growth**: a before/after pair or monthly checks that show change you can point to.

A reasonable way to convert: an A means every line is met with evidence and at least one piece stretched the student; a B means most lines are met; a C means the habit held but several lines are thin. Use the same scale every year so the transcript means the same thing each time.

Out-of-home try-it

Portfolio review prep, and a review (17–18)

- *Time*: two hours of prep, then the event
- *Materials*: 10–12 pieces or images; the sketchbook; one written question per piece
- *Mess/safety*: the student chooses what to bring. You check the event’s format and whether a parent should come along.
- *Venue rules*: National Portfolio Day events suggest bringing up to 10–12 pieces, welcome works in progress, and hold short reviews, in person and online.⁵¹ Community art centers and co-ops sometimes run their own reviews. Check each current page.
- *The pull*: a reviewer who does this for a living takes your work seriously for fifteen minutes.
- *The skill*: pack or load the pieces in sequence. Write one question per piece, take notes during the review (Chapter 7’s notes-only rule), and afterward choose one note to act on this month. Bring the sketchbook, because reviewers like process.

Talk box (this chapter)

Opening (locked): “If a stranger saw only these pieces, what would they learn about how you think?”

Follow-ups:

1. “Which piece opens?” (sequence and first impressions)
2. “Where’s the observation work?” (evidence of seeing)
3. “What’s missing?” (honest gaps)
4. “Which card would you want a reviewer to read?” (process and authorship)
5. “Would you change the order now?” (revision, their choice)

How to wait. Count a slow three, then wait again after the first answer. Here the wait is often longer, because the student is judging their own year, and that’s harder than judging a museum painting. Look at the pieces, not at your student.

What stuck silence usually means at this age. They see the gaps and don’t want to say them. They think “how you think” means “how smart you are.” They’re hunting for an admissions-sounding answer. Or they’ve already guessed which piece you like best. Try listing the gaps together, calmly, as next month’s plan: “So we need one more observation piece and some process photos. That’s October.” “Not today” is allowed.

Don’t say: “This one’s your best. Put it first.” **Say instead**: “If a stranger saw only these pieces, what would they learn about how you think?”

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked: for the first months, run only the monthly checks and archive, with no portfolio talk at all. The habit of honest looking comes before any selection for an audience.

Mixed: once a term, run a progress check and an edit session in the same week. The habits the check names (“Observe is still thin”) tell the edit what’s missing.

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration)

This is a composite, not a real student. A seventeen-year-old lays out a 20-piece “portfolio” for an art-school application. It holds eight digital character illustrations, four finished acrylic paintings of different subjects, three photographs, two graphite portraits drawn from phone photos, a watercolor landscape, a pen drawing of a car, and a design for a band poster. Everything is finished and polished. There are no process images, no observation work, no cards, and no common question.

Ask your student: “What would a stranger learn about how this person thinks?”

Mostly that they can finish things. There’s no visible thinking, no question, and no sign of looking at anything real. The two portraits from phone photos run straight into SAIC’s stated caution. With no work from direct observation, Pratt’s 3–5 and RISD’s recommendation aren’t met.^{33,34,19} None of this is a judgment of talent. The illustrations may be the strongest work in the room.

Here’s the fix. Keep the five strongest finished pieces. Add three to five observation pieces over the next two months: a mirror self-portrait, a long still life, a place drawn on site. Pair the best pieces with process images (thumbnails, stage photos, a layer history for the digital work). Write a card for every piece. If there’s time, let two or three illustrations grow into a small investigation with a question. The result is fewer, better-chosen pieces, with the thinking visible.

A composite: the digital portfolio with no observation (illustration)

Another composite. A seventeen-year-old aiming at art school has a strong digital portfolio and no life drawing at all. He’s skeptical: “Nobody draws from life anymore.”

His parent didn’t argue. They printed the current requirement pages for three schools, dated them, and put them on the table. The student read them himself. That month he started drawing his own hand on the tablet from life, with time-lapse on (Chapter 5), and one charcoal self-portrait in a mirror each week (Chapter 3). By December his observation set held four pieces, two digital and two charcoal, and his digital illustrations had begun to look more solid. He hadn’t expected that part.

For the student

Here’s the difference that matters: **the archive is everything; the portfolio is a choice.** Log and photograph every finished piece, including the ones that didn’t work. When someone asks to see your work, you choose from the archive for that reader. Keep your sketchbook private unless you decide otherwise.

Your progress checks are for you. Once a month, pull three pieces and look at them against the eight studio habits. Which habits are clear, which are starting, and which aren't there yet? Write two sentences. After six months, those pages will show you growth you couldn't see week by week.

The whose-mark card goes with every piece you might show anyone. It covers what you made, what tools you used, what references you looked at, who helped, any AI use, and consent for any person shown. If you can't honestly fill in "My marks," the piece isn't portfolio work. It can still be a useful study.

Requirements change every year. Before you build a portfolio for any program (AP, an art school, a contest), copy the current requirement onto a sheet and write today's date on it. Check it again before you submit.

Worked example: one archive line and its card

Archive: 14 Nov 2026 · *Stairwell, 4 p.m.* · charcoal on paper · 18 × 24 in · 6 h · stairwell-4pm.jpg · Card: Y

Card: *My marks:* all drawing, from life, three sessions on the back stairs. *Tools:* vine and compressed charcoal, kneaded eraser, a pencil for measuring; photo cropped and exposure adjusted only. *References:* none; drawn on site. *Help:* my mother's critique note ("the bottom step is the darkest thing — is that what you want?"). *AI:* none. *Consent:* no people shown. *Signed:* I made the marks and choices described here.

That's one piece, fully accounted for. Fifteen of those, with process, makes a sustained investigation.

Two tries

1. Log your last five finished pieces in the archive, with photos, today.
2. Pull your best 20 from the archive and sort them into *strong*, *maybe*, and *no*. Use one test: which would you defend to a stranger?

Explain it back

What's the difference between an archive and a portfolio? Explain it to someone at home, using your own work.

Challenge

Put a 15-image sustained investigation plan on your wall. Write the question at the top, then three chapters of five images, with process included and a month beside each chapter. Revise it whenever the question changes, and date each revision.

A word about AI

A picture a program generates isn't your work, however good the prompt was. The U.S. Copyright Office put it plainly in 2025: authorship requires a human who determined the expressive elements, "not the mere provision of prompts."¹⁵ AP says "automated imagery is not evidence of skill," Pratt bans AI-rendered images, and Scholastic won't accept AI-generated final work. The house rule is simpler than any of theirs. No generated image goes in your portfolio, and any AI use goes on the card.

If it isn't clicking

1. The archive keeps falling behind. Twenty pieces unlogged, photos scattered across three phones. *What it usually means:* logging is a separate chore instead of part of the Hour. *Next move:* log during Friday File, every week, five minutes. Catch up on the backlog in one Saturday session, then never let it get past a week again.

2. They can't choose. Every piece is either a masterpiece or garbage, depending on the hour. *What it usually means:* choosing by mood instead of by reader. *Next move:* strong, maybe, and no piles, with one test ("Would you defend it to a stranger?"). You break ties only when asked. If it's still stuck, choose for one specific reader, such as the RISD page or the Scholastic category.

3. The investigation stalls at image six. *What it usually means:* the question is too broad, or too small to carry fifteen pieces. *Next move:* split it into three chapters of five, and let the second chapter change one thing: scale, medium, time of day, or viewpoint. Rewrite the question with a verb you can see (Chapter 7).

4. Admissions anxiety takes over. Every piece becomes "for the portfolio," and the fun drains out. *What it usually means:* the door has become the house. *Next move:* return to the house. For two weeks, no portfolio talk. Daily pages, one long observation piece, a museum visit. The portfolio is a by-product of a good studio year, and a good studio year needs some work that's for nobody.

When to slow down. If monthly checks show no change for three months, spend a few weeks back in Chapter 3's measuring and long drawings. The check just told you something useful. That's its job.

When to go ahead. If the student sequences, cards, and self-scores without prompting, they're ready for an outside review and, if they want it, a contest entry or an application.

When to find another teacher. A portfolio review, a community class with regular critique, or a dual-enrollment drawing course gives your student outside eyes. That's a gift, not a failure. Check age rules and formats first.

Tools, including AI

The Art Hour's AI box has the full rules. For this chapter:

- **Non-generative photo edits are fine.** Cropping, straightening, and adjusting exposure, contrast, or color so the photo matches the real piece all count. AP allows these at every stage.¹⁶
- **No generated image in any portfolio.** That includes generative fill, expand, or background replacement on a photo of real work. If a photo needs a background fixed, reshoot it.
- **Any AI use goes on the card, described exactly.** On the AP route, it's also disclosed in the portfolio fields AP names. The house default is simpler: none needed.
- **No AI detectors as grades.** They're unreliable and have been shown to misjudge human writing.²² The honesty tools in this book are the card, the process images, and the archive.
- **A spreadsheet, a phone camera, and a calendar** do almost everything this chapter asks.

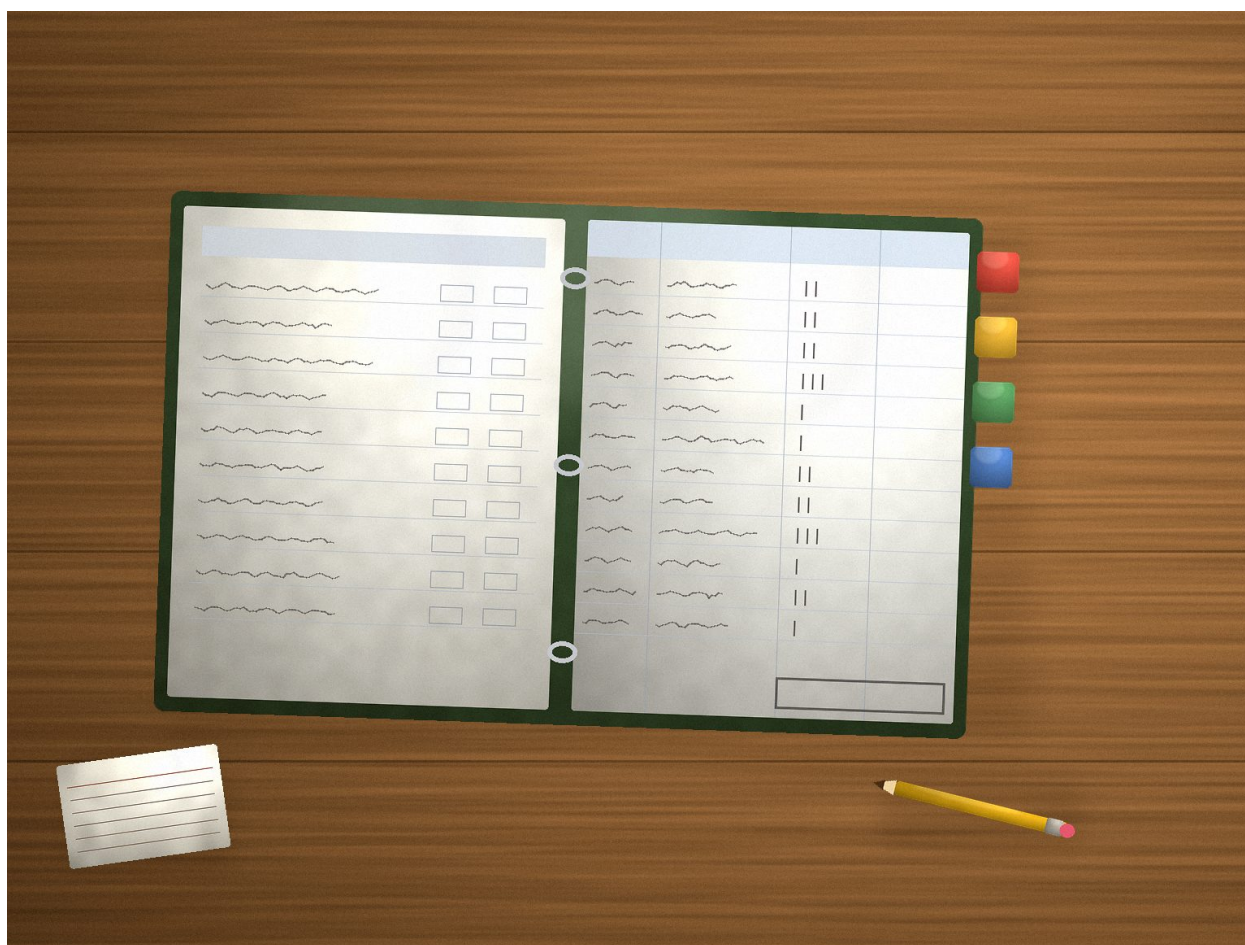
What “done enough” looks like

Before closing a semester:

- ☐ A complete, dated archive with a photo of every finished piece.
- ☐ Monthly progress checks filed, with the student's two sentences and your one.
- ☐ Two before/after pairs this year.
- ☐ A whose-mark card for every portfolio candidate.
- ☐ A semester grade with reasons, written against a standard set in advance.
- ☐ The credit evidence file updated.
- ☐ For 17–18 applicants: a sequenced portfolio for each program, checked against a dated requirement sheet, with the observation set in place and the investigation on schedule.

Placement is by skill and independence, not birthday. A sixteen-year-old with a clear question can run the full portfolio sequence. An eighteen-year-old in a first art year keeps the archive and monthly checks, and ends with a half-credit or a full one that's entirely honest.

Chapter 9 — Records, credit, and next steps



The art happened in the studio corner: the long still life under the taped lamp mark, the stairwell drawn three afternoons running, the critique where your student asked their own question first. A record is how that year makes sense to someone who wasn't there. That might be a registrar, an admissions reader, an evaluator, a scholarship committee, or your student at twenty-five, trying to remember what they did at sixteen.

This chapter turns a year of art into a credit a stranger can read. It covers hours, course titles, descriptions, grades, and the evidence file behind them, and then the doors some families want to open: AP, dual enrollment, art schools, contests. Those doors are real, and this chapter describes them carefully. They're still doors, though, not the house. A plain, honest credit in Art I, earned in

about 120 logged hours, is a complete high-school art record.

You're in good company. About 3.1 percent of U.S. students in grades 9 through 12 were home-schooled in 2022–23.^{29,1} Registrars read homeschool transcripts all the time. A clear one makes their job easy, and a clear one is not hard to write.

This week you can do two things. Start the hour log, and write a working course title at the top of it. Everything else builds from those.

What a stranger needs to see

A good art record answers three questions for someone busy, fair, and curious:

1. **What was studied?** A plain course title and a short description.
2. **How much?** Hours from a log.
3. **What came of it?** A grade with reasons, and evidence behind it: the archive, monthly checks, cards, and samples.

The first two fit on one page. The third is the credit evidence file from Chapter 8. If a reader ever asks, you can say “here” and hand it over.

Hours and credit

How much is a credit? A high-school credit, often called a Carnegie unit after the foundation that introduced it in 1906, typically represents about 120 hours of study: classes meeting four or five times a week for 40 to 60 minutes across a school year.⁴ HSLDA, a homeschool advocacy organization, suggests counting an elective like art as one credit at 120 or more logged hours and a half credit at 60 or more. It also notes that parents determine credit, and that some states use different scales.⁵ New York defines a unit as 6,480 minutes of instruction, which is 108 hours.⁵⁵

Where the hours come from. The Art Hour rhythm reaches a credit without heroics. Here's one worked year, offered as arithmetic, not a mandate:

- Three 50-minute Art Hours a week for 32 weeks comes to about 80 hours.
- A 12-minute daily page, five days a week for 32 weeks, adds about 32 hours.
- Two museum or gallery visits and one portfolio review add about 10 hours.

That's roughly 122 hours, or about one elective credit. A community class term or independent studio blocks at 17–18 add more. A lighter year of about 60 honest hours is a half credit, and that's a real credit.

The log. One line per session, kept weekly during Friday File:

7 Oct · 50 min · Art Hour · Still life, session 2 (value); critique: VTS on own piece. 8 Oct · 12 min · Daily page · Kettle, left hand. 12 Oct · 2 h · Outing · Museum visit, one question (“How do painters show wet?”); three sketches. 16 Oct · 90 min · Community class · Wheel-throwing, week 3 of 10.

Record the date, the minutes, what kind of session it was, and one line on what happened. Keep it in a notebook, a spreadsheet, or the back of the Monday-plan card, whatever you'll actually use. A log kept weekly is honest. A log rebuilt from memory in May is shaky, and multiplying 180 days by an hour isn't a log at all.

Outings count. So do community classes, portfolio reviews, museum visits with a sketchbook, and studio time the student chose. Hours spent scrolling for “inspiration” don't.

The course title

The course title is the first thing a stranger reads, and often the only thing. Here is the house rule, in full:

Course titles: Art I, Art II, Art III, Art IV; Drawing; Painting; Photography; Digital Art and Media; Ceramics; Sculpture; Printmaking; Art History; Art Appreciation; Art Portfolio. “AP” only when the course is authorized through the AP Course Audit, using the exact College Board title. “Honors” only with a written standard in the course description. Dual-enrollment courses listed with the college's name; the college sends its own transcript. Never a brand, “Art Hour,” “AP Art,” “AP Studio Art,” or Emerging Adults Art I.

These names come from public course vocabularies, such as the Texas high-school art course list and the national course codes schools use to share data.⁵⁶ A registrar anywhere will recognize them.

How to choose.

If the year was mostly...	Title
A first full year of general studio work across media	Art I
A later general year	Art II, Art III, Art IV
One medium (most of the hours in it)	Drawing, Painting, Photography, Digital Art and Media, Ceramics, Sculpture, or Printmaking (a roman numeral is optional: Drawing I, Drawing II)
Looking, reading, and writing about art	Art History , or Art Appreciation for a lighter survey
A senior year built around a portfolio	Art Portfolio
About 60 hours	Any of the above, marked (0.5)

When in doubt, choose Art I or Art II. Ceramics, Sculpture, and Printmaking usually mean hours at a community studio, since kilns and presses belong there, not at home.

AP, exactly. “AP” on a homeschool transcript requires authorization through the College Board's AP Course Audit.⁵⁷ A homeschool provider submits documentation of homeschool status (a signed letter of intent is acceptable), the subject-specific audit form, and a syllabus, either adopted or

original. Only then may the course carry an AP title, and only the College Board’s current name: **AP 2-D Art and Design**, **AP 3-D Art and Design**, **AP Drawing**, or **AP Art History**. A student can study independently and submit the AP portfolio or sit the AP Art History exam without an audited course. In that case, the course keeps a plain title (Drawing II, for example) and the AP score is reported separately.

Names to keep off the transcript. “AP Art” and “AP Studio Art” aren’t current College Board course names. You may still see “AP Studio Art” in older state or national course-code lists, which is exactly why it’s worth a warning.⁵⁶ A curriculum’s brand name doesn’t go in the title, and neither does “Art Hour,” this book’s title, or anything like **Emerging Adults Art I**. None of those tells a stranger what was studied. A program you used can be named in the description if it helps.

Honors, if you want it

Honors is optional. If you use it, the course description has to say in writing what made the course honors-level, and the evidence file has to show it was met. Here’s one standard you could adopt or adapt:

Honors standard: a sustained investigation of 15 works with process documentation, a 300-word artist statement in the student’s own words, and at least one outside review or juried entry, in addition to the regular course requirements.

HSLDA’s guidance points out that honors and AP courses take more work, not more credit.⁵ An honors course is still one credit. Whether it earns a weighted grade is up to your grading policy, so state that policy on the transcript and apply it the same way every year. “Honors Art” with no written standard is a line a careful reader will question.

Writing the course description

One paragraph for a stranger: title, year, hours, media, major projects, how it was assessed. Here are three patterns:

Art I (grade 10, 2026–27; 1.0 credit). Daily sketchbook practice; observational drawing (measuring, value, long still life, mirror self-portrait, clothed figure gesture with consent); watercolor, gouache, and acrylic; phone photography and digital drawing from life; art history through a drawn timeline and museum visits; student-led critique and 100-word artist statements. Assessed by monthly progress checks on eight studio habits, a dated archive, and a semester review against a written standard. About 124 hours logged.

Drawing (grade 11, 2027–28; 1.0 credit). Observational and figure drawing in graphite, charcoal, and ink, plus digital drawing from life with process capture; a series of long still lifes and portrait sittings; two community clothed-model sessions; monthly critique and one outside portfolio review. Includes a 10-week community drawing class (about 20 hours).

Art Portfolio (grade 12, 2028–29; 1.0 credit). A sustained investigation of 15 works with process documentation on the question “How does one room change across a day?”; an observation set; captions and a 300-word artist statement written by the student; portfolio reviews; submission to AP Drawing as an independent student (score reported separately).

Each one uses plain words and names media, projects, outings, and assessment, and none claims anything the file can’t show. There’s no need to mention the whose-mark cards in the description. They’re in the file, and they show that every piece was the student’s own.

One more thing a description shouldn’t do is claim that art raised the student’s scores in other subjects. The best evidence doesn’t support that claim, and art needs no such justification.^{2,3}

A grade from evidence

Chapter 8 set out a written standard and a semester review. Here’s how it becomes a transcript grade:

1. **Write the standard before the semester starts**, in plain words (Chapter 8 has a model).
2. **At the semester review**, check the evidence against each line. Is there a page behind it?
3. **Convert to a letter** using the same scale you use for every other course, and print that scale on the transcript.
4. **Keep the reasons** in two sentences in the evidence file: “All six lines met; the long observation series and the outside review stretched her. A.”

Effort and growth belong in the conversation, and in the file, with evidence. “Before/after pairs show measured proportions by March” is evidence. “Worked very hard” is true and kind, but it doesn’t stand alone. The sketchbook itself is never graded. It’s where bad drawings are allowed, and it has to stay that way.

The credit evidence file

This is the folder, paper or digital, that stands behind the transcript line. At 17–18 the student maintains it and you check it.

- The **hour log**, with totals.
- The **course description**.
- The **written standard** and the **semester grade with reasons**.
- **Samples**: photos of about ten pieces across the year, with their whose-mark cards.
- **Tabbed sketchbook pages** the student chose. The sketchbook stays private in the way that matters: the student picks what a reader sees.
- **Monthly progress checks** and **before/after pairs**.
- **Outside records**: community-class certificates or receipts, dual-enrollment syllabi, contest or review notes.

A dozen well-chosen items beat a crate. If a reader asks for “everything,” it’s reasonable to offer

the file and the portfolio and explain that the sketchbook is a practice space. Most readers kept a private notebook once themselves, and they understand.

Honest lines and dishonest lines

Honest	Not honest
Art I — 1.0 — 124 hours from a weekly log	Art I — 1.0 — “180 days × 1 hour” with no log
Drawing II — 1.0 — AP Drawing score reported separately	AP Drawing, with no AP Course Audit authorization
Art I (Honors) with the standard printed in the description	Honors Art, with no written standard
Photography — 0.5	Photography — 1.0, for 50 hours
ART 101 Drawing I (Anytown Community College) , dual enrollment; official college transcript sent separately	Drawing I, with no college named
Art Portfolio — student statements in the student’s own words	A statement a model drafted, or a parent rewrote
Painting — including a 10-week community acrylic class	A brand name as the course title

The honest column protects your student. Every line has a page behind it.

AP for homeschoolers

AP is optional, and it’s accurate to say so. If your student wants it:

- **AP Art and Design** (2-D, 3-D, or Drawing) is a portfolio, submitted digitally. Chapter 8 has the structure. For 2026–27, the deadline is **Friday, 7 May 2027, 11:59 PM ET**.⁵²
- **AP Art History** is a written exam covering ten units, from global prehistory to global contemporary. The College Board describes it as equivalent to a two-semester introductory college art history course. It has no prerequisite, and the 2027 exam is on Wednesday, 12 May.⁴⁶
- **Homeschoolers test through a local authorized school.** You find one through the AP Course Ledger and contact its AP coordinator. For the Art and Design portfolio, the coordinator sets up an exam-only section. Exam orders are due in mid-November, so make contact in early fall, not in spring.⁵³
- **The score and the title are separate** unless the course was audited. An independent student’s transcript keeps a plain title, and the AP score goes in its own section or on the College Board’s score report.
- **College credit varies by college.** Some give credit or placement for AP scores, some don’t, and art schools can be stricter. RISD, for example, doesn’t accept AP or IB credit from art or studio classes.³³ Check each college’s current credit policy.

Dual enrollment and community classes

Dual enrollment means taking a college course for college credit, and usually high-school credit too, while still in high school. Good first art courses are Drawing I, 2-D Design, and an art history survey. Age minimums, placement rules, and studio seat availability vary by college, so the parent checks. On the home transcript, list the course in the year taken, with the college’s name and course number. HSLDA suggests counting a three- to five-credit college course as one high-school credit.⁵ The college sends its own official transcript separately. Keep the syllabus in the evidence file.

Dual enrollment is common. In one national study, about a third of students (34 percent) took a college course for credit during high school. That figure isn’t specific to homeschoolers and excludes AP and IB, but it shows registrars know what they’re looking at.⁵⁸

Community classes (art centers, museum schools, co-op studios) usually aren’t separate transcript lines. Count their hours inside a home course, and say so in the description: “Painting, including a 10-week community acrylic class.” Keep a certificate or receipt, and put one or two pieces from the class in the file with honest cards (“made in a community class; instructor demonstrated glazing on a separate tile”).

A composite: working, driving, and taking 2-D Design (illustration)

This is a composite, not a real family. A seventeen-year-old works twenty hours a week at a grocery store and takes 2-D Design at the community college one evening a week. At home she keeps a daily page and one Art Hour on Saturdays.

Her transcript for that year shows two lines. The first is **ART 110 2-D Design (Anytown Community College)**, dual enrollment, with the college transcript sent separately. The second is **Drawing — 0.5**, from about 65 logged hours of daily pages, Saturday Hours, and two museum visits. Both are honest, and together they tell a stranger exactly what a busy year of art looked like.

What your state asks (five examples)

Homeschool law is state law, and it varies. Here are five examples, read from the current texts at the time of writing. They’re a map, not legal advice.^{55,59,60}

- **New York.** The home-instruction regulation requires one unit of art and/or music across grades 9–12. A unit is 6,480 minutes, so a log of minutes is the natural record.
- **Pennsylvania.** The home-education statute lists art among the courses taught at the secondary level, and “two years of arts and humanities” among its graduation requirements. The statute doesn’t define the phrase in that list, so a family might count art alone or art alongside other humanities. Read the text and your district’s guidance.
- **Texas, North Carolina, and Virginia.** The homeschool rules for these states don’t name art as a required subject. You’re free to include it, and when you do, use a plain title like any other course.

Everywhere, laws change. Re-check your state’s current text, or your state education department’s

summary, before relying on any of this. If you live somewhere else, look up your state this week and write down what, if anything, it says about art at the high-school level.

Art-school realities

A few admissions facts matter enough to plan around, as of this writing:

- **Pratt’s homeschool-transcript rule.** Pratt asks homeschooled applicants for a transcript from a state-approved accredited homeschool association or a partnering accredited high school, *or* a GED, TASC, or HiSET, *or* 12–15 dual-enrollment credits, all in the humanities or social sciences, with a grade of at least 3.0 (out of 4.0) in each class. Studio courses don’t count toward those credits.¹⁹ That’s a real hurdle, and it takes planning. Families aiming at Pratt should read the current page by the start of junior year.
- **RISD** doesn’t accept AP or IB credit from art or studio classes.³³
- **Portfolio counts and rules** for RISD, SAIC, Pratt, and National Portfolio Day are in Chapter 8, dated.

Rules like these change. Check every school’s current pages each August, save a dated copy, and don’t assume one school’s rule applies to another.

A composite: the senior who started late (illustration)

Another composite. An eighteen-year-old in her last year of high school decides she wants art on her transcript. She has never drawn from life.

She starts with 15–16 moves: daily pages, a measured still life, a mirror self-portrait, watercolor washes. The book never calls that “behind.” She logs about 70 hours from January to June. Her transcript reads **Art I — 0.5**, with a description listing observational drawing, watercolor, and one museum visit with sketches. Her evidence file holds her first and last self-portraits side by side, and that pair says more than the grade does.

Sample transcript lines

Here are some composite examples:

- 9th: **Art I — 1.0 — A**
- 10th: **Drawing — 1.0 — A—**
- 11th: **Photography — 0.5 — B+; Art History — 0.5 — A**
- 12th: **Art Portfolio — 1.0 — A; ART 101 Drawing I (Anytown Community College) — dual enrollment — 1.0** (official college transcript sent separately)
- If audited: **AP Drawing — 1.0 — A** (AP Course Audit authorization on file)
- If not audited but the AP portfolio was submitted: **Drawing II — 1.0 — A**; AP Drawing score reported separately

A four-year path isn’t required. One honest credit of art is a full high-school art life, and many students will stop there with a habit that lasts decades.

Next steps

When the book is done, or when your student is, here's where things can go.

Keep the habit. A daily page, a long observation piece each month, a museum room now and then. Most adults who draw for life have a sketchbook, not a degree.

Find outside eyes. A community class, a co-op critique group, a sketch group, or a portfolio day. Chapter 10 has more.

Enter a show, if the student wants to. The Scholastic Art & Writing Awards are open to students in grades 7–12 who are at least 13, and homeschoolers are assigned a region by home zip code. Final work generated by AI is ineligible, students are responsible for releases from anyone depicted, and there's a portfolio category for seniors.¹¹ Many members of the U.S. House also run a yearly high-school art competition. Rules and deadlines are set office by office, so check your own representative's page for current details.⁶¹ County fairs, library shows, and co-op exhibitions make good low-stakes first entries. Enter one piece, not five, and read the rules first.

Take a college course. Dual enrollment in Drawing I or an art history survey gives a student a teacher, a studio, and college credit.

Take a studio year. Some students spend a year after high school building a portfolio: community classes, a part-time job, a sketchbook, and a sustained investigation. That's a real plan, not a delay.

Or simply keep making. Art that ends up on no transcript and in no portfolio still counts. It was always the point.

Keep the file. Store the sketchbooks, the archive, and the evidence file somewhere dry, with a backup of the photos. In a few years your student will want them, the ugly pages included.

Chapter 10 — Resources



This chapter maps what's out there: free collections, community studios, college courses, shows, published programs, materials, and a few digital tools. It isn't a ranking. The right resource is the one that fits your student, your week, and your household. Some families run four years of high-school art on a library card and this book. Others add a community class for the kiln, a dual-enrollment course, or a published program for structure. All of those are good ways to do this.

The list starts with what costs nothing, because most of what a 15- to 18-year-old needs is already free: things worth looking at closely, examples of how artists solved problems, and places to draw. Buy after you've checked those. No prices are printed here, since they change faster than books do.

This week you can do one thing from this chapter. Have your student choose one work from an open-access museum collection, download it, write its credit line, and spend ten minutes looking before reading anything about it. That's the whole resources plan for week one.

How to choose: questions of fit

Whatever you're considering (a program, a class, a book, a set of paints), four questions tell you most of what you need.

- 1. How much will it ask of you?** Some resources expect you to prepare and demonstrate. Others (video lessons, a community teacher, a college course) carry more of the teaching. Neither is better. It depends on your week and on how much your student can now run alone.
- 2. Does it have your student looking at real things?** Some programs center observation: draw the chair in front of you. Others center step-by-step demonstration: follow these strokes. Both have a place. Demonstration builds technique and confidence, and observation builds the seeing that art schools and AP reviewers look for. If a resource is all demonstration, keep the daily page and one long observation piece a month alongside it.
- 3. Where does your student actually sit?** Place by skill and independence, not by the label on the box. A publisher's age range is a starting guess. Look at a sample lesson and ask whether your student could do it today with some struggle. That's the right level.
- 4. Will the record still read plainly?** A program's name never becomes the course title. It can go in the description, if anywhere (Chapter 9).

Start free: library, museums, and open collections

The library

Most homeschooling families already use the library. In the 2022–23 national survey, parents of 53 percent of homeschooled students reported a library visit in the past month.²⁹ For a teenage artist, look for:

- **Monographs:** big books on one artist, with large reproductions. These are the best looking objects there are, and they make excellent material for Chapter 6's artist studies.
- **Survey books** on world art history, for the drawn timeline.
- **How-to books** on drawing, painting, color, photography, and design. Borrow several and keep the one that clicks.
- **Interlibrary loan,** for the book your branch doesn't have.
- **Teen programs and makerspaces.** Some libraries lend cameras or tablets, or run drawing groups. Check your library's calendar.

Museums

In the same survey, parents of 43 percent of homeschooled students reported a visit to an art gallery, museum, or historical site in the past month.²⁹ Before you go:

- **Check admission.** Many museums offer free days, free hours, or free or reduced admission for students. Rules vary and change, so check the museum's site.
- **Check sketching rules.** Many galleries allow pencil only. Some limit sketchbook size or folding stools, and photography rules vary by gallery and by loan.
- **Check teen programs.** Some museums run teen studios, drawing-in-the-galleries sessions, or longer courses, each with its own age rules.
- **Preview the galleries.** Families set their own standards for what they want to see. A quick look at the current exhibitions online saves surprises.
- **Go with one question** (Chapter 6). A two-hour visit to answer one question beats a day spent trying to see everything.

University galleries, art centers, and sculpture gardens count too. The best museum is often the one close enough to visit monthly.

Open collections online

Several major museums put high-quality images of public-domain works online for free. These are ideal for master copies, color swatches, formal analysis, and the drawn timeline. Each museum's own page gives the maker, date, medium, and credit line, so the source check is built in.

- **Art Institute of Chicago.** More than 50,000 images released under CC0, free to download and use. The museum suggests this caption format: "Artist. *Title*, Date. The Art Institute of Chicago."³⁷
- **National Gallery of Art (Washington, D.C.).** More than 60,000 images from its collection as free downloads, with collection data released under CC0. Check each image's rights line.³⁸
- **The Metropolitan Museum of Art.** More than 492,000 images of public-domain artworks, free for any use under CC0 and marked on the collection site.³⁹
- **Smarthistory.** A free art-history site with essays and videos across many periods and places.⁴⁸ It's good for getting your bearings before a museum visit, and for the student checking a claim.
- **Art21.** Free films of living artists talking about and making their work, with guides for educators.⁴⁵ This is the home of Chapter 6's watch-and-sketch pages, and a good way into contemporary art that's hard to like at first.
- **Khan Academy's AP Art History material,** linked from the College Board's AP Art History student page. It's useful for exam-bound students and for anyone who wants a structured survey.⁴⁶

A few habits make these work well:

- **Search by subject, not just by name:** "still life," "harbor," "interior," "woodblock print."
- **Zoom.** Brushwork, paper grain, and the way an edge was handled are the point.
- **Copy the credit line** onto the study and the whose-mark card.

- **Use the museum’s own page**, not a copy elsewhere. That’s where the reliable information is.

Your own town

Public sculpture, murals, old buildings, carved lettering on a bank. A town you’ve lived in for years looks different with a sketchbook in hand.

Free resources, chapter by chapter

Chapter	A free place to start
1–2 Habit and studio	Any object in the house; a pocket sketchbook; a library book on keeping a sketchbook
3 Drawing from life	A mirror, a lamp, your own hands; a park bench; a church or station interior
4 Painting	A window at different times of day; one open-access painting to swatch
5 Photography, digital, design	A phone in manual mode; posters on a library bulletin board; a real client down the street
6 History and contemporary	Open collections; Art21 films; a museum free day; a university gallery
7 Critique and statements	A co-op critique group; a portfolio day; a character counter
8–9 Portfolio and records	A phone camera, a spreadsheet, index cards, sticky tabs

Outside eyes: community classes, studios, and groups

Sooner or later your student will want something the kitchen table can’t give: a kiln, a press, a wheel, a darkroom, a clothed-model session, or simply other people making art in the same room. That’s good news. It means the habit took hold.

Community studios and art centers. This is where ceramics, printmaking, sculpture, and film photography belong. The equipment, ventilation, and firing are handled properly there, under an instructor. Before enrolling, run a short fit check:⁶²

- **Instructor:** Who teaches? Can you see their work, or sit in on a class first?
- **Age rules:** Is the class open to your student’s age? Does a parent need to stay?
- **Materials safety:** How is ventilation handled? Are solvents used, and how are rags and waste managed?
- **Figure-model policy:** For any figure class, are the models clothed? This book’s rule is clothed, consenting models only, and many open figure sessions are adults-only. Ask before booking.

- **Critique:** Does the class include a regular critique, and in what format?

If the answers are good, enroll for a term. If you're not sure, ask to observe one session first.

Homeschool co-ops. A co-op art class adds peers and critique. If you help run one, bring Chapter 7's CRP card for the table.

Sketch groups and plein-air outings. Many towns have informal groups that draw together in parks, cafés, and museums, or paint outdoors (plein air means painting on site, in the open air). They're usually friendly to serious teenagers. Check who runs the group, and at 15–16, go along the first few times. A good first move is to draw the other artists.

Portfolio days and reviews. National Portfolio Day events bring together representatives from more than 90 member art schools for short reviews, in person and online. Students bring up to 10–12 pieces, and works in progress are welcome.⁵¹ Some art centers and colleges run their own review days. Chapter 8 covers how to prepare.

Dual enrollment: a college course in high school

For a 17–18-year-old ready for more, and sometimes a mature 16-year-old, a dual-enrollment course gives a real studio, a trained teacher, college credit, and classmates who aren't family. Good first courses:

- **Drawing I:** observation, measuring, and value in a college studio.
- **2-D Design:** composition, color, and visual organization.
- **An art history survey:** a structured tour of a large span of art, often easier to get into when studio seats are full.

Questions to ask the college before enrolling:

- What's the minimum age, and what placement or permission steps are there for high-school students?
- Are studio seats open to dual-enrollment students, and when do they fill?
- What will materials cost, and what's supplied?
- For drawing courses: do any sessions use nude models? If so, is there a section or course that doesn't, or an alternative assignment? This book's rule is clothed models only.
- How will the college transcript be sent?

On the home transcript, list the course with the college's name and course number, and have the college send its own transcript (Chapter 9).

Shows and contests

A first show can be a real milestone, and it's always optional. Saying no is a complete answer.

- **Scholastic Art & Writing Awards.** Open to students in grades 7–12 who are at least 13. Homeschoolers are assigned a region by home zip code. AI may be used for brainstorm-

ing, but final AI-generated work is ineligible, and AI use must be disclosed. Students are responsible for releases from anyone shown in their work.¹¹

- **The Congressional Art Competition.** Many members of the U.S. House hold a yearly competition for high-school artists in their district. Rules, eligibility, and deadlines are set office by office, so check your own representative's current page.⁶¹
- **County fairs, library shows, and co-op exhibitions.** Low-stakes, local, and often the most fun.

For any entry, read the current rules, fill in the whose-mark card, get releases for any person shown, and enter one piece rather than five.

Published programs, described by fit

Here are some programs families commonly meet, described in their publishers' own terms and in no particular order. Nothing here is an endorsement, and editions change, so check the publisher's current description before buying.⁶³

Artistic Pursuits. The publisher offers books for older students, including high-school levels, and describes an emphasis on original work from observation. *Fits:* families who want looking and original work at the center, with moderate parent preparation. *Pairs with this book:* naturally. Use it for lessons, and this book for the Art Hour, critique, portfolio, and records.

How Great Thou Art. The publisher lists intermediate drawing programs for "Ages 12 & Up," covering topics such as shading, values, composition, perspective, and portraits. The program is explicitly Christian. *Fits:* families who want directed, step-by-step drawing within a Christian framework, with lower parent preparation. *Pairs with this book:* add the daily page from life and a monthly long observation piece so seeing gets its share.

Discovering Drawing (Davis Publications). A high-school studio drawing textbook. *Fits:* a student who wants a school-style drawing year, or a family planning a course titled Drawing. *Pairs with this book:* use the text's sequence for Make, and this book for the week's shape, critique, and records.

Atelier (Arts Attack). A video-based program that the publisher describes as eight levels for ages 4 to 16. *Fits:* a 15–16-year-old in a family that wants the video to carry more of the teaching, or a co-op that wants a shared format. *Pairs with this book:* follow the video lesson with the talk box, so the student describes before judging. (This isn't the classical "atelier" drawing tradition taught in person.)

Library how-to books. Many publishers, borrowed free. *Fits:* any budget. *Asks of you:* choosing, since you become the curator.

Fit at a glance

This isn't a ranking. Read across for the fit.

If you want...	Consider...
No cost at all	Library, museums, open collections, Art21, this book
Observation and original work, moderate prep	Artistic Pursuits, or library books plus this book
Step-by-step drawing, Christian framework, lower prep	How Great Thou Art
A school-style drawing text	<i>Discovering Drawing</i>
Video carries more of the teaching (15–16)	Atelier (Arts Attack)
Kilns, presses, wheels, darkrooms, clothed-model sessions	A community studio or art center
A college studio and college credit	Dual enrollment

Combining is fine. A published program plus a community class plus the daily page is a strong year. Whatever you combine, the course title stays plain, and every portfolio piece gets its whose-mark card.

Materials by budget

You don't need much to start, and almost nothing on this list is urgent. Buy as chapters need it, share what you can, and read every label (the Art Hour's safety rules cover how).^{13,12}

The core kit (covers most of the book)

- A sturdy sketchbook the student likes, plus a pocket one for outings
- Graphite pencils in a range (hard to soft), a kneaded eraser, and a sharpener
- Vine and compressed charcoal, with wet wipes for dust (wipe it, never blow it)
- A fine pen for contour and ink studies
- A watercolor set, a small set of gouache, and a basic acrylic set built around three primaries plus white
- A few good brushes (a round, a flat, and a larger wash brush), a water jar, and a palette
- Cold-press watercolor paper and mixed-media paper
- A drawing board, clips, and tape
- A phone camera (it counts, for photography and for the archive)

Add as the work asks

- A tablet and stylus, if digital work becomes central (Chapter 5)
- A self-healing cutting mat, a metal ruler, a craft knife, and a cut-resistant glove for the holding hand, with a parent present at 15–16
- Toned paper for gouache notes and panels or canvas boards for acrylic layers
- A portable easel or stool for plein-air work
- A clamp lamp, for consistent light on still lifes

Only at 17–18, only if chosen: solvent-free oils

A small set of oil colors, safflower oil for cleanup (the two-rag method, then soap and water), and a lidded metal can or water bucket for oily rags, emptied out of the house daily. Oil-soaked rags can catch fire on their own.^{13,12} Water-mixable oils are another option. Their makers describe them as cleaning up with water, which is a maker's claim, so read the label.^{14,42}

What to skip at home

- Turpentine, mineral spirits, and other solvents
- Spray fixatives and spray paints indoors (brush-on acrylic polymer works for fixing drawings, and any spray goes outdoors with a parent present)
- Darkroom chemistry (use a community darkroom)
- A home kiln or press (use a community studio)
- The giant 24-tube set, when three primaries plus white teach mixing faster
- Anything unlabelled, or with a label you can't read in full

When your student needs a different door

You don't need a diagnosis to adjust materials. If your student works with therapists or specialists, they're good people to ask.

- **Hand or motor challenges:** larger tools, digital drawing, photography, collage from their own photographs. The seeing and the ideas are the art.
- **Visual impairment:** high-contrast media, tactile work such as clay at a community studio, and audio description at museums. Ask your local services what's available.
- **Attention differences:** shorter Make blocks, a visible timer, one project at a time, and the daily page as the anchor.
- **Anxiety about judgment:** a private sketchbook, always. Critique others' work first, and let the student ask their question first. Outside eyes come only when the student chooses.
- **Advanced students:** outside eyes early (community classes, portfolio days, dual enrollment) and a sustained investigation from fifteen. Advanced students still gain from the daily page.
- **Late starters at 17–18:** begin with 15–16 moves. A half-credit is a real credit.

AI tools: a pointer and a dated table

The Art Hour's AI box has the full rules, and they don't change here. A generated image is never the student's mark. A model never writes the statement. Any AI use goes on the whose-mark card. At 15–16 you hold the account and your student sits beside you, and at 17–18 a parent-linked account is used only where the service's terms allow teens.

For reference, here's what each service's own terms said about age as of 28 September 2026. **Terms change often, so check the current terms before setting anything up.**

Service	Minimum age in its terms	Teens	Notes for parents
ChatGPT (OpenAI)	13	Under 18 needs a parent’s or guardian’s permission	A linked parent can remove image generation and opt the teen out of model training; check current settings ²⁵
Grok (SpaceXAI)	13	13–17 need a parent’s permission, and the parent is responsible for all use	Terms grant the company a broad license to what you submit, including a person’s image and likeness, so never upload faces ²³
Claude (Anthropic)	18	Not permitted	Adults only ²⁷
Gemini (Google)	13 to manage your own Google Account (U.S.)	Teen settings, including image features, vary	Check current Family Link and account settings ²⁶
Midjourney	13	Where a teen can’t consent to the terms, a parent or guardian agrees for them	An image generator, with no role in the student’s portfolio ⁶⁴
Adobe generative features	Account age varies; check current terms	18+ required to use “Non-Adobe Models” inside Adobe’s generative features	Generative Fill is generative, so it stays off portfolio work ²⁸

If you run your own assistant, such as a hosted bot or agent, treat it as *your* tool, not your student’s. A shared hosted workspace isn’t a privacy boundary. One hosted service’s own documentation says that all bots on an account share one cloud computer, with its files and logins, and warns against treating separate bots as a security boundary.²⁴ Keep faces, other people’s children, and identifying details out of every AI tool.

Teaching a younger sibling

If there’s a younger child in the house, one of the best resources for your teenager is that child. Once in a while, have your student lead one activity from *Art for Little Thinkers* (ages 5–10) or *Art for Young Minds* (ages 11–14). A good fit is a blind contour, a silent look at a painting, or a first value scale.

- *Time:* 30 minutes

- *The pull*: being the expert in the room, and seeing a skill you take for granted through someone else's eyes
- *The skill*: explaining simply. Demonstrate, then hand over the pencil, and resist the urge to take it back. Afterward, your student writes one line: "What did I have to explain that I'd never put into words before?"

You get a breather, the younger child gets a patient teacher, and your student learns what they actually know.

Resources for you

The parent deserves resources too. Many adults were told at some point that they "can't draw," and some still believe it. A few things help:

- **Keep a daily page yourself**, beside your student's, and don't show it off. It's one of the quietest, most powerful lessons in this book.
- **Take one evening class** at a community art center. You'll understand your student's struggles differently.
- **Take a docent tour**. Docents ask good questions for a living, and you'll borrow moves for the talk box.
- **Read the student sections** of this book. They're short, and they're the fastest review of each chapter's main idea.

Before you buy anything

Five questions:

1. Have we used the library and an open collection this month?
2. Does this resource have my student looking at real things, or only copying steps? If only steps, what will we add?
3. Does it fit where my student actually is, and how much of my week will it take?
4. Have we read the label, and does it fit the house safety rules?
5. Will the course title still read plainly, with every piece signed honestly?

If the answers are yes, yes, a good fit, yes, and yes, buy with confidence. If not, the library opens tomorrow morning.

A Note on Sources

Studies, standards, admissions pages, and product terms named in the chapters are listed in Notes, in one series at the back, so the teaching pages can keep a teaching voice. When the same source comes up in several chapters, it has one note, and every mark that cites it carries that note's number.

Some questions stay open, and the book leaves them open rather than filling them. The Chamberlain study of art students is cited from the authors' eprint; its journal and year weren't confirmed. No maker's page for water-mixable oils was checked, so that paragraph follows the label, not a source. No published standard sets age rules for figure studios, and the book's clothed-model rule is its own. The dose suggestions, tool rules, the three-step habit scale, and the letter-grade conversion are practice suggestions, not findings. Several studies (Cohen and Bennett's, the *Studio Thinking* research, and the Bastani mathematics trial) come from adults, arts high schools, or another subject, and are used for what they show about the method, not as findings about fifteen- to eighteen-year-olds in art.

College Board materials, admissions pages, contest rules, and platform terms change every season; the dates in each note say when they were read. Most were re-read on 28 September 2026. A few pages could not be re-read that day by automated reading: the Art Institute of Chicago's open-access page, Smarthistory, Adobe's generative-AI terms, and Google's age table. Those notes say so and give the earlier reading or a secondary source. The Congressional Art Competition's eligibility details come from search results rather than a rules page, and Pennsylvania's statute was read from a copy saved that morning. Access date for web sources: 28 September 2026. Nothing here is legal advice; state rules are summarized from the texts named in Chapter 9's notes, and families should read the current page before relying on any figure.

Notes

1. National Center for Education Statistics, *Homeschooling in the United States: Results from the 2012 and 2016 Parent and Family Involvement Survey (PFI-NHES: 2012 and 2016)*, Web Tables (NCES 2020-001; December 2019), Table 9, <https://nces.ed.gov/pubsearch/pubsinfo.asp?pubid=2020001>. Share of homeschooled students taught art during home instruction in 2016: 53 percent overall; 78 percent in kindergarten–2nd grade; 63 percent in grades 3–5; 50 percent in grades 6–8; 29 percent in grades 9–12. A 2016 survey; the table gives no reasons, and the figures are not projected to today. PDF on disk re-read 28 September 2026.
2. Ellen Winner, Thalia R. Goldstein, and Stéphan Vincent-Lancrin, *Art for Art's Sake? The Impact of Arts Education* (Paris: OECD Publishing, 2013), <https://doi.org/10.1787/9789264180789-en> (accessed 28 September 2026). The report found “no evidence that training in visual arts improves overall academic skills or verbal skills (literacy),” and noted that “one experimental study found that learning to look closely at works of visual art improves skills in observing scientific images — a typical instance of close skills transfer.” It presents wider effects of the studio habits as transfer hypotheses, not findings. PDF on disk.
3. Ellen Winner and Lois Hetland, eds., “The Arts and Academic Improvement: What the Evidence Shows” (Reviewing Education and the Arts Project, Harvard Project Zero), *Journal of Aesthetic Education* 34, nos. 3/4 (2000): a review of 188 reports, 275 effect sizes, and 10 meta-analyses found no demonstrated causal link from arts study to verbal or mathematics achievement. Executive summary: <https://pz.harvard.edu/sites/default/files/REAP%20Executive%20Summary.pdf> (accessed 28 September 2026).
4. Carnegie Foundation for the Advancement of Teaching, “What Is the Carnegie Unit?”, <https://www.carnegiefoundation.org/faq/what-is-the-carnegie-unit/> (accessed 28 September 2026): introduced in 1906; a high-school unit “typically represents 120 hours of study, with classes meeting four to five times a week for 40 to 60 minutes over a school year.” The Foundation now also promotes competency-based alternatives. The worked year in “Dose honesty” is this book’s arithmetic, not a rule.
5. HSLDA, “3 Ways to Determine My Teen’s High School Course Credit” (15 January 2020), <https://www.hslda.org/post/3-ways-to-determine-my-teens-high-school-course-credit> (re-read live 28 September 2026): for an elective such as art, “log 120+ hours for 1.0 credit and 60+ hours for 0.5 credit”; core courses 150 hours; lab science 180; a 3–5-credit college course = 1.0 high-school credit; honors and AP courses take more work, not more credit; parents determine credit, and some states use different scales. An advocacy organization’s guidance, not law.

6. Lois Hetland, Ellen Winner, Shirley Veenema, and Kimberly M. Sheridan, *Studio Thinking 2: The Real Benefits of Visual Arts Education* (New York: Teachers College Press, 2013), as summarized in the OECD report *Art for Art's Sake?* (2013), Box 4.1. The researchers observed, videotaped, and coded 38 visual-arts classes at the Walnut Hill School for the Arts and the Boston Arts Academy, and interviewed the teachers. They describe eight studio habits of mind (Develop Craft, Engage and Persist, Envision, Express, Observe, Reflect, Stretch and Explore, Understand Art Worlds) and three recurring studio structures (demonstration-lecture, students-at-work, critique). Described teaching goals, not measured outcomes; used here as vocabulary and as a picture of good teaching, not as evidence of transfer. The plain-language habit lines in this book are its own. Framework page: <https://www.studiothinking.org/the-framework.html> (accessed 28 September 2026).
7. Visual Thinking Strategies (VTS), developed by Abigail Housen and Philip Yenawine, <https://vtshome.org/> (accessed 28 September 2026). The three questions (“What’s going on in this picture? What do you see that makes you say that? What more can we find?”) and the practice of paraphrasing each comment without praising or correcting. This book uses “we” in the third question for a group at the table; some VTS family materials use “What more can you find?” VTS began in museum and classroom programs.
8. Liz Lerman, Critical Response Process (devised 1990), <https://lizlerman.com/critical-response-process/> (accessed 28 September 2026). Four steps: Statements of Meaning; Artist as Questioner; Neutral Questions; Permissioned Opinions, in which the responder asks permission to give an opinion and the artist may decline.
9. Leah H. Somerville, “Special Issue on the Teenage Brain: Sensitivity to Social Evaluation,” *Current Directions in Psychological Science* 22, no. 2 (2013), <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC3992953/> (accessed 28 September 2026). A review describing heightened adolescent sensitivity to peer and social evaluation. A tendency, not a diagnosis, and not a study of art, sketchbooks, critique, or social media; used here as the reason the sketchbook is private by default and critique is permissioned and student-chaired.
10. Figure-drawing and open-studio age rules differ by venue. Many community studios limit sessions with nude models to adults, and some run youth sessions with clothed models, but policies vary and change, and no single published standard was found (checked 28 September 2026). This book’s rule doesn’t depend on any venue: clothed, consenting models only; the parent checks the venue’s age rules and model policy before booking; students 17–18 attend only sessions the parent has checked.
11. Scholastic Art & Writing Awards (Alliance for Young Artists & Writers), “Frequently Asked Questions,” <https://www.artandwriting.org/frequently-asked-questions/> (re-read live 28 September 2026). Open to teens in grades 7–12, age 13 and up, in the U.S., its territories and military bases, and Canada (excluding Quebec); homeschooled and virtual-school students are assigned a region by home zip code. AI policy (as of 1 July 2025): AI may aid the process, such as brainstorming or outlining, but any entry “for which the final product is itself AI-generated” is ineligible, and entrants indicate whether and how AI was used. Students, not the Alliance, are responsible for any consents or releases from people depicted. The Portfolio category (six works) is for grade 12 only, with Gold Medal Portfolio scholarships; fee waivers exist. Fees are not printed here; policies change each season.

12. Art & Creative Materials Institute (ACMI), “Classroom Art Materials Safety,” <https://www.acmiart.org/classroom-art-materials-safety>, and “Materials Safety,” <https://www.acmiart.org/materials-safety> (both accessed 28 September 2026). The AP Seal is for students in sixth grade or younger; CL Seal products are for seventh grade or older, and users “must read the product label in full before opening.” Both seals are applied under ASTM D-4236 and the Labeling of Hazardous Art Materials Act (LHAMA).

13. U.S. Consumer Product Safety Commission, *Art and Craft Safety Guide* (Pub. 5015), <https://www.cpsc.gov/s3fs-public/5015.pdf> (PDF on disk, read 28 September 2026). ASTM D-4236, made mandatory by LHAMA, is a procedure for labelling chronic hazards, not a non-toxic rating; the guide advises reading labels and choosing the safest materials available. Ventilation: “Adequate ventilation means that clean air is flowing toward the artist and contaminated air is flowing away. Blowing air around with a fan without a source of clean air is not adequate ventilation, and can actually increase exposures to harmful substances.” “Never eat, drink, or smoke in studios”; wash hands after working. “Use metal-mesh or Kevlar gloves when using sharp tools or knives.” “Linseed oil or solvent-soaked rags can spontaneously combust, so rags should be stored in a covered container that does not allow air in or vapors out.” Aerosol sprays: “If possible, use outdoors or with a spray booth or a fume hood and a National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (NIOSH)-approved respirator with an organic vapor cartridge”; “Use clear acrylic polymer emulsion to fix drawings.” Painting: “Use premixed paints to avoid inhalation of dry pigments/dyes/powders”; some water-based acrylics “contain small amounts of ammonia (as a stabilizer) and formaldehyde (as a preservative), which may cause respiratory irritation.” Solvents and skin: “Avoid using toluene, turpentine, kerosene, or other solvents to clean your skin”; for oil paints, remove paint from hands “with vegetable/baby oil or non-toxic artist’s soaps and detergent cleaners rather than with solvents,” and “Avoid turpentine and mineral spirits.” Photographic materials: developers may be highly alkaline and concentrated acetic acid (stop bath) highly toxic; wear gloves and goggles; darkroom ventilation should exhaust contaminated air “at the rate of at least 10 room volume changes per hour.” Indoor kilns require mechanical ventilation to the outdoors. Computers: “Take short breaks often (every 10 minutes)”; this book frames that older, general guidance as short, frequent breaks, not medical advice. Poison Control: 1-800-222-1222. The guide sets no age for craft knives. This book’s rules (a parent present for blades at 15–16; no solvents, indoor sprays, darkrooms, or kilns at home; brush-on fixative first; solvent-free oils only at 17–18) are its own practice rules, stricter than the guide; not pointing brushes with the lips is also a house rule.

14. Gamblin Artists Colors, “Solvent-Free Oil Painting,” <https://gamblincolors.com/studio-safety/solvent-free-painting/> (accessed 28 September 2026). The paint maker’s own guidance, not an independent safety standard: the “two rag” method (wipe the brush, clean it with safflower oil, wipe on a second rag), then soap and water after the session; mineral oil or cooking oil not used during painting because they are non-drying; solvent-free mediums “best suited for direct, or ‘alla prima,’ painting styles”; oil-soaked rags stored at minimum in an oily-rag safety can, or better, soaked in water in a jar and put in the outdoor trash. The maker also suggests a small amount of its own solvent for thin underpainting; this book leaves that out. The maker describes its drying oils as non-toxic; the book doesn’t repeat that as a claim and treats every tube by its label. Whether to use oils at all is the family’s choice; this book offers them only at 17–18 and only solvent-free.

15. U.S. Copyright Office, *Copyright and Artificial Intelligence, Part 2: Copyrightability* (29 January 2025), announced in NewsNet Issue 1060, <https://copyright.gov/newsnet/2025/1060.html> (accessed 28 September 2026): outputs are protectable “only where a human author has determined sufficient expressive elements,” and not through “the mere provision of prompts.” Cited as an echo of the book’s teaching reason, not as legal advice.

16. College Board, *AP Art and Design Plagiarism and Artificial Intelligence Policy Guide* (2026; PDF created 12 August 2026; “updated guidance for the 2026–2027 AP Art and Design portfolio”), on disk, and AP Central, “Guidance for Artificial Intelligence Tools and Other Services — AP Art and Design Policy,” <https://apcentral.collegeboard.org/exam-administration-ordering-scores/administering-exams/exam-policies/artificial-intelligence-tools> (re-read live 28 September 2026). Finished pieces must be the student’s own work. Students “can use generative AI tools only during research, ideation, practice, experimentation, and revision”; “Using generative AI tools to create final submitted artwork is prohibited,” including generative features inside editing software (object creation, generative fill or expand, background replacement). Non-generative edits (exposure, contrast, color correction, cropping, minor cleanup) are allowed at all stages. “Students must disclose any AI use (generative or non-generative)” in the AP Digital Portfolio; AI-generated content is preexisting source material that must be cited, identified as not student-created, and transformed, and failure to disclose may be treated as a policy violation. The guide notes that “Prior published materials may reflect earlier restrictions on AI use.” This book’s rule is stricter.

17. College Board, *AP Art and Design Course and Exam Description*, Effective Fall 2026 (covers AP 2-D Art and Design, AP 3-D Art and Design, and AP Drawing), <https://apcentral.collegeboard.org/courses/ap-2-d-art-and-design> (PDF on disk, read 28 September 2026). Instructional goals include “the ability to (1) conduct a sustained investigation through practice, experimentation, and revision, guided by questions.” Portfolio structure: Selected Works, 40 percent of the total score (five works; for 3-D Art and Design, ten images, two views each of five works); Sustained Investigation, 60 percent (fifteen digital images, including process, plus written responses). Typed fields, character limits including spaces: for each Selected Works piece, Idea(s) visually evident (250), Materials used (150), Processes used (250), Image Citation (200), Digital Tools (200); for the Sustained Investigation, two written responses of up to 850 characters each (the guiding inquiry; how the investigation developed through practice, experimentation, and revision), and for each image Materials (150), Processes (350), Digital Tools (200), Image Citation (200), and size. Responses “are not evaluated for correct spelling, grammar, or punctuation.” Sustained Investigation scoring weights (p. 33): formulate and identify, in writing, questions or areas of inquiry, 20 percent; written and visual evidence of practice, experimentation, and revision, 30 percent; works that demonstrate synthesis of materials, processes, and ideas, 30 percent; works that demonstrate 2-D, 3-D, or drawing skills, 20 percent. Scoring guidance: “Automated imagery is not evidence of skill”; the glossary defines automated imagery as “Visual content produced primarily by software or tool-based features with minimal user-directed manipulation, such as filters, generative AI, or one-step effects”; and “Process documentation alone does not establish authorship of the images.” The 850-character limits and the 20/30/30/20 weights were checked against this PDF for the final pass. For the 2026–27 portfolio year; check the current description each year.

18. College Board, AP Digital Portfolio Terms and Conditions (January 2026), PDF on disk: “AP Art & Design: The use of generative AI tools and features is categorically prohibited at any stage

of the creative process.” This conflicts with the 2026–27 policy guide, which says earlier materials may reflect older restrictions. The book’s house rule (no generated imagery anywhere in a portfolio or its process images; no model-written text) satisfies both documents for the work itself; families on the AP route should follow what their AP coordinator confirms.

19. Pratt Institute, “Undergraduate Application Requirements: High School Applicants” (Fall 2027 cycle), <https://www.pratt.edu/resources/undergraduate-application-requirements-high-school-applicants/> (re-read live 28 September 2026). General visual portfolio: “10 to 20 Artworks,” final and fully resolved, made within the last 18 months, each documented with media, dimensions, and year; “3-to-5 examples of original work done from the direct observation” of three-dimensional subjects. Images “fully rendered by generative AI are prohibited”; AI image-enhancement is permitted if the work remains original, with disclosure of all AI tools and all text prompts; AI text generation is not permitted in the essay or any written portfolio component, including descriptions. Homeschooled applicants: a transcript issued by a state-approved homeschool association or partnering high school accredited by the Department of Education, or GED, TASC, or HiSET results; a university transcript may substitute for a GED if the student took 12 to 15 dual-enrollment credits at a regionally accredited institution, all in the humanities and social sciences, with a grade no lower than 3.0 (of 4.0) in each class; “Studio-based classes will not be considered.” An earlier research note mentioned a Pratt page giving 10–15 works; no such page could be found on re-check, and the high-school page’s 10 to 20 is used here.

20. Hamsa Bastani et al., “Generative AI Without Guardrails Can Harm Learning: Evidence from High School Mathematics,” *PNAS* (2025), <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2422633122> (author PDF read 28 September 2026). High-school mathematics in Turkey: access to a basic GPT-4 interface raised practice performance, but lowered later unassisted exam performance by 17 percent. The authors note that objective evaluation criteria are unavailable in creative subjects. Off-subject for art; cited once, as a caution.

21. William H. Walters and Esther Isabelle Wilder, “Fabrication and Errors in the Bibliographic Citations Generated by ChatGPT,” *Scientific Reports* 13 (2023): 14045, <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-023-41032-5> (accessed 28 September 2026). Cited for the point that chatbots can invent sources, so every claim gets checked against a museum page or a book.

22. Weixin Liang et al., “GPT Detectors Are Biased Against Non-Native English Writers” (2023), arXiv:2304.02819, <https://arxiv.org/abs/2304.02819> (accessed 28 September 2026). Text detectors frequently misclassified human writing by non-native English speakers as machine-written. A study of writing detectors, cited for the general point that detectors are not a fair basis for grading; no reliable detector for images is assumed in this book.

23. SpaceXAI, Terms of Service – Consumer (last updated 11 September 2026), <https://x.ai/legal/terms-of-service> (re-read live 28 September 2026): users must be at least 13; teens 13–17 need a parent’s or legal guardian’s permission, and the parent agrees to the terms and is “responsible for all use of the Service”; users grant SpaceXAI an “irrevocable, perpetual, transferable, sublicensable, royalty-free, and worldwide right” to use submitted inputs, and “To the extent the User Content includes a person’s image, likeness, voice, or other similar attributes,” the same rights to those attributes. Other services’ terms differ; read before uploading anything.

24. SpaceXAI docs, “Grok Bot FAQ,” <https://docs.x.ai/grok-bot/faq> (re-read live 28 September

2026): “Every Bot on your account uses one persistent cloud computer. They share its files, browser sessions, and logins”; “Do not use separate Bots as a security boundary.” The company’s own documentation for a hosted agent; not an education product.

25. OpenAI, Terms of Use (effective 1 January 2026), <https://openai.com/policies/terms-of-use/> (re-read live 28 September 2026): “You must be at least 13 years old”; users under 18 “must have your parent or legal guardian’s permission.” OpenAI, “Introducing parental controls” (29 September 2025), <https://openai.com/index/introducing-parental-controls/> (re-read live 28 September 2026): a linked parent can “Remove image generation” and “Opt out of model training” for a teen’s account, among other settings. Terms change; check the current versions.

26. Google For Families Help, “Guide your child’s Gemini Apps experience,” <https://support.google.com/families/> (re-read live 28 September 2026): a parent can give a child under 13 (or the applicable age) access to Gemini Apps through Family Link. Google Account Help, “Age requirements on Google Accounts,” <https://support.google.com/accounts/answer/1350409>: 13 is the minimum age to manage your own Google Account in the U.S. (the country table did not render for automated reading on 28 September 2026; figure as read for *Art for Young Minds* on 27 September 2026). Teen image-generation limits were seen only in search results and are not stated as fact here.

27. Anthropic, Claude Help Center, “Age assurance on Claude” (18 May 2026), <https://support.claude.com/en/articles/age-assurance-on-claude> (re-read live 28 September 2026): “Claude, our consumer product, is only available to people over 18 years.”

28. Adobe, Generative AI Product Specific Terms (effective 23 April 2026), § 7.2, <https://www.adobe.com/cc-shared/assets/pdf/legal/servicetou/adobe-generative-ai-product-specific-terms-en-us-20260423.pdf>: users must be 18 or older to use Non-Adobe Models within Adobe’s generative features (read by the research stream on 28 September 2026; the PDF timed out on the final re-check). The general Adobe account age was seen only in a secondary source and is not stated here. Check the current terms.

29. Ellena Sempeles and Jiashan Cui, *Parent and Family Involvement in Education: 2023, First Look* (NCES 2024-113; National Center for Education Statistics, September 2024), <https://nces.ed.gov/pubsearch/pubsinfo.asp?pubid=2024113>. Table A-6: among students ages 5–17 in kindergarten through grade 12 or equivalent, 3.4 percent were homeschooled in 2022–23 (about 1,765,000 students), and 3.1 percent in grades 9–12. The larger 5.2 percent figure in the same table is “instruction at home” (homeschooled or enrolled full-time in virtual school) and is not the homeschool share. Table A-5: among homeschooled students (all grades), parents reported in the past month “Visited a library,” 53 percent, and “Visited an art gallery, a museum, or a historical site,” 43 percent; these are all-grade homeschool figures, not a high-school row. PDF on disk re-read 28 September 2026.

30. Viktor Lowenfeld, *Creative and Mental Growth* (New York: Macmillan, 1947; later editions with W. Lambert Brittain), which names a “Period of Decision” for the high-school years. Stage names and ages vary across editions; used here as a map, not a scientific stage. <https://archive.org/details/creativementalgr00> (accessed 28 September 2026).

31. Jeffrey Jensen Arnett, “Emerging Adulthood: A Theory of Development from the Late Teens Through the Twenties,” *American Psychologist* 55, no. 5 (2000): 469–480,

<https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.5.469>. Arnett uses the term for roughly ages 18–25. This book uses “Emerging Adults” only as a series name for ages 15–18 and does not cite Arnett as describing that age.

32. Dale J. Cohen and Susan Bennett, “Why Can’t Most People Draw What They See?” *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance* 23, no. 3 (1997). Adult participants; misperception of the object was the main source of drawing error. An adult study, used here as a map of how drawing goes wrong, not as a study of teenagers. Author PDF: <https://people.uncw.edu/cohend/research/papers/Cohen%20and%20Bennett%2097.pdf> (accessed 28 September 2026).

33. Rhode Island School of Design, “Apply to RISD” (first-year admissions), <https://www.risd.edu/admissions/first-year/apply-risd> (re-read live 28 September 2026): the portfolio “should present 12–20 examples of your most recent work”; RISD “strongly recommend[s]” including examples of drawing or painting from direct observation; research or preparatory work in “up to three— but no more than three —portfolio uploads/slides”; any work supported or created by AI must include a description of process and tools; RISD “will not accept AP or IB credit from art or studio classes.” (The first-year landing page, <https://www.risd.edu/admissions/first-year>, now carries deadlines only.) Admissions pages change each season.

34. School of the Art Institute of Chicago, “Undergraduate Portfolio Requirements by Degree,” <https://www.saic.edu/admissions/undergraduate/portfolio-requirements> (re-read live 28 September 2026): BFA applicants “Submit 10–15 pieces of your best and most recent work”; SAIC “discourages work that is copied or rendered directly from photographs, magazines, or other artists’ works”; collaborators’ names and roles are listed. No AI statement was located on the page.

35. Try-its in this chapter draw on the book’s activity banks: the daily page (SKB-01); blind contour, grown up (OBS-01); the student-led look (CRIT-01, VTS student-led); the baseline (AS-01, monthly progress check, used here as an ungraded starting point); teaching a younger sibling (OUT-05); and the museum visit with one question (a preview of HIST-02, taught in Chapter 6). Codes let later chapters point back.

36. Try-its in this chapter draw on the book’s sketchbook and safety banks: the daily page (SKB-01), nine thumbnails (SKB-02), the ugly-page license (SKB-03), the question log (SKB-04), the labelled copy (SKB-05), the monthly page review (SKB-06), the visual journal spread (SKB-07); read the label (SAFE-01), ventilation and the no-food studio (SAFE-02), blades and cutting (SAFE-03), solvent-free and oily rags (SAFE-04), and sprays outdoors (SAFE-05).

37. Art Institute of Chicago, “Open Access Images,” <https://www.artic.edu/open-access/open-access-images> (accessed 28 September 2026; the site refused automated re-reading later that day): more than 50,000 public-domain images released under Creative Commons Zero (CC0), with the suggested caption form “Artist. Title, Date. The Art Institute of Chicago.” Check each image’s rights line before use.

38. National Gallery of Art, “Free Images and Open Access,” <https://www.nga.gov/artworks/free-images-and-open-access> (re-read live 28 September 2026): “more than 60,000 images from our collection available as free downloads”; a dataset for the 130,000+ artworks and artists in the collection is released under CC0. Check each image’s rights line and record the credit line on the

study.

39. The Metropolitan Museum of Art, “Open Access at The Met,” <https://www.metmuseum.org/hubs/open-access> (re-read live 28 September 2026): “over 492,000 images of public-domain artworks” and basic data on all accessioned works available under Creative Commons Zero (CC0), under an Open Access Initiative begun in February 2017. Dataset: <https://github.com/metmuseum/openaccess>.

40. Rebecca Chamberlain, Jennifer E. Drake, Aaron Kozbelt, Rebecca Hickman, Joseph Siev and Johan Wagemans, “Artists as Experts in Visual Cognition: An Update,” author eprint, Goldsmiths Research Online, <https://research.gold.ac.uk/id/eprint/22050/>. Art students (42 first-years at Pratt, before formal training) outperformed non-art students (37) on drawing and on some, not all, visual-spatial tasks, a pattern consistent with top-down attention. Cross-sectional design, so selection isn’t ruled out. The journal and year weren’t confirmed from the eprint (likely *Psychology of Aesthetics, Creativity, and the Arts*, 2019); cited here as the eprint. Accessed 28 September 2026.

41. The try-its and practice in this chapter draw on the house teaching bank: observational drawing OBS-01 to OBS-07 and figure and portrait FIG-01 to FIG-06, with the observation set (PORT-05, Chapter 8) and people-and-privacy practice (SAFE-07, Chapter 5). Bank codes appear here rather than in the body so the teaching pages stay readable.

42. Water-mixable oils are described by their makers as thinned and cleaned with water. That is the makers’ description; no maker’s page for water-mixable oils was verified for this book, and no independent source was consulted. Follow the label on the tubes you buy, and keep the rag rule, since rags still carry drying oil.

43. The try-its and practice in this chapter draw on the house teaching bank: painting PNT-01 to PNT-08 and color COL-01 to COL-03, with solvent-free and oily-rag practice (SAFE-04) and sprays outdoors (SAFE-05) from Chapter 2. The series of five (PNT-08) and alla prima (PNT-06) are 17–18 moves; the solvent-free oil starter (PNT-07) is optional at 17–18.

44. The try-its and practice in this chapter draw on the house teaching bank: digital art DIG-01 to DIG-06, photography PHO-01 to PHO-06, design DES-01 to DES-05, color COL-04 (color with a job) and COL-05 (screen versus print), and screens and people-and-privacy safety SAFE-06 and SAFE-07. The generated-image comparison (DIG-06) is a 17–18 activity with a parent present, and its image is never filed.

45. Art21, “Art21 for Educators,” <https://art21.org/for-educators/> (accessed 28 September 2026): free films of contemporary artists and educators’ guides.

46. College Board, AP Students, “AP Art History,” <https://apstudents.collegeboard.org/courses/ap-art-history> (re-read live 28 September 2026): ten units from Global Prehistory to Global Contemporary, each weighted at approximately 4–21 percent of the multiple-choice score; college equivalent “A two-semester college introductory art history course”; recommended prerequisites, none; exam “Wed, May 12, 2027.” The page links to Khan Academy AP Art History material; the link was confirmed, and the Khan Academy content itself was not reviewed for this book. The required-works list wasn’t confirmed from the current Course and Exam Description, so no count is given. Exam dates and course details change yearly.

47. The try-its and practice in this chapter draw on the house teaching bank: art history HIST-01 to

HIST-06 and contemporary art CONT-01 to CONT-05. AP Art History prompt practice (HIST-06) is for exam-bound students at 17–18 only; the artist conversation (CONT-04) and response piece (CONT-05) are 17–18 moves. The written describe–analyze–interpret–judge method belongs to Chapter 7.

48. Smarthistory, <https://smarthistory.org/>. A free online art-history resource of essays and videos, founded by the art historians Beth Harris and Steven Zucker. The site blocked automated reading on 28 September 2026 (security check), so its own description could not be re-read; the founders and its free status are as summarized in the Wikipedia article “Smarthistory” (read 28 September 2026), a secondary source. Check the current site.

49. Edmund Burke Feldman’s four-step approach to art criticism (description, analysis, interpretation, judgment), set out in his textbooks, including *Varieties of Visual Experience*, and widely summarized in teaching materials, for example <https://www2.gvsu.edu/hipshean/resources/Feldman's%20Model%20> (accessed 28 September 2026). No particular edition or year is cited; the edition was not confirmed.

50. Try-its in this chapter draw on the house teaching bank: CRIT-01 VTS, student-led; CRIT-02 Critical Response Process at home; CRIT-03 Describe–analyze–interpret–judge; CRIT-04 Monthly wall critique; CRIT-05 Notes, not arguments; CRIT-06 Outside eyes; WRITE-01 The 100-word statement; WRITE-02 Captions to the limit; WRITE-03 Artist statement, drafted and revised; WRITE-04 The investigation question; WRITE-05 Citing sources. The ten-minute parent warm-up and the composite examples are illustrations, not reported families.

51. National Portfolio Day Association, “FAQs,” <https://nationalportfolioday.org/faqs> (re-read live 28 September 2026): “over 90 member schools”; “Most reviews are 10 to 15 minutes”; bring “up to 10-12 pieces”; works in progress welcome; in-person and virtual events. Event formats and dates change.

52. College Board, AP Central, “Supporting Exam Only Students” (AP Art and Design submission guide for AP coordinators), <https://apcentral.collegeboard.org/series/art-and-design-submission-guide-ap-coordinators/supporting-exam-only-students> (re-read live 28 September 2026): coordinators support students in exam-only sections (“e.g., homeschooled and independent study students”), can review submitted work, and may report a policy violation; key date “Fri, May 7, 2027, 11:59 PM ET — Deadline: Students Submit AP Art and Design Portfolios.” Dated to 2026–27.

53. Jacob Mishook, “The Homeschoolers’ Guide to College Board Assessments,” College Board All Access (29 June 2026), <https://allaccess.collegeboard.org/homeschoolers-guide-college-board-assessments> (accessed 28 September 2026): homeschoolers arrange AP exams through a local authorized school found via the AP Course Ledger; exam orders are due in mid-November; fee reductions may be available. No fees are printed in this book because they change.

54. Try-its in this chapter draw on the house teaching bank: PORT-01 The archive; PORT-02 Pull the best 20; PORT-03 Edit and sequence; PORT-04 Sustained investigation plan; PORT-05 The observation set; PORT-06 Requirements check, dated; PORT-07 Portfolio review prep; AS-01 Monthly progress check; AS-02 The whose-mark card (grown); AS-03 Before/after pair; AS-04 Self-score against a published rubric; AS-05 Semester review and grade; AS-06 Credit evidence file. The three-step habit scale, the semester standard, and the letter conversion are house practice,

not validated instruments. Composite examples are illustrations, not reported families.

55. New York Codes, Rules and Regulations, title 8, § 100.10 (Home instruction), <https://www.law.cornell.edu/regnyork/8-NYCRR-100.10> (re-read live 28 September 2026). Subdivision (e)(1): “a unit means 6,480 minutes of instruction per school year.” For grades 9 through 12, required instruction includes “art and/or music (one unit)”; “The units required herein are cumulative requirements for grades 9 through 12.” Not legal advice; read the current regulation.

56. Texas Education Agency, 19 Tex. Admin. Code ch. 117, subch. C, §§ 117.302–117.303 (Level I: “Art I, Art Appreciation, and Art and Media Communications I”; Level II includes Art II, Drawing I, Painting I, Printmaking I, Ceramics I, Sculpture I, Photography I, and Digital Art and Media I), <https://tea.texas.gov/about-tea/laws-and-rules/texas-administrative-code/19-tac-chapter-117>; School Courses for the Exchange of Data (SCED) visual-arts codes, via the Vermont course-code set and NCES SCED Finder (e.g., 05151 Art Appreciation, 05152 Art History, 05156 Drawing, 05157 Painting, 05167 Photography, 05170 Art Portfolio; codes 05172/05174/05175 still use the outdated “AP Studio Art” names), <https://nces.ed.gov/scedfinder>. Both accessed 28 September 2026. Texas public-school rules; homeschools are not bound, and the names are used here as vocabulary only.

57. College Board, AP Central, “AP Course Audit for Homeschool Providers of AP Courses”: “All homeschool providers who wish to label their courses AP... must participate in the AP Course Audit”; steps include documentation of homeschool status (a signed letter of intent is acceptable), the subject-specific audit form, and an adopted or original syllabus. <https://apcentral.collegeboard.org/courses/ap-course-audit/explore-by-role/homeschool-providers-ap-courses> (accessed 28 September 2026).

58. National Center for Education Statistics, *Dual Enrollment: Participation and Characteristics* (NCES 2019-176): 34 percent of students in the High School Longitudinal Study of 2009 cohort took courses for postsecondary credit while in high school. The figure excludes AP and IB and is not specific to homeschooled students. <https://nces.ed.gov/pubs2019/2019176.pdf> (accessed 28 September 2026).

59. Pennsylvania, 24 P.S. § 13-1327.1 (Home education program), <https://www.legis.state.pa.us/cfdocs/legis/LI/co> Subsection (c)(2): at the secondary level the courses that “shall be taught” include “art; music.” Subsection (d): graduation requirements in grades nine through twelve include “(5) Two years of arts and humanities”; the phrase is not defined in that list. Text read 28 September 2026 from a copy saved that morning (the live page did not render for automated reading on re-check). Not legal advice.

60. Texas Education Agency, “Home Schooling,” <https://tea.texas.gov/families-and-students/finding-school-your-child/home-schooling>; North Carolina Division of Non-Public Education, “Home School Requirements & Recommendations,” <https://www.doa.nc.gov/divisions/non-public-education/home-schools/requirements-recommendations>; Va. Code § 22.1-254.1, <https://law.lis.virginia.gov/vacode/title22.1/chapter14/section22.1-254.1/>. None of the three texts, as saved and read on 28 September 2026, names art as a required subject for homeschoolers. Not legal advice; re-check current texts.

61. U.S. House of Representatives, “Congressional Art Competition,” <https://www.house.gov/educators->

and-students/congressional-art-competition (re-read live 28 September 2026): a nationwide high-school visual art competition held each spring; students submit entries to their representative's office, and panels of district artists choose the winners. That homeschoolers in grades 9–12 are eligible, and that each office sets its own rules and deadlines, comes from search results rather than a primary rules page; check your representative's current page.

62. The fit checklist draws on OUT-01 Community studio class in the house teaching bank; other items in this chapter draw on OUT-02 Dual-enrollment art course, OUT-03 Shows and contests, OUT-04 Sketch group or plein air outing, and OUT-05 Teach a younger sibling. Figure-studio age rules vary by venue; no single primary source sets them.

63. Publishers' own descriptions, not independent reviews; prices omitted. Artistic Pursuits, <https://artisticpursuits.com/> (high-school levels and an emphasis on original work from observation, per the publisher, carried from the sibling titles' reading). How Great Thou Art Publications, <https://www.howgreatthouart.com/> ("Ages 12 & Up" intermediate drawing; topic list from the publisher's homepage; explicitly Christian), read for the sibling title 27 September 2026. Sallye Mahan-Cox, *Discovering Drawing*, 3rd ed. (Davis Publications), <https://catalog.davisart.com/Products/668-3/discovering-drawing-student-book-3rd-ed.aspx> (catalog listing as a high-school studio drawing textbook). Atelier / Arts Attack, <https://homeschoolart.com/curriculum> (video-based; eight levels; ages 4–16, per the publisher, read for a sibling title 31 August 2026). Check current editions and descriptions.

64. Midjourney, Terms of Service (version effective 27 May 2026), § 2, "Age Requirements," <https://docs.midjourney.com/hc/en-us/articles/32083055291277-Terms-of-Service> (re-read live 28 September 2026): users must be at least 13 and meet the local minimum age of digital consent; where a user can't consent to the terms, a parent or guardian agrees on their behalf.